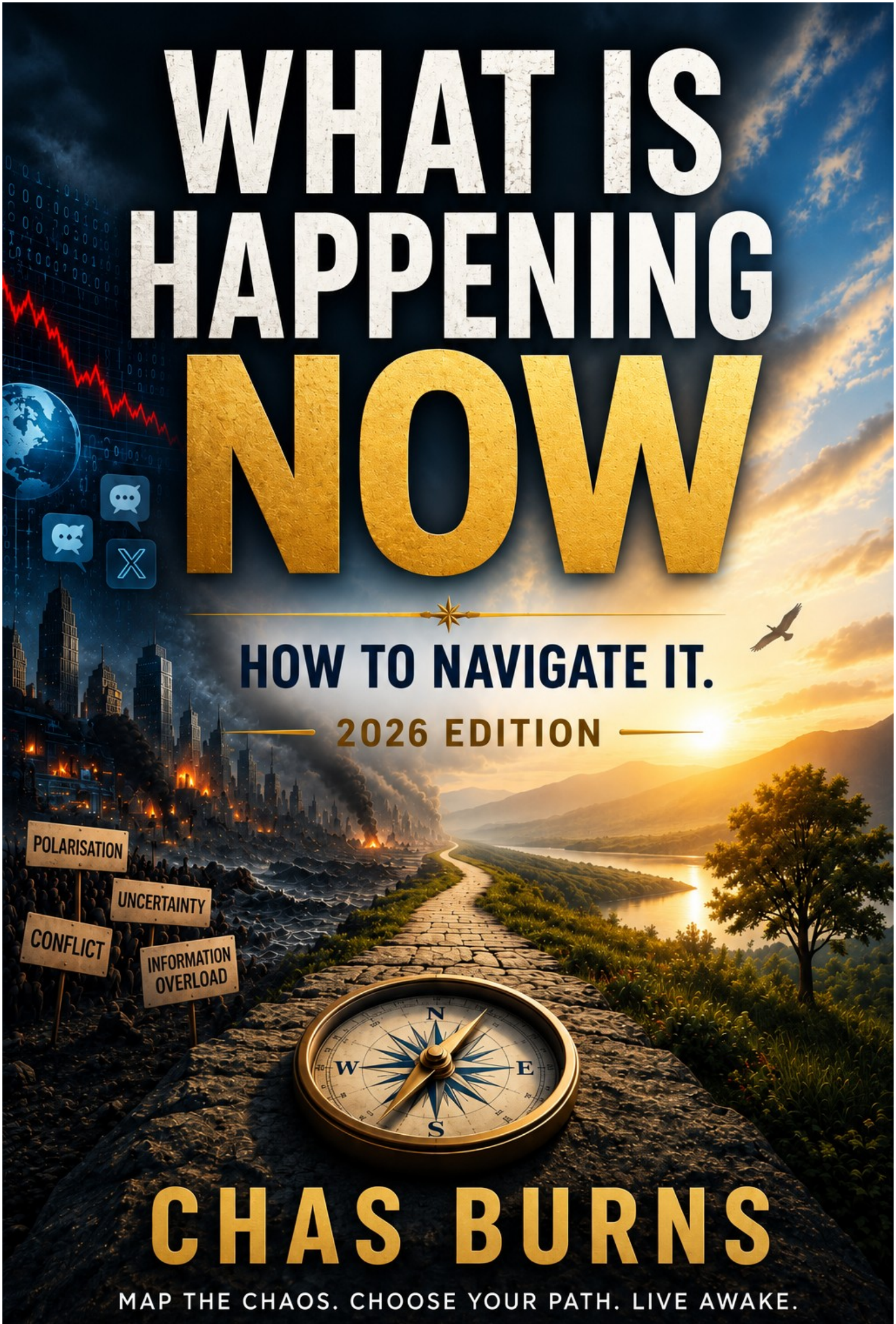

WHAT IS HAPPENING NOW
HOW TO NAVIGATE IT.
2026 EDITION
POLARISATION
UNCERTAINTY
CONFLICT
INFORMATION OVERLOAD
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CHAS BURNS
MAP THE CHAOS. CHOOSE YOUR PATH. LIVE AWAKE.

What Is Happening Now: How to Navigate It

2026 Edition

Chas Burns

Copy Real Publishing

Complimentary schools edition

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Sri Das is the pen name of Chas Burns.

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For everyone who has felt the refrigerator go silent
and wondered what it meant.

Introduction: Mapping Our Times

✦

Let us begin with a confession.

This book does not know what is happening now. Not entirely. Not with the confident, laminated certainty of a self-help title that has already decided what your problem is before you've had a chance to mention it. What this book does know — or suspects, with reasonable conviction — is that something is happening. That you feel it. That most days it hums beneath the surface of ordinary life like a refrigerator you've stopped noticing until the power cuts out and the silence is suddenly deafening.

Something is happening now. And most of us are navigating it with the rough equivalent of a hand-drawn map, a compass that spins when held near anything electronic, and advice from people who are themselves consulting hand-drawn maps.

This is an attempt to do better than that.

✦

We are, by any reasonable measure, the most informed generation in the history of the species. We carry in our pockets a device that connects us to the accumulated knowledge of every civilisation that ever troubled itself to write anything down. Ancient astronomical tables. The complete works of every major philosopher. The precise boiling point of tungsten. Peer-reviewed studies on the migratory patterns of the European roller. We have all of this. Instantly. Always.

And yet.

A 2023 study found that the average person spends approximately four hours and thirty-seven minutes on their phone each day.[1] Another found that switching between tasks — the thing our phones require us to do roughly two hundred and twenty-one times per day — reduces effective intelligence by the equivalent of a significant night without sleep.[2] A third found that the more time adolescents spend on social media, the less likely they are to report feeling that their life has meaning.[3]

We have the sum of human knowledge in our hands. We are, on the evidence, becoming less wise.

This is not a paradox. It is a design feature. We will return to it.

✦

[1] This figure varies by study and by country, but not by enough to make you feel better.

✦

What, precisely, is happening now?

To answer that properly, we need to take three steps back. Not metaphorically — or not only metaphorically — but historically. Because to understand a river, it helps to know something about the mountains it came from. And we have, in the space of a single human lifetime, moved from one kind of

world to another so completely that many of us have not quite registered that the first world existed, or that it worked in ways that ours does not, or that some of what it knew deserves the courtesy of being understood before being discarded.

So we will use three lenses throughout this book.

The first looks back roughly a hundred years — to the 1920s, give or take. A world of villages and immediate community, of letters and Sunday dinners, of grief that happened in the same room as the body, of boredom that was not yet considered a medical emergency.

The second looks back to the period just before the smartphone — before 2007, before the world became permanently connected, when people got lost on purpose, made plans that couldn't be cancelled by text, and had private thoughts that stayed private simply because there was nowhere to put them.

The third lens is this one: 2026, in which you are reading this, probably on a device that has already interrupted you twice.

These are not nostalgic lenses. Nostalgia is a liar with excellent lighting. The past had poverty, injustice, boredom of a genuinely punishing variety, and dentistry that does not bear thinking about. The point is not to return. The point is to see clearly. Because when you hold all three pictures at once, something useful happens: the current picture stops looking inevitable. And things that have stopped looking inevitable can be changed.

✦

There is a second framework running through these pages. We call it the Navigation Map — though it is less of a map and more of a compass that points in three directions at once, which sounds paradoxical but is actually just how compasses work when the terrain is complicated.

For every domain we move through — work, love, health, meaning, the raising of children, the contemplation of death — we will look at three instruments:

The psychological: how the mind can be understood, steadied, and gently redirected when it starts insisting that everything is fine or, alternatively, that nothing will ever be fine again.

The physical: what the body needs, what it is currently not getting, and how returning to it — the actual, unremarkable, breathing body that is sitting somewhere holding this book — tends to clarify things that ten minutes of scrolling does not.

The spiritual: which we use here in the widest possible sense, to mean the part of experience that cannot be optimised, quantified, or improved by a productivity app. The part that asks: why? The part that notices a winter sky and feels, briefly and inexplicably, less afraid.

These three instruments work together. They are, in fact, the same instrument viewed from different angles. We separate them only for the purposes of this book, in the same way that a map separates roads from rivers, while the actual landscape insists on mixing them without permission.

✦

A note on gender.

This book is, in one sense, about everyone. The peculiar loneliness of the modern condition is not proprietary. Anxiety does not check identity documents at the door.

But the experience of being alive in 2026 is not identical for men and women, and pretending otherwise — in the name of a false universality that somehow always ends up looking like one particular kind of person — helps no one. There are patterns. Social media does different things to teenage girls than it does to teenage boys, not because of anything essential about girls or boys, but because of how the platforms were designed, how culture shaped the inputs, and how the outputs landed.[4] Men and women grieve differently, connect differently, seek help differently, fall apart differently, and put themselves back together through different routes. Where those routes diverge, we will say so.

Where the experience is shared — and much of it is — we will say that too.

We will also acknowledge, without making a performance of it, that the binary of male and female does not contain everyone, and that those navigating life outside or between those categories carry particular pressures that 2026 has not yet finished deciding how to feel about. This book cannot solve that. It can at least notice it.

✦

A note on this book's relationship to certainty.

Sri Das — the pen name acknowledged in this book — is not a scientist, a clinician, a licensed anything, or a person who has arrived at some elevated plateau of non-attachment from which the world appears perfectly clear. Sri Das is, rather, a careful and somewhat stubborn observer of human beings, of their habits and their suffering and their occasional extraordinary dignity, who has become convinced that the reason most people feel lost right now is not that they are broken or weak or insufficiently grateful — but that the terrain genuinely has changed, very fast, and nobody handed out updated maps.

This is the map. Or the beginning of one.

It will be wrong in places. Next year's edition will correct some of those errors and introduce several new ones, in the time-honoured tradition of all good navigation.

✦

Here is what we will cover.

We will move through the three historical lenses and ask what they diagnose about now. We will spend time — uncomfortable time, necessary time — in the anatomy of the digital condition: what the phone is doing to attention, what social media is doing to identity, what the permanent availability of information is doing to the capacity to believe anything at all. We will move through work, love, health, the raising of children (a chapter that several people who have read early drafts described as "the one that made me put the book down and ring my teenager"), spiritual life, death, and civic life. At the end of each section, we will return to the Navigation Map and ask: given all of this, what can actually be done?

The answer, in most cases, turns out to be something embarrassingly simple. Go outside. Talk to someone. Stop looking at your phone for twenty minutes. Pay attention to the thing directly in front of you, which is usually more interesting than whatever the algorithm has decided to recommend in its place.

This is not to say that the crisis is simple. The crisis is not simple. The forces shaping modern life are structural, commercial, political, and in some cases deliberately engineered to prevent the very kind of clear thinking this book is attempting to encourage.[5] But the response to structural complexity has always begun, irritatingly, with the individual. With the particular human sitting in a particular chair, holding a particular book, who has perhaps already noticed that the refrigerator is silent and is wondering, for the first time in a while, what that sound might mean.

It might mean something good.

Let us find out.

✦

[4] It is worth noting, here at the very beginning, that some of the most interesting research on gender and social media was produced by the platforms themselves, then suppressed, then leaked, then disputed, then quietly confirmed by fourteen independent studies. We live in an era of abundant information and complicated epistemology.

[5] The word "deliberately" is doing real work in that sentence. We will return to it in Chapter Two, with documentation.

✦

— Sri Das, 2026

✦

The 2026 Edition is the first volume in an annual series. Each subsequent edition will retain the three-lens structure and Navigation Map while updating its content to reflect the specific pressures and developments of the preceding year. Readers who return year on year will find old friends and new problems. This is, after all, the nature of maps.

✦

Chapter One: Lenses of Time — Yesterday, Yesterday's Tomorrow, Today

✦

There is a particular kind of person — you may know one, or be one — who, when confronted with a problem, will immediately go to the nearest window and stare out of it for several minutes before doing anything else. This is not procrastination, though it resembles it closely enough to be mistaken for it by anyone watching. It is, in fact, the beginning of thinking. It is the mind stepping back to get the whole picture into frame before deciding where to stand.

This chapter is that window.

Before we diagnose the present — its anxieties, its distractions, its remarkable capacity for making people who have everything feel that something is missing — we need to step back far enough to see the whole picture. Not because the past was better. It wasn't, on balance, though it had its moments. But because the present has a habit of presenting itself as inevitable, as the natural and logical outcome of all previous history, when in fact it is simply one of several possible outcomes, arrived at through a sequence of choices, accidents, and commercial decisions made by a relatively small number of people in a relatively small number of rooms.

That is worth knowing.

So we are going to travel. Briefly, selectively, and without any suggestion that we should want to go back. We will look at the world through three lenses.

The first: roughly 1920. Pre-war, pre-television, pre-penicillin. A world organised around proximity and community, where most of what mattered happened within walking distance.

The second: roughly 1995 to 2006. The last decade of the analogue-dominant life, when the internet existed but had not yet eaten everything, and the phone in your pocket was primarily for calling people.[1]

The third: now. 2026, in which the average human attention span is shorter than it was when the last edition of this comparison was made, and shortening still.

We will move through five domains in each lens: community, daily rhythm, communication, grief and mortality, and spiritual life. In each domain we will ask the same three questions: what did we lose? what did we gain? and — the question most self-help books prefer to avoid — what is the cost?

✦

[1] The pager, briefly, promised to solve the problem of not being reachable. It did this by making you permanently reachable, which turned out not to be a solution so much as a restatement of the problem in a smaller box.

✦

I. Community

Through the First Lens: 1920

In 1920, most people in Britain, and most of the world, lived close to where they were born. Not because they lacked imagination, but because movement was expensive, slow, and not yet the default assumption. The village, the neighbourhood, the parish — these were not lifestyle choices. They were the structure of life itself.

This had consequences that we now regard as either idyllic or claustrophobic, depending on our temperament. On the idyllic side: you were known. The woman at the bakery knew your name, your mother's name, and approximately what had happened to your Uncle Bernard, who was not discussed at Christmas. The community held information about you that you had not chosen to share and could not delete. This was, simultaneously, one of the most comforting and most surveilled existences imaginable.[2]

The community also held function. When someone died, the neighbours came. Not metaphorically, not via a WhatsApp group sending flame emojis — they came, physically, to the house, and they brought food, and they sat with the grief because that was what you did. When someone was ill, others filled in. When the harvest needed bringing in, or the roof needed patching, or the new mother needed rest, the community organised itself around the need, informally, inefficiently, and on the whole reliably.

This was not charity. It was not even, precisely, kindness. It was the operating system of a world in which you knew that next year you might be the one who needed the roof patched.

The shadow side was real. Community in 1920 also meant conformity, gossip, the suffocation of difference, the casual cruelty of small places where everyone knows which families are not quite right. It meant that a woman who wanted something other than what the village expected of women had very little structural support for wanting it. It meant that a man who was not the right kind of man — not robust enough, not interested in the right things, not legible by the community's particular vocabulary of masculinity — had nowhere to go and no language to describe what was wrong.

We do not wish to return to 1920. We simply wish to notice what was there.

Through the Second Lens: 1995–2006

By the mid-nineties, community had already changed its shape. Urban migration, the post-war dispersal of extended families, the rise of the suburb — these had been dismantling the village structure for decades. But something still held. The street. The pub. The office. The school gate. The gym class on a Thursday evening where you saw the same twelve people every week for three years and gradually, without meaning to, became part of each other's lives.

These were what sociologists call third places: environments that are neither home nor work but the spaces in between where unplanned human contact happens.[3] The barbershop. The library. The community centre with its terrible coffee and its fold-out chairs and its local amateur dramatics society performing Grease every November with extraordinary commitment and mixed results.

What third places require is presence. You have to actually be in them. And being in them, in the pre-smartphone era, meant being unavailable to everywhere else. When you were at the pub, you were at the pub. Your attention was, by default, local. Conversation happened in real time, with all the inefficiency and occasional brilliance that implies. You could not, mid-sentence, check whether someone else had said something more interesting.

This sounds obvious. It was not, at the time, recognised as a luxury.

Through the Third Lens: 2026

The average person in 2026 has more connections than any human being in history. They have followers, friends, contacts, subscribers, networks. They are, by every quantitative measure, less alone than their grandparents.

They are also, by every qualitative measure, lonelier.

This is one of the genuinely strange facts of contemporary life, and it deserves a moment. Loneliness in the developed world has reached levels that public health authorities have, with some understatement, described as epidemic. In the UK, approximately one in four adults reports feeling lonely often or always. Among adults under thirty-five, the figure is higher.[4] Among teenagers, higher still.

We have built, at extraordinary expense and ingenuity, the most connected communication infrastructure in human history. And we are using it, in significant part, to feel alone in new and previously unavailable ways.

The third place has not disappeared. But it has competition it did not previously have. Why go to the pub — with its logistics and its noise and the requirement to be visibly present and emotionally available — when you can sit on your sofa and interact with a curated selection of people who have already been filtered for compatibility by an algorithm? The algorithm does not ask you to listen to a twenty-minute account of someone's difficult week at work. It knows what you like and it gives it to you, quickly and reliably, in a way that human community has never managed and will never manage, because human community was never designed for your comfort. It was designed for mutual survival, which is a different and considerably more demanding brief.

The cost is this: we are in the process of outsourcing the difficult, inefficient, unpredictable work of being with other people to systems that make it easier — and in doing so, we are losing the capacity for it. The muscle, unused, weakens. The tolerance for awkwardness, the ability to sit in a silence that isn't curated, the skill of being genuinely interested in someone whose algorithm profile would not have matched yours — these are atrophying quietly, in the same way that the ability to navigate by the stars atrophied once GPS arrived.

We do not notice the loss until we need the skill. And then we are standing in an open field at night, looking at a sky full of stars, with no idea which way is north.

✦

[2] This is, it is worth noting, not entirely different from the experience of existing on social media, except that in 1920 the surveillance was conducted by people who also knew you and would probably bring you soup if you were ill. The algorithm will not bring you soup.

[3] The term was coined by sociologist Ray Oldenburg in his 1989 book The Great Good Place, which is both a rigorous piece of sociology and an extended lament for the American bar, depending on how you read it.

[4] The UK Campaign to End Loneliness has been publishing data on this since 2011, at which point the figures were already alarming. They have not become less alarming since.

✦

II. Daily Rhythm

Through the First Lens: 1920

In 1920, the day was organised by the body and the sky.

You woke when it was light, or shortly before, because the work that needed doing was calibrated to daylight. You ate at times that were roughly consistent because the household required it. You worked, you rested, you ate again. In the evening, after dark, the options were limited: conversation, reading if you had candles or gas, perhaps music if someone in the household could play. Then sleep, which arrived reliably because you were tired in the uncomplicated way that physical work produces.

There was boredom. Considerable boredom, of a kind that no longer exists in the developed world. Long Sunday afternoons with nothing to do and nowhere to go and no screen to consult. Waiting for trains, waiting for letters, waiting for news of distant events that might take days to arrive. Children played outside not because their parents had read articles about the developmental benefits of unstructured outdoor play, but because there was nothing else and outside was where children went.

We tend to pathologise boredom now, as if it were a failure of provision. But boredom is also the condition in which the mind, having nothing to process, begins to generate its own material. Boredom is where daydreams happen. Where plans form. Where the mind notices what it actually wants, as opposed to what it has been presented with. Boredom is, neurologically, not an absence of activity but a particular kind of activity — one associated with creativity, self-reflection, and the consolidation of memory.[5]

This is not an argument for eliminating stimulation. It is an argument for understanding what was lost when we did.

Through the Second Lens: 1995–2006

By the nineties, the day had already been complicated. The television had reorganised the evening. Fast food had renegotiated the mealtime. The commute had extended the working day at both ends. The rhythm was less agricultural, less tied to the body's natural cycles — but it was still, broadly, a rhythm. There was a shape to the day that most people inhabited without noticing it.

You woke. You did not immediately look at a screen, because the screen was not there yet. You ate breakfast with or without the radio or a newspaper. You went to work. Work had edges — a start and an end — and when you left the office, the office could not follow you. Your boss could not contact you at 9pm unless they rang the house phone, which required a particular kind of boldness that most managers lacked. Your time, once you had left work, was yours in a way that is now nearly incomprehensible.

You watched television in the evening, but television in the nineties was a finite resource. There were four channels in the UK, and they did not all run all night. The news was on at ten. After that, there was increasingly little to watch, and eventually the television, recognising this, went to bed before you did.

You slept. Not perfectly, because sleep is never perfect. But without a glowing rectangle on the nightstand tracking your anxiety and offering, should you wake at three in the morning, an infinite scroll of content designed by some of the most talented engineers in the world specifically to prevent you from going back to sleep.

Through the Third Lens: 2026

The contemporary day begins, for most people, with the phone.

Not with consciousness. Not with a breath, or a stretch, or a moment of noticing the quality of the light. With the phone. Before the eyes are fully open, the thumb is moving. Notifications from the night. Messages that arrived while the body was doing the reparative, non-negotiable work of sleeping. News, by which we mean a curated selection of everything that went wrong since last you checked. The accumulated pressure of the world, delivered before breakfast.

This is not a small thing. The first moments of wakefulness set the nervous system's tone for the hours that follow. Cortisol, the primary stress hormone, is naturally elevated in the morning — this is part of what wakes you, and it is entirely healthy. But overlaying that natural arousal with a dose of social anxiety, news-driven alarm, and the low-grade comparison pressure of other people's morning posts does something to the nervous system that the cortisol spike alone was not designed to accommodate. The body arrives at breakfast already slightly behind, already slightly defended, already in a low-level version of the alert state that evolution reserved for the approach of predators.

The predators are metaphorical now. The nervous system has not received the update.

By the time you reach midday, you have context-switched — moved from one task, thought, or conversation to another — several hundred times. Each switch carries a small cognitive cost: a few seconds of reorientation, a slight dissipation of focus. Individually, these costs are invisible. Accumulated across a day, they amount to what researchers have called attention residue: the lingering cognitive fog of a hundred incomplete transitions.[6] You arrive at the end of the working day feeling exhausted in a way that is difficult to justify, having spent much of it sitting down. This is the exhaustion not of exertion but of fragmentation.

The evening offers relief, theoretically. But the phone is still there, and the algorithm — which has been watching your behaviour for years and knows, with unsettling accuracy, what will keep you engaged — is patient. It has the entire night. It has, in fact, no interest in the concept of enough.

You sleep late, or sleep badly, or sleep with the phone face-down on the nightstand because you have read something about sleep hygiene, but it is still there, and some part of you knows it, and that part does not fully rest.

✦

[5] The neuroscience of boredom is a relatively young field, largely because researchers spent several decades eliminating boredom from their experimental conditions rather than studying it. This is, in retrospect, an oversight of some magnitude.

[6] The term is from organisational psychologist Sophie Leroy, whose 2009 research on task-switching and cognitive performance remains one of the more unsettling reads in workplace psychology, particularly if you are reading it on your phone while doing something else.

✦

III. Communication and Attention

Through the First Lens: 1920

In 1920, communication was slow. Not frustratingly slow — frustratingly implies a comparison to something faster — but simply slow, in the way that things are when the speed of information is limited by the speed of a person carrying it.

A letter took days. A telegram was for emergencies and cost money. A telephone existed but was neither common nor, by modern standards, particularly reliable. You called by speaking to an operator, who connected you, and the call was usually brief because the line was expensive and privacy was limited and there was something slightly performative about speaking into a device that felt, to most people, not entirely natural.

What this slowness produced was deliberateness. When you wrote a letter, you wrote one. You thought about what you wanted to say and you said it, and then you sent it, and then you waited. The waiting was part of the communication. The gap between sending and receiving was not dead time — it was time in which the thought was held, considered, perhaps regretted, perhaps elaborated. You could not send an angry message in the small hours of the morning and have it received before you had slept on it.

Attention, correspondingly, was singular. When you were talking to someone, you were talking to them. There was no notification from anywhere else. There was no elsewhere. The conversation in front of you was the only conversation happening.

This sounds serene. It was also sometimes stifling. The absence of connection was sometimes not peaceful but isolating, particularly for those — women at home, disabled people, those in rural communities without means of travel — for whom the speed of communication was not a philosophical question but a material constraint. For them, slow was not deliberate. It was just slow.

Through the Second Lens: 1995–2006

Email arrived in the nineties as something close to magic. A message, delivered instantly, to anyone with an address. No postage, no delay, no handwriting. The love letter, the business proposal, the midnight confession — all of them transmissible at the speed of a key press.

For about a decade, it mostly worked. Email in the late nineties was used sparingly enough that most people could manage their inbox without the inbox managing them. The number of messages was still small enough to constitute communication rather than administration.

Then the volume increased. Then came the expectation of rapid response. Then the work email that arrived at seven on a Sunday evening and the question — unanswered, because there was no established protocol — of whether you should reply.

The mobile phone, meanwhile, had arrived and was slowly changing the social contract of availability. Not yet a computer. Not yet a window onto every piece of content ever produced. Just a phone, and then a phone with texts, which introduced a new register of communication — informal, instant, brief — that sat between the letter and the spoken word and resembled neither fully.

The text message rewrote the rules of attention in ways that were not immediately obvious. It was interruptive, by design. It arrived without warning. It created the expectation of an answer — not immediately, but soon. Soon was undefined, and the undefined nature of soon produced a low-level social anxiety that was novel enough that we did not yet have a name for it. We called it being busy.

Through the Third Lens: 2026

There are, at present, approximately five billion people using social media. Each of them is producing content — posts, comments, reactions, stories, reels, threads — at a rate that would have been, to anyone in 1920, not just incomprehensible but physically implausible. The volume of human communication in 2026 would have struck a person from a hundred years ago as noise. Not communication. Noise.

The question is whether they would have been wrong.

The attention economy — the term economists use for the system in which your attention is the product being sold, not the thing doing the consuming — is now the organising logic of most of the digital world. Every platform, every app, every notification system is calibrated to one end: to capture and hold your attention long enough to sell it to an advertiser. This is not conspiracy theory. It is the publicly stated business model of the companies involved, described in their investor prospectuses, litigated in their antitrust hearings, and occasionally regretted in the memoirs of their early employees.[7]

What this means for communication is that communication has been colonised by a system that is not interested in communication. The algorithm does not care whether you understood the message. It cares whether you stayed. Every feature — the infinite scroll, the variable reward of notifications, the visible like count, the read receipt that shows your message has been seen but not answered — is designed not to connect you to other people but to keep you in the system long enough to be shown another advertisement.

We communicate more than ever. We understand each other, the evidence suggests, rather less.

✦

[7] Among the more illuminating accounts is that of early Facebook investor Roger McNamee, whose book Zucked describes, with the particular clarity of someone who spent years enthusiastically funding a thing before noticing what it was doing, the deliberate engineering of compulsive use. It is the kind of book that is most useful to read before you need it, and most commonly read after.

✦

IV. Grief and Mortality

Through the First Lens: 1920

In 1920, death was present.

This sounds obvious — death is present now, in the sense that it happens — but in 1920 it was present in a way that is now difficult to imagine. People died at home, usually, in their own beds, in rooms where their families were. The body stayed in the house for a day or two. Neighbours came. The children saw the body, because the body was there, and pretending it was not would have required a logistical effort that nobody had time for.

Infant mortality in Britain in 1920 stood at approximately eighty deaths per thousand live births.[8] By 2025, it was below four. This is, unambiguously, good. A world in which parents are not routinely burying their children is a better world, by any measure that matters. We should not romanticise the grief of 1920.

But the ubiquity of death produced something that we have lost and are only now noticing the loss of: familiarity. Not comfort, not equanimity, but the deep structural knowledge that life ends, and that its ending is part of its shape, and that the people around you will die and you will die and this is not a problem to be solved but a fact to be inhabited. This knowledge lived in the body in 1920. It was encoded in the rituals — the black armband, the drawn curtains, the formal period of mourning — which gave grief a container and a duration and a social form.

Grief in 1920 was not private. It was, by community standard, public: worn, announced, witnessed. Others knew you were grieving because you looked like someone who was grieving, and they adjusted accordingly. They did not expect you to be fine. They did not suggest, gently, that you might want to consider moving on.

Through the Second Lens: 1995–2006

By the nineties, death had retreated from the home into the hospital. This, again, is mostly good: modern palliative care and the ability to manage pain at end of life represent genuine human progress. But the retreat of death from domestic space meant, gradually, that most people in the developed world reached adulthood without having been physically present with a dying person. Death happened, but it happened elsewhere, managed by professionals, behind closed doors.

What filled the space was a cultural awkwardness around mortality that earlier generations would have found bewildering. We did not know what to say. We sent flowers. We said I'm sorry for your loss with the slightly panicked air of people who have been told the correct phrase but are not entirely sure it fits. We gave grief a polite window — a week, perhaps two, for something catastrophic — and then returned, by collective agreement, to the assumption that everything was fine.

This was not cruelty. It was the behaviour of people who had not been taught, because their parents had not taught them, because the social structures that once held grief collectively had dissolved without obvious replacement.

Through the Third Lens: 2026

Death in 2026 is everywhere and nowhere.

Everywhere: the news feed delivers footage of disasters, wars, and mass casualty events with a frequency and immediacy that would have constituted psychological trauma in any previous era. We watch strangers die, in high definition, while eating breakfast. The cumulative exposure to others' deaths — people we have never met, in places we will never go, for reasons that are frequently incomprehensible — has

produced what therapists now call vicarious traumatisation at a population scale. We are grieving, constantly, for people and places we have no direct connection to, and we have no ritual for this kind of grief because no previous generation has needed one.

Nowhere: our own deaths, and the deaths of those close to us, remain as hidden as ever. We have not, despite our exposure to death-at-a-distance, become more comfortable with death up close. The hospital is still where most people die. The body is still managed elsewhere. The grief is still expected to be private, brief, and resolved.

The result is a strange asymmetry: we are saturated with mortality we cannot feel, and starved of the cultural tools to feel the mortality that is ours.

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[8] To give this figure its full weight: eighty deaths per thousand means that if you had twelve children, you might expect, on average, to bury one. In some communities, the rates were significantly higher. This is not a statistic. It is what most families lived with.

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V. Spiritual Life

Through the First Lens: 1920

Spiritual life in 1920, in Britain and much of the world, was structured by religion. Not necessarily deep or transformative religion — plenty of people attended church with the same level of transcendent engagement they brought to paying the gas bill — but organised religion, with its weekly rhythm, its communal gathering, its set of stories about why things are the way they are and what human beings are for.

Whether or not one believed the literal content of those stories, they performed a function that is not provided by their absence. They gave the week a shape. They provided a community that was explicitly organised around something larger than individual interest. They offered ritual for the major transitions of life — birth, marriage, death — that was shared and witnessed rather than improvised individually. They answered, in some form, however imperfectly, the question that every generation of human beings asks and that no productivity system has yet adequately addressed: what does this mean?

The shadow of organised religion in 1920 is familiar and real. It excluded, it enforced, it harmed, it covered over. Women, in most religious traditions of that era, were the worshippers and the organisers and the givers of labour, with considerably less formal authority than the men for whom they were doing it. Doubt was not well accommodated. Difference was not well accommodated. These are not minor footnotes.

Through the Second Lens: 1995–2006

By the nineties, organised religion was in retreat in the developed West, and something else was arriving to occupy the space. Yoga, which had been a minority practice in the seventies, was entering the mainstream. Meditation, previously associated with Buddhism or the more committed end of the New Age, was becoming available to people who were not especially interested in Buddhism but were very interested in

stress reduction. Self-help — the idea that the individual, through the right application of technique, could improve their own psychological weather — was expanding from a shelf at the back of the bookshop to a significant cultural force.

What this represented was not the death of spiritual need but its privatisation. The question what does this mean did not go away. It moved. From the collective to the individual. From the shared to the personal. From the given to the chosen.

This was, in many ways, liberating. The freedom to construct your own meaning, without inheriting a tradition that might not fit you, is real freedom. It matters, particularly for those for whom the available traditions were designed by and for someone else.

But privatised spirituality has a structural weakness: it has no community. The yoga class may be full, but the yoga class does not, typically, gather to respond to your crisis at two in the morning, or sit with you while someone you love is dying, or remind you, through shared practice, that you are part of something that existed before you and will continue after you. The wellness industry — which by 2026 is worth over six trillion dollars globally[9] — has become extraordinarily good at selling the feeling of spiritual experience while consistently declining to provide its social architecture.

Through the Third Lens: 2026

Spiritual life in 2026 is abundant and atomised.

There is more available — more traditions, more teachers, more practices, more apps offering guided meditation and breathwork and sound healing and Jungian dream analysis — than at any previous point in human history. And there is, for many people, less sense of meaning than their grandparents reported in surveys conducted in the post-war years, when the material conditions of life were considerably harder.[10]

This is not a coincidence. Meaning, it turns out, is not primarily a product of information or technique. It is a product of connection: to other people, to a shared story, to something that extends beyond the individual self. The self-optimisation culture of 2026 is, in its structure, anti-meaning: it locates the source of all wellbeing in the individual, measures progress in personal metrics, and treats the community as a resource for the self rather than the other way around. It sells the experience of transcendence without the obligations that traditionally accompanied it. It is, in the precise sense of the word, spirituality without sacrifice — and sacrifice, which is merely the word for giving something up for something larger than yourself, turns out to be where a significant portion of the meaning was.

We will return to this in Chapter Eight. For now, it is enough to observe that the question what does this mean is being asked by more people, more urgently, than it was in 1920 — and that the infrastructure for answering it is, in several important respects, less available.

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[9] The global wellness market was valued at approximately six trillion dollars in 2023 and is projected to grow. A significant portion of this figure represents the monetisation of practices — meditation, breathwork, communal gathering, time in nature — that previous generations accessed for free, in community, as a matter of ordinary life. We have, with some ingenuity, found a way to sell people the things they gave away.

[10] Gallup's global wellbeing surveys, which have been running in various forms since the mid-twentieth century, consistently find that sense of purpose and meaning correlates more strongly with social connection and contribution to community than with wealth, comfort, or access to spiritual content. This is one of the more robustly replicated findings in social science, and one of the most consistently ignored by the wellness industry.

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What the Three Lenses Tell Us

We have now looked at five domains of human life through three different windows, and a pattern has emerged. Not a simple pattern — history is not simple, and the suggestion that any era was uniformly better or worse than any other should be treated with the suspicion it deserves. But a pattern nonetheless.

The world of 1920, for all its genuine hardships, was organised around the assumption that human beings are social animals who require community, ritual, shared meaning, and physical presence with the natural world. This was not a philosophy. It was just the shape life took when you could not outsource those things to a device.

The world of 1995–2006 was in transition: the old structures dissolving, the new ones not yet arrived, a brief window of genuine freedom — from the enforced conformity of the old community, from the demands of the new connectivity — that nobody quite recognised as a window until it closed.

The world of 2026 is organised, primarily, around a different assumption: that the individual is the basic unit of wellbeing, that connection is a feature to be optimised rather than a condition of life, and that the purpose of technology is to make everything easier, including the things that were never supposed to be easy.

These assumptions are producing results. They are producing wealth, comfort, access, and connection at scales that previous generations could not have imagined. They are also producing, at the same scale, anxiety, loneliness, meaninglessness, and a kind of fragmented, distracted unhappiness that is new enough to the human experience that we are still working out what to call it.

The rest of this book is about what to do with that.

But first, it is worth sitting with what we have just seen — the way a cartographer, before drawing a new map, will stand for a moment and simply look at the territory.

We are not lost. We are in unfamiliar terrain with an outdated map, which is a different and considerably more solvable problem. The terrain can be read. The new map can be drawn.

That is what we are here to do.

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Next: Chapter Two — The Digital Condition: Anatomy of Our Attention

In which we look more closely at the phone in your pocket, what it is actually doing to you, and why that knowledge has so far proven remarkably difficult to act on.

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Chapter Two: The Digital Condition — Anatomy of Our Attention

✦

Let us begin with the phone.

Not metaphorically. The actual phone. The one that is, with a probability approaching certainty, either in your hand, on the table beside you, or in your pocket where you can feel it through the fabric — a small, rectangular awareness, like a tooth you can't stop touching with your tongue.

Pick it up, if it isn't already in your hand. Look at it for a moment. It is, by any reasonable measure, an extraordinary object. It contains maps of every city on earth. It can translate any spoken language in real time. It can identify a bird by its call, a plant by its leaf, a piece of music by four seconds of ambient recording. It gives you access, at any moment of any day, to the complete published works of every major thinker in human history, the entire archive of recorded music, and more films, television programmes, and documentary footage than you could consume if you began watching now and lived to be three hundred.

It also checks, on average, every time you interact with it, whether something new has arrived that might be more interesting than whatever you were doing before. And it is very rarely wrong that something has.

This is the device we are discussing. Hold both facts at once, because the second doesn't cancel the first and the first doesn't excuse the second. The phone is genuinely remarkable. It is also doing something to us that we are only beginning to understand, and what it is doing is not, on the whole, what we were told it would do when we agreed to carry it everywhere.

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I. The Architecture of Attention

Before we can talk about what the phone is doing to attention, we need to talk about what attention is — because attention is not, as we tend to assume, simply the thing that happens when you look at something. Attention is the fundamental organising principle of conscious experience. It is not what you notice. It is what makes noticing possible. It is, in the words of psychologist William James, writing in 1890, long before anyone had a smartphone to worry about, "the taking possession by the mind, in clear and vivid form, of one out of what seem several simultaneously possible objects or trains of thought."[1]

One out of several. James's definition contains, already, the essential constraint. Attention is selective by nature. It cannot be in two places at once. What you attend to, you experience. What you don't attend to, you don't — regardless of whether it is technically in front of you.

This matters because the entire architecture of the modern digital environment is designed around the premise that attention is a resource to be competed for and captured. Not shared. Not earned, in the older sense of earning — by being genuinely interesting or useful or true. Captured: held against its natural tendency to move, in the same way that a dam captures water not by being more attractive than the river but by being in the way.

The attention economy — the phrase was coined by Herbert Simon in 1971, though he could not have imagined the scale of what he was naming — operates on a simple logic: human attention is finite, the things competing for it are not, and the platform that captures the most attention makes the most money.[2] Everything else follows from this. The infinite scroll, which removes the natural stopping point of a finite page. The variable reward mechanism, which delivers interesting content unpredictably rather than reliably, because unpredictable rewards are neurologically more compelling than predictable ones — the same principle that makes a slot machine more addictive than a vending machine.[3] The notification, which does not wait for you to come to it but reaches into whatever you are doing and taps you on the shoulder, every time, until you have formed the habit of checking in anticipation of the tap rather than waiting for it to arrive.

These are not accidents of design. They are the design.

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[1] James wrote this in Principles of Psychology, a two-volume work that took him twelve years to complete and that he described, upon finishing, as "a loathsome, distended, tumefied, bloated, dropsical mass." This is either a cautionary tale about long projects or a useful reminder that the people who understood attention best were not always happy about what they found.

[2] Simon's original formulation was: "A wealth of information creates a poverty of attention." He wrote this about the television age. He would, one imagines, have had thoughts about the subsequent fifty years, though whether he would have been able to finish them without being interrupted is another question.

[3] The variable reward mechanism was identified by behavioural psychologist B.F. Skinner in the 1950s, using pigeons. The pigeons pressed a lever and sometimes got food. The unpredictability of the reward made them press the lever compulsively, far more than pigeons who got food every time. Skinner was studying pigeons. The social media platforms were studying Skinner.

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II. What the Brain Does With All of This

The human brain is, among its many remarkable qualities, a prediction machine. It is not primarily a reactor to events but an anticipator of them — constantly generating models of what is about to happen based on what has happened before, and adjusting those models in response to new information. This is enormously useful. It is what allows you to catch a ball, finish a sentence, navigate a familiar route without conscious attention. It is also, in the context of the smartphone, a significant vulnerability.

When you pick up your phone and check it — for messages, for notifications, for the news, for anything — you are training the prediction machine. You are teaching it that the phone contains things worth checking. The prediction machine notes this. It begins to anticipate the check. It starts, in the intervals between checks, to generate low-level curiosity: is there something there? Has something happened? This anticipatory state — not yet anxiety, but not quite rest either — is now the baseline condition of most people who own a smartphone.[4]

The neurotransmitter involved is dopamine, which is not, as popular culture tends to suggest, simply a pleasure chemical. Dopamine is more precisely a wanting chemical. It does not fire in response to getting what you want — it fires in response to the anticipation of getting what you want, and most intensely in

response to the possibility that you might get it. The slot machine again. The variable reward. You check your phone not because you know something interesting is there, but because it might be, and the might be is, neurologically, more compelling than the probably isn't.[5]

This is not a character flaw. It is not weakness or laziness or poor impulse control, though it is sometimes described in those terms by people who find it easier to blame the user than to examine the engineering. It is a rational response by a neurological system that was designed, over several hundred thousand years, to pay close attention to anything in the environment that might be significant. The brain that ignores the rustle in the grass is the brain that gets eaten. The brain that checks, just in case — that brain survives. We are all descended from the checkers.

The problem is that the rustle in the grass happened, historically, once in a while. The notification happens, on the average smartphone, approximately eighty times per day.[6]

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[4] There is a concept in trauma psychology called hypervigilance: a state of heightened alertness in which the nervous system is constantly scanning for threat. It is a symptom of post-traumatic stress, and it is experienced as profoundly exhausting. The baseline attentional state of the heavy smartphone user is not identical to hypervigilance, but it is, in structure, rather closer to it than to rest.

[5] The neuroscience here is associated primarily with the work of Wolfram Schultz, whose research on dopamine neurons in the 1990s established the distinction between reward prediction and reward receipt. His findings, which won him a share of the 2024 Lasker Award, are the scientific foundation of every app that has ever sent you a notification. He seems, based on available evidence, somewhat ambivalent about this.

[6] This figure is from a 2023 analysis of smartphone usage data across multiple countries. It varies by age, with younger users receiving significantly more. The figure does not include the notifications the user chose not to enable, which means it is, in a sense, the conservative estimate.

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III. The Platforms, One by One

It is tempting to discuss social media as a monolith — social media bad, put down phone, go outside — and while the go outside part of that advice is genuinely excellent and we will return to it, the monolith framing misses something important. The different platforms are doing different things to different people in different ways, and the differences matter.

Facebook is, in 2026, no longer primarily a platform for the young. Its demographic has aged steadily, and it is now used most intensely by people over forty-five — which means it is the platform where a significant portion of the population is receiving its news, maintaining contact with extended family, and, not coincidentally, being exposed to the political misinformation that algorithmic amplification has made a structural feature of the social web. Facebook's algorithm — like all social media algorithms — prioritises content that generates strong emotional responses, because strong emotional responses produce engagement, and engagement is the metric. Outrage is more engaging than agreement. Fear is more engaging than reassurance. The algorithm is not trying to make you angry. It is simply indifferent to what it takes.[7]

Instagram is a platform organised around the visual, and specifically around the curated visual: the photograph that has been selected from forty-seven alternatives, filtered, lit, cropped, and captioned with the kind of casual spontaneity that takes twenty minutes to perfect. This is not unique to Instagram — the impulse to present a managed version of oneself to others is as old as portraiture — but Instagram has industrialised it. The comparison culture this produces is, for women and girls in particular, corrosive in ways that the platform's own internal research documented, in 2021, and then suppressed.[8] The research found that thirty-two per cent of teenage girls reported that when they felt bad about their bodies, Instagram made them feel worse. The platform published a press release noting that Instagram was a positive experience for most users and continued to operate as before.

TikTok is a different kind of machine. Where Facebook is organised around the social graph — you see content from people you know — TikTok is organised around the interest graph: you see content that the algorithm predicts you will watch, regardless of whether you have any connection to the person who made it. The algorithm is, by most accounts, extraordinarily good at this. It can identify your interests, your mood, your vulnerabilities, with an accuracy that most users find either impressive or unsettling, depending on the day. The result is a feed that feels, to a degree that other platforms have not quite achieved, personally addressed — as if the algorithm knows you, which in the relevant sense it does, better than most of your friends do, because it has watched you for longer and with more attention than most of your friends have.[9]

TikTok's particular contribution to the attention economy is the short video format: fifteen seconds, sixty seconds, three minutes at the outside. Each video is complete in itself. Each ending is immediately followed by the beginning of the next. The scroll is vertical and continuous; the content is dense and varied; the gap between one thing and the next is designed to be imperceptible. This is not a casual design choice. It is the logical conclusion of the attention-capture project: a format in which there is no natural stopping point, no moment at which the experience reaches a satisfying conclusion and the user thinks yes, that's enough, I'm done. Done is not a feature.

X (formerly Twitter), in its current form, has become, for many of its users, less a social network than a performance venue. The short-form text format rewards aphorism, provocation, and the well-timed rejoinder. It punishes nuance, because nuance takes more than two hundred and eighty characters and most users will not follow the thread. The result is a public square optimised for certainty — for the confident assertion, the devastating one-liner, the ideological position stated as obvious truth — and correspondingly hostile to the admission of complexity, doubt, or the possibility of being partly wrong. Spend enough time in this environment and the habits of mind it rewards begin to colonise your thinking outside it. The world starts to look like a series of positions to be defended rather than problems to be explored.

These are not all the platforms. They are the four that are currently doing the most work on the most people, and the principles they illustrate — algorithmic amplification of emotion, social comparison, interest-graph personalisation, format-driven attention capture — are present in every platform to some degree, because they are the principles that work, in the narrow sense of generating engagement. They are worth understanding not because understanding them will necessarily make you stop using the platforms, but because using them without understanding them is the condition the platforms were designed to produce.

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[7] Frances Haugen, the Facebook whistleblower who gave the US Senate internal documents in 2021, described the company's algorithm as follows: "Facebook has realised that if they change the algorithm to be safer, people will spend less time on the site, they'll click on less advertising, they'll make less money." This is the clearest available description of the structural problem. It is not that the companies are evil, though some of the decisions made within them were. It is that they are operating a machine that is indifferent to outcomes other than engagement, and engagement is not the same thing as wellbeing.

[8] The documents, which became known as the Facebook Papers, were published by the Wall Street Journal in September 2021. The company's response — that the research was being mischaracterised, that Instagram was net positive, that the full context was more complicated — may or may not be accurate in its details. It is worth noting that "the full context is more complicated" is a defence that is structurally available to any organisation that does not want to change what it is doing.

[9] This is not metaphor. TikTok's algorithm has access to your watch time, your re-watches, the point at which you paused, the point at which you scrolled away. It knows not just what you watched but where your attention wavered. Most human relationships operate with considerably less granular data.

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IV. The Information Environment

There is a particular kind of headache — not painful, exactly, but heavy, slightly blurring at the edges — that arrives after a sustained session of reading the news. If you have experienced this and assumed it was a personal failing, a weakness of concentration or insufficient interest in current affairs, it may be reassuring to learn that it is, in fact, a rational response to an irrational situation.

The human brain evolved to process information at the speed at which information historically arrived: slowly, locally, and with enough gaps to allow assimilation before the next item appeared. A village, in 1920, might receive significant news — a death, an election result, a distant war — perhaps once a week, via the newspaper, and the village had seven days to talk about it, contextualise it, decide what it meant, and work out what, if anything, to do about it.

The contemporary news environment delivers significant events at a rate of several per hour, from dozens of sources, with immediate commentary, counter-commentary, breaking developments, corrections to the corrections, and the additional meta-layer of commentary on the coverage itself. The brain has not changed. The information rate has increased by several orders of magnitude. The result is not better understanding of the world but worse — a condition researchers have called information overload, in which the volume of incoming data exceeds the system's capacity to process it, and the system responds by processing less of each item rather than fewer items.[10] We skim. We scan. We form opinions about events we have not read past the headline.

This is not stupidity. It is triage. The brain, overwhelmed, makes the only rational choice available to it: it reduces the depth of processing in order to maintain the breadth. The cost is that understanding is replaced by familiarity. We know of many things and understand few of them well, which is a form of epistemic poverty that feels, from the inside, like being well-informed.

The misinformation problem is, in part, a product of this state. False information spreads not primarily because people are credulous or foolish but because, in a high-volume information environment, the mental shortcuts the brain uses to evaluate claims — does this feel true? does it fit what I already believe? did someone I trust share it? — are the only tools that can operate at the speed required. We do not have time, processing forty items of news per day, to evaluate each one carefully. The brain uses the shortcuts. The shortcuts are, by design, exploitable.[11]

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[10] Information overload as a formal research concept dates to the 1970s, when it was studied primarily in the context of organisational decision-making. The researchers of that era would find the contemporary information environment recognisable in structure and unimaginable in scale — like a traffic engineer from 1975 being shown a modern motorway junction. The principles are the same. The magnitude is not.

[11] The most robust finding in misinformation research is not that false information is more believable than true information — on careful examination, most people can distinguish them — but that false information spreads faster, because it tends to be more emotionally arousing. Anger, disgust, and fear are more sharing-motivating than calm interest. The algorithm amplifies what gets shared. The result is a system that is structurally biased toward the false, not because false is preferred, but because false tends to be angrier.

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The Peculiar Case of Andy

There is a type of person — let us call him Andy, though he has many names and exists in most social circles — who was, ten years ago, broadly reasonable. He read the newspaper, had moderate political opinions, and could be relied upon to have a sensible conversation about most subjects. In recent years, Andy has changed. He has become certain in ways he was not certain before. He has found a set of explanations — for the economy, for his health, for the behaviour of governments, for the general feeling that things are not as they should be — that are comprehensive, internally consistent, and resistant to counter-evidence. He brings these explanations to family dinners, where they are received with the particular silence that follows something nobody knows how to answer.

What happened to Andy was not stupidity, and it was not some latent pathology finally surfacing. What happened to Andy was the internet.

Andy had, like most people, a genuine sense that something was wrong. The feeling was not incorrect — several things were wrong, in the economy, in institutional trust, in the visible behaviour of powerful organisations. Andy went looking for explanations, as people do. The algorithm, which does not care whether explanations are true but does care whether they are engaging, gave him engaging ones. The engaging ones had the quality of revelation — they explained not just one thing but everything, with a coherence that legitimate complexity rarely achieves. Andy found communities of people who shared these explanations. The communities confirmed and extended the explanations. Andy's search history taught the algorithm that this was what he wanted, and the algorithm obliged.

This process is not unique to conspiracy theory. It operates across the entire spectrum of strong belief, from the political to the dietary to the medical. The mechanism is always the same: a genuine need for explanation, a recommendation engine that rewards engagement over accuracy, and a community that provides belonging in exchange for ideological conformity. What you end up with, at the far end of the

process, is someone for whom the explanations have become more real than the evidence — because the explanations came with community, validation, and the satisfying feeling of understanding, while the evidence came alone, in the form of a correction from someone who clearly didn't get it.

Andy is not irretrievable. But he is harder to reach than he was, and the channel that changed him is still open and still running.

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V. Parasocial Life

In the corner of many people's digital lives, quietly taking up considerable psychological space, there is a person they have never met.

A podcaster. A YouTuber. A Substack writer. A streamer. An influencer of some description, in some corner of the vast and differentiated attention economy. This person speaks, in their content, with an intimacy that resembles friendship: first-person confessions, personal disclosures, the sense of being addressed directly. They have opinions that the listener finds themselves agreeing with, tastes they find themselves adopting, references they find themselves looking up. The listener knows this person's voice better than they know the voices of some of their actual friends.

This is a parasocial relationship: a one-sided bond in which one party experiences genuine connection, while the other is unaware of their existence.[12] The term sounds clinical, slightly pathological, and it is worth being clear that it is neither. Parasocial relationships are normal. They have always existed — people felt genuine grief when actors died, genuine affection for characters in novels, real loyalty to radio voices they had never seen. What is new is the scale, the intimacy, and the commercial infrastructure built around them.

The parasocial relationship has become, for many people, a significant supplement to — and in some cases a substitute for — actual social connection. This is understandable. The parasocial relationship offers many of the emotional satisfactions of friendship — the sense of being known, of shared sensibility, of regular contact — without any of the costs. The podcaster does not need you to listen when they are struggling. The YouTuber does not require you to be emotionally available on a bad day. The parasocial relationship is, in the precise sense of the word, comfortable — and comfort, while valuable, is not the same thing as connection.

The muscle analogy applies here too. The capacity for genuine intimacy — with its demands, its misunderstandings, its requirement that you be present not just when it suits you but when it is needed — is a capacity that requires exercise. The parasocial relationship is the stationary bike of human connection: it feels like the real thing, it occupies the time that the real thing would occupy, and it does not build the same muscle.

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[12] The term was coined by sociologists Donald Horton and Richard Wohl in 1956, in a paper studying audience responses to television personalities. Their observation that viewers spoke of television hosts as if they were personal acquaintances was considered, at the time, slightly alarming. It was also, in retrospect, rather understated as a prognosis.

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VI. What It Is Doing to the Body

We have been discussing attention and psychology, but the phone is not only a psychological event. It is a physical one. It happens to a body, and the body registers it in ways that do not appear in the screen time statistics.

Sleep. The light emitted by screens — specifically the blue-wavelength component — suppresses the production of melatonin, the hormone that regulates the sleep cycle. The body interprets blue light as daylight: an instruction to be alert, attentive, and not yet ready for sleep. This is well established and has been well established for over a decade, during which time screen use in the hour before bed has continued to rise, particularly among adolescents.[13] The results are visible: average sleep duration in the developed world has fallen by approximately ninety minutes since the 1940s, with the steepest decline occurring in the smartphone era. This matters not as a lifestyle inconvenience but as a health issue: sleep deprivation at population scale is associated with increased rates of cardiovascular disease, metabolic disorder, impaired immune function, and — less discussed but equally significant — reduced capacity for emotional regulation, which means that the population is becoming, on average, both more tired and less able to manage the anxiety that the phone is also producing.

Posture. The posture of phone use — head forward, neck flexed, shoulders rounded — places a load of approximately twenty-seven kilograms on the cervical spine when the head is tilted sixty degrees, compared to approximately four to five kilograms when the head is upright.[14] This is not, in isolation, catastrophic. But the average person spends several hours per day in this position, and the accumulated effect on the musculoskeletal system is now visible in clinical data: physiotherapists report significant increases in neck pain, upper back problems, and headaches in patients aged fifteen to thirty-five, in patterns consistent with sustained forward head posture. The body is, quite literally, bending under the weight of what we are looking at.

The nervous system. The phone is, among other things, an anxiety delivery device. News, social comparison, the ambient pressure of unanswered messages, the low-level vigilance of checking — all of these activate, to varying degrees, the sympathetic nervous system: the fight-or-flight system that evolved to respond to acute physical threat. The sympathetic nervous system is not designed for sustained, low-level activation. It is a sprint mechanism being used as a resting state. The result, in the body, is chronic mild stress — elevated cortisol, reduced heart rate variability, a persistent background tension that the body experiences as normal because it has forgotten what its absence feels like.[15]

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[13] The research on blue light and sleep is associated primarily with Charles Czeisler at Harvard and Matthew Walker at UC Berkeley, whose 2017 book Why We Sleep managed the rare feat of being both a bestseller and scientifically robust. Walker's central argument — that sleep is not a luxury but the foundational physiological process upon which all others depend — has been confirmed by subsequent research to an extent that makes the continued rise of screen use before bed a rather striking collective decision.

[14] The figure comes from a 2014 study by spine surgeon Kenneth Hansraj, published in Surgical Technology International, which calculated the forces on the cervical spine at various angles of head flexion. The study went modestly viral, which is one of the more ironic things that has happened in the history of public health communication.

[15] Heart rate variability — the variation in time between heartbeats — is one of the most reliable physiological indicators of nervous system state. High variability indicates parasympathetic dominance: rest, recovery, openness. Low variability indicates sympathetic activation: alertness, stress, defensive readiness. Consistent smartphone users show, on average, lower resting heart rate variability than non-users. The body is keeping a record.

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VII. What It Is Doing to the Mind

Anxiety. The relationship between social media use and anxiety is, at this point, one of the most replicated findings in behavioural psychology. The association is dose-dependent — more use correlates with more anxiety — and it is stronger for passive use (scrolling, observing, consuming) than for active use (posting, creating, direct messaging).[16] It is stronger for women than for men, stronger for adolescents than for adults, and strongest of all for adolescent girls, for reasons we will examine in detail in Chapter Five. It is worth noting here that the relationship is bidirectional: anxious people use social media more, and social media makes people more anxious. The algorithm, which does not distinguish between the two directions, is happy with either.

Identity. Who are you when you are not being seen?

This is not a philosophical question, or not only a philosophical question. It is a practical one, and it has become more practically urgent in the social media era than at any previous point in modern history. The self has always been partly a performance — sociologist Erving Goffman documented this in the 1950s, long before anyone had a profile to manage — but the performance of the contemporary self has acquired an infrastructure, an audience, and a metric that previous performances lacked.[17] You can see, precisely, how many people approved of who you were today. You can compare that number to yesterday's number, to other people's numbers, to the number you expected. The self, exposed to this kind of feedback at this kind of frequency, begins to orient toward the feedback rather than toward whatever was there before the feedback arrived.

The therapeutic term for this is externalisation of self-worth: the location of the sense of one's own value in external rather than internal signals. It is associated with fragility — because external signals fluctuate, and a self built on fluctuating signals fluctuates with them — and with the compulsive seeking of more signals, because the signal that was sufficient yesterday becomes insufficient today, in the same way that the dose that was sufficient last month becomes insufficient this month.

This is the identity consequence of the attention economy: not the creation of false selves, exactly, but the gradual transfer of the sense of self from something internal and relatively stable to something external and constantly in need of maintenance. We are not, most of us, performing falsely. We are performing more than we used to, for an audience that is always watching, and we have slowly forgotten that there was something there before the performance began.

Frustration tolerance. The digital environment has, as a structural feature, eliminated waiting. Information is instant. Entertainment is instant. Communication is instant. The delivery of physical goods, in the major urban centres, is now measured in hours. This is, in many respects, good. Waiting for things that don't need to be waited for is not a virtue.

But frustration tolerance — the capacity to sit with difficulty, discomfort, and delay without catastrophising or abandoning the task — is a psychological skill that is built through practice, and the practice it requires is, specifically, the experience of waiting and tolerating the discomfort of waiting. The brain learns that the uncomfortable feeling is temporary, that the difficult thing is manageable, that the reward at the end is worth the discomfort in the middle. In an environment where discomfort is immediately solvable by switching to something else, this learning does not occur. The discomfort remains novel. The difficult thing remains intolerable.

The clinical consequence is visible in therapy practices: younger patients presenting with what practitioners describe as an almost complete inability to tolerate uncertainty — not pathological anxiety in the clinical sense, but a baseline expectation that discomfort should be quickly resolved, combined with significant distress when it is not. The expectation was set by the environment. The environment was designed that way.

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[16] The distinction between passive and active social media use was established in a series of studies in the mid-2010s, with the clearest early formulation coming from researchers at the University of Michigan. Passive consumption — looking at what others are doing — is consistently more depressing than active engagement. The mechanism appears to be social comparison: watching others' lives without participating produces the particular misery of the audience, as opposed to the lesser misery of the participant.

[17] Goffman's The Presentation of Self in Everyday Life, published in 1959, argued that all social interaction is a kind of performance in which we manage the impressions others form of us. It was considered a somewhat cynical thesis at the time. It has since been vindicated so completely that it has become difficult to remember it was ever controversial.

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VIII. What It Is Doing to the Soul

We arrive, finally, at the domain that is hardest to measure and easiest to dismiss: what the digital condition is doing to the part of experience that resists quantification.

Call it soul, if the word fits you. Call it the inner life, if it doesn't. Call it the capacity for stillness, for presence, for the experience of being fully in one place at one time with one's full attention intact. Whatever you call it, it has a character that is recognisable when it is there and conspicuously absent when it is not.

Stillness requires, as a minimum condition, the absence of input. Not the absence of all sensation — the wind, the quality of light, the sounds of a room — but the absence of directed input: content that is aimed at you, designed to claim your attention, structured to prevent the kind of formless, undirected awareness that is the precondition of reflection. The contemplative traditions — every one of them, across every

culture that has engaged seriously with the question of inner life — agree on this. The mystic, the philosopher, the psychoanalyst, the cognitive neuroscientist all converge on the same point: the mind needs, regularly, to be left alone.

The digital environment does not leave the mind alone.

This is not an oversight. It is, again, the design. An app that leaves you alone generates no data, no engagement, no revenue. The silence is the competitor. The silence is what the platform is designed to fill.

The spiritual consequence of a life lived in continuous directed input is not dramatic. It does not arrive as crisis. It arrives as a gradual, almost imperceptible diminishment of the capacity for wonder, for depth of feeling, for the experience of meaning. The things that used to matter begin to matter slightly less. The capacity for boredom — which, as we noted in Chapter One, is the precondition of self-generated thought — disappears. The inner life, like any unused faculty, weakens. Not gone. Not destroyed. Simply quiet, and growing quieter.

There is a moment, which many people report and few discuss, of sitting in a genuinely peaceful environment — a garden, a hillside, a room without screens — and feeling, rather than peace, a peculiar anxiety. The anxiety of having nothing to attend to. The discomfort of the mind that has forgotten how to be with itself. This is not a sign of damage. It is a sign of habituation. The mind has become accustomed to the stimulation and experiences its absence as deprivation.

The way back from this is not dramatic either. It is, in fact, embarrassingly ordinary. We will discuss it in the Navigation sections that follow each chapter. For now, it is enough to note that the capacity is not lost. It is only, in the precise sense of the word, dormant.

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IX. A Summary, of Sorts

We have covered a great deal of difficult terrain in this chapter, and it is worth pausing before the practical section to register what has actually been established.

The digital environment is not evil. It is not a conspiracy, in the sense of a coordinated plan by malicious actors. It is something in some ways more interesting and in some ways more difficult to address: a set of systems optimised for a single metric — engagement — that turns out to be in structural tension with several of the things that make human beings healthy, happy, and capable of living with themselves and each other.

The people who built these systems were not, in most cases, trying to do harm. They were trying to build things that people would use. They succeeded, at a scale no one predicted. The harms that followed are, in many cases, still being contested, still being researched, still being minimised by the institutions that produced them. But the broad outlines are no longer seriously in doubt: the direction of the effects is established, the mechanisms are understood, and the gap between what we know and what we are collectively doing about it is one of the more striking features of the current moment.

You are not powerless in this. That is the point of the next section, and the rest of this book.

But it is important, before moving to what can be done, to have looked clearly at what is. The map is only useful if it shows the territory as it is, not as we would prefer it to be.

Look at it, then. And then let us talk about what to do.

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Navigation: The Tools for This Chapter

Psychologically: Begin with awareness before action. Keep a phone log for one week — not to shame yourself, but to see. Note the time, the trigger, and what you were feeling immediately before you picked up the phone. Most people find three to four consistent triggers: boredom, anxiety, social discomfort, transitional moments (waiting, walking, the gap between tasks). Once the triggers are visible, they can be met differently. The phone is usually not the answer to the question the trigger is asking.

Physically: The most evidence-based single intervention for reducing phone dependency is not a digital detox. It is putting the phone in another room at night. Not face-down on the nightstand. In another room. The first night is uncomfortable. The second is less so. The sleep data from people who do this consistently is, among the more hopeful statistics in this chapter.

Spiritually: Once per day — not for long, five minutes will do — sit somewhere without the phone and do nothing in particular. Not meditation, not mindfulness practice, not a structured exercise. Nothing. Let the mind wander where it wants to go. Notice where it goes. The first week this will feel like a waste of time. The second week it will feel like something else, though the word for what it feels like varies by person and we will not pre-empt it.

The point is not to escape the digital world. The point is to visit the one that exists without it, often enough to remember that it does.

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Next: Chapter Three — Work and Wealth: The Labour of Life

In which we discover that the problem of not being able to leave the office has been solved, in the manner of a wish granted by a malicious genie, by making the office inescapable.

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Chapter Three: Work and Wealth — The Labour of Life

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Somewhere around 2015, a particular phrase entered the professional vocabulary of the English-speaking world and has not left it since. The phrase is always on, and it is used, depending on context, as either a boast or a complaint — sometimes simultaneously, by the same person, in the same sentence, without any apparent awareness of the contradiction.

Always on means, in practice: available. Reachable. Responsive. It means that the working day has no edges, that the email that arrives at nine on a Sunday evening exists in the same psychological category as the email that arrives at eleven on a Tuesday morning, and that the question of whether to answer it — now, later, or not at all — is one you will spend a non-trivial amount of your Sunday evening resolving. It means that the office, which previous generations understood to be a place you left, has become a condition you inhabit.

This has happened so gradually, and with such a convincing narrative of progress attached to it — flexibility, connectivity, the future of work — that most people have not quite noticed that what was promised was freedom and what arrived was its structural opposite. The freedom to work from anywhere has become, for a significant portion of the workforce, the obligation to work from everywhere. The genie was very thorough.

We will, in this chapter, examine how work has changed across the three lenses — what it was, what it briefly was, and what it has become — and we will try to understand not just the practical consequences but the deeper ones: what happens to a person whose work has no edges, and what happens to a society that has quietly come to believe that productivity is the primary measure of human value.

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I. Through the First Lens: 1920

Work in 1920 was, for most people, physical.

Not in the romanticised sense of the artisan at the lathe, though artisans existed. In the ordinary sense: most of the population worked with their hands, their backs, and their hours of available light. Agricultural labour. Factory work. Domestic service. Mining. Construction. The trades — carpenter, blacksmith, seamstress, baker — which required skill of a kind that lived in the body as much as in the mind, accumulated over years of practice, and visibly expressed in the quality of what was made.

The relationship to time was different. The working day was structured by external conditions — the factory whistle, the harvest, the light — rather than by the worker's own discipline. This had the considerable advantage of making the end of work legible. When the whistle blew, work was over. The body came home. The mind could, within the constraints of exhaustion, follow.

There was also, in 1920, a clearer relationship between work and its product. The baker made bread. The carpenter made furniture. The miner extracted coal, which became heat in someone's home. The connection between effort and outcome was short, visible, and in most cases comprehensible to the person performing the effort. This sounds like a small thing. It is not.[1]

For women in 1920, work was in most cases domestic — and crucially, unpaid. The labour of the household: cooking, cleaning, child-rearing, the management of the family's material existence. This work was as exhausting and as necessary as any paid employment, and it was afforded approximately the social recognition of a natural feature. Women were not working. They were simply being women. The economic and psychological consequences of this designation — the invisibility of labour that did not enter the formal economy — are with us still, in the persistent undervaluation of care work, in the disproportionate domestic burden carried by women even in households where both partners are employed, and in the still-unresolved question of what counts as real work and who decides.[2]

Financial life in 1920 was, by contemporary standards, simple. Most people were paid wages for hours worked. Debt existed but was not yet the organising financial principle of ordinary life. The concept of a credit score — a numerical assessment of your reliability as a debtor, used to determine your access to housing, transport, and goods — did not yet govern the material conditions of existence. Money was, on the whole, a thing you had or didn't have, rather than a thing you borrowed from your future self in the reasonable hope that your future self would be in a position to repay it, which your future self, statistically speaking, often was not.

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[1] The philosopher and motorcycle mechanic Matthew Crawford, in his 2009 book Shop Class as Soulcraft, argues that the disappearance of manual trade from the working lives of most educated people has produced a specific kind of psychological poverty: the absence of the cognitive satisfaction that comes from making a thing that exists independently of the maker, and that works or doesn't work by criteria that are not up for negotiation. You can dispute the value of an Excel spreadsheet. You cannot dispute whether the engine runs.

[2] The economist Marilyn Waring spent a significant portion of her career documenting the extent to which unpaid domestic and care labour — performed disproportionately by women globally — is excluded from national accounting systems, and therefore from the metrics by which societies measure their own prosperity. Her 1988 book If Women Counted is still the clearest available account of this exclusion. The accounting systems have not materially changed.

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II. Through the Second Lens: 1995–2006

The office, by the mid-nineties, had become the dominant site of working life for the educated professional classes in the developed world. It was, by most contemporary assessments, not an inspiring place. The cubicle — that architectural expression of the belief that human beings can be efficiently processed in identical modular units — had reached its zenith. The commute was long. The coffee was bad. The fluorescent lighting was the kind that made everyone look slightly unwell, which was perhaps appropriate, since many of them were.

But the office had one quality that has come to seem, in retrospect, almost radical: it had edges.

You entered it at a defined time and left it at another. Your work was, in the main, conducted within it. The equipment required for your work — the computer, the printer, the filing cabinet — was there, and not at home. When you left, you left. Your boss had your home phone number, but ringing it after hours required a specific decision to intrude on your private time, and most managers, faced with the social awkwardness of making that call, did not. The boundary was not enforced by rule. It was enforced by friction, and friction, it turns out, does an enormous amount of work in the world.[3]

Money, in the nineties, was also undergoing a significant transformation. The financialisation of everyday life — the expansion of credit, the rise of the home as investment vehicle, the pension system's shift from defined benefit to defined contribution — was well underway. But it was still possible to have a reasonably stable working life on a single income in most of the developed world, to purchase a home on a professional salary, and to expect that the deal you were offered at the start of your working life — work reliably, save modestly, retire adequately — would be approximately the deal you received at the end of it.

This expectation, we now know, was the last generation of its kind. It ended before most people noticed it was ending.

Work identity in the nineties was also relatively bounded. You had a job. The job was not, for most people, the core expression of their selfhood. You might find your work interesting, even occasionally meaningful, but the proposition that your employer should be your primary community, that work should be your central source of purpose and belonging, that a reasonable response to the question who are you? was a job title — these ideas were in their infancy. They would mature considerably in the decade that followed.

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[3] The concept of friction as a structurally important feature of social life is underappreciated. Many of the things we now experience as freedoms — the ability to send a message, make a purchase, or change a relationship status instantly — were previously subject to friction that created time for reflection, reconsideration, and the occasional beneficial change of mind. The removal of friction from human transactions has generally been understood as progress. It is worth asking, case by case, what the friction was doing.

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III. Through the Third Lens: 2026

The working life of 2026 is, in most developed economies, organised around three dominant facts.

The first is the collapse of the boundary between work and not-work.

The second is the AI transition, which is reshaping the labour market in real time, with consequences that range from the genuinely exciting to the genuinely alarming, depending primarily on which kind of work you do and how quickly your employer has noticed that a language model can do it for less.

The third is the housing-cost crisis, which has rearranged the relationship between work and financial security in ways that make the expectations of the nineties generation feel not just dated but faintly insulting.

We will take each in turn.

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The Boundary Problem

The smartphone did not merely make workers more accessible. It reconfigured the psychological architecture of the working day. When the office could follow you home in your pocket, the question of when you were working and when you were not became genuinely unanswerable — not because the answer was hidden, but because the category distinction had dissolved.

This is not, it should be noted, a problem distributed equally. The senior executive who checks email at midnight does so by choice, in the context of a career that rewards the performance of total commitment. The warehouse operative who must be available to accept or decline shift notifications within fifteen minutes, on a zero-hours contract, at any time of any day, does so by structural necessity. The gig economy worker — the delivery driver, the freelance graphic designer, the TaskRabbit contractor — operates in a labour market where availability is the product being sold, and where declining a job means declining income in a way that a salaried employee checking messages at the weekend does not.

The flexibility that the new economy promised is real, for those with enough leverage to use it. It is considerably less real for those without leverage, for whom flexibility is a euphemism for precarity: the freedom to choose which hours you work, constrained by the necessity of working as many of them as possible.[4]

The psychological consequences of the collapsed boundary are not, in the main, dramatic. They are cumulative and quiet. The work email read at nine in the evening does not ruin the evening. It simply means the evening is not fully the evening. The mind is partly at work. The body is at rest but the nervous system is not quite. The next morning arrives with a slightly shorter psychological runway. Over weeks, months, years, the margin between work and recovery narrows to a width that is not adequate for either.

The clinical term for what happens at the far end of this process is burnout, which has been a recognised occupational phenomenon since the 1970s but has reached, in the last decade, what researchers cautiously describe as epidemic prevalence.[5] Burnout is not tiredness. It is not even exhaustion, exactly. It is the specific condition of a person whose capacity for engagement — with work, with other people, with the texture of their own life — has been depleted past the point where rest alone can restore it. It is the condition of a system that has been running too hot for too long and has begun, in self-protection, to shut things down.

It is also, in the current working environment, something close to rational. The system is asking for too much. The system was designed without an off switch. The person responding to these conditions by gradually going offline is not malfunctioning. They are making the only adjustment available to them.

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[4] The distinction between flexibility and precarity is one of the more important conceptual tools in understanding the modern labour market. A useful heuristic: flexibility that you chose and can unchoose is flexibility. Flexibility that you accepted because the alternative was unemployment, and that you cannot easily revise, is precarity with better marketing.

[5] The WHO formally classified burnout as an occupational phenomenon — not a medical condition, but a factor influencing health — in 2019. This was widely reported as the WHO "recognising burnout as a disease," which is not quite what they said, but the gap between what they said and what was reported is itself a small study in the information environment we discussed in Chapter Two.

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The AI Question

Something is happening to work, and the pace at which it is happening makes it genuinely difficult to describe without the description being outdated by the time it is read.

The broad outlines are these. Artificial intelligence — specifically the large language models and generative systems that became publicly visible in late 2022 and have been advancing at a pace that surprised even the people building them — is capable of performing, at speed and scale, a range of cognitive tasks that were, until very recently, the exclusive province of human professionals. Writing. Analysis. Research. Basic legal work. Medical diagnosis support. Code. Design. Customer service. Financial modelling.

This does not mean that all these professions are ending. It means that the portion of these professions that consisted of routine cognitive tasks — the tasks that could be specified clearly enough to be automated — is being absorbed into AI systems, and the professionals in question are being repositioned as supervisors, editors, and handlers of the cases too complex or too unusual for the system to manage. This repositioning is not always well managed, not always compensated, and not always offered as a choice.[6]

The emotional experience of this transition, for the workers affected, is not primarily economic. It is existential. The question is not only will I have a job but what was the work for, if a system built in a data centre can do it faster and for less? The question is old — it has been asked at every technological transition since the introduction of the printing press — and it has always, eventually, resolved: the labour displaced by one technology found expression in the next. This is probably still true. The probably is doing more work in that sentence than it used to.

For younger workers entering the labour market now, the AI transition is not a disruption to an established career. It is the condition into which they are entering. They are being asked to develop expertise in fields that may look substantially different within the decade, using tools that are themselves changing quarterly, for employers who are themselves uncertain about what the stable configuration of their workforce will be. The anxiety this produces is not irrational. It is, under the circumstances, a reasonable response to genuine uncertainty, and it deserves something better than the advice to adapt, upskill, and embrace change that is currently being offered in its direction.

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[6] The economist Daron Acemoglu, in his 2024 book Power and Progress, argues that the direction of technological development is not predetermined — that the decision to automate some tasks rather than augment human capability in others is a choice, made by people with particular interests, and that different choices would produce different distributions of the gains. This is not an anti-technology argument. It is an argument about who technology is being built for. The question is worth asking, and worth asking repeatedly.

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Money, Housing, and the Broken Contract

In 1995, the median house price in England was approximately £61,000. The median full-time salary was approximately £18,000. The ratio was roughly 3.4 to one.

In 2026, the median house price in England is approximately £285,000. The median full-time salary is approximately £37,000. The ratio is approximately 7.7 to one, and in London it is rather higher than that.[7]

These are not simply numbers. They are the arithmetic of a generation's relationship to economic security. The deal that previous generations understood — work reliably, save prudently, own a home, retire adequately — is no longer available to most people under forty on a single professional income in the major cities of the English-speaking world. This is not a personal failure. It is a structural shift, produced by a combination of planning restrictions, low interest rates that inflated asset prices over two decades, and a tax system that treats property investment more favourably than labour.

The psychological consequences of living in a labour market where your income is precarious, your housing is unaffordable, and the future that was promised to you has been quietly withdrawn are significant and, in the main, not adequately addressed by the advice to practice gratitude and maintain a positive mindset.[8] Financial anxiety is the most common form of anxiety in the developed world, and it is, uniquely among the major anxiety categories, grounded in a reality that meditation does not change.

This is worth stating clearly, because a significant portion of the wellness discourse that surrounds economic anxiety treats it as a psychological problem amenable to psychological solutions — as if the person who cannot afford to heat their flat simply needs to reframe their relationship to scarcity. They do not. They need the flat to cost less, or their income to be more, or both. The psychological tools we offer in the navigation section of this chapter are for the anxiety that surrounds economic difficulty, not substitutes for addressing the difficulty itself.

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[7] The figures are from UK ONS data and Halifax House Price Index. The regional variation is significant: the ratio in London and the South East is considerably higher than the national average, and in some areas of Northern England and Wales it remains close to or below the 1995 national ratio. The housing crisis is not uniform. It is, however, directional.

[8] This is not a critique of gratitude practice, which has genuine and well-evidenced psychological benefits. It is a critique of the application of gratitude practice as a response to structural economic problems — a category error that has become, in certain corners of the wellness industry, something close to an ideological position.

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IV. The Meaning Problem

There is a question underneath all of the above that is harder to put numbers on but may be more important than any of them.

What is work for?

In 1920, for most people, the answer was immediate and not especially philosophical: work was how you fed yourself and your family. The meaning of work was its function. It kept you alive and, if you were fortunate, modestly comfortable. This is not an inspiring answer, but it is a stable one. It does not require work to be fulfilling, self-expressive, or aligned with your deepest values. It requires it to pay.

Somewhere in the second half of the twentieth century, in the prosperous economies of the developed world, work acquired additional requirements. It was supposed to be interesting. Then fulfilling. Then, in the early years of the tech economy, with its ping-pong tables and its flat hierarchies and its persistent suggestion that the office was where you went to change the world, work was supposed to be the primary site of personal meaning.

This is a significant burden to place on a contractual arrangement between a person and an organisation.

The passion economy — the cultural injunction to find work you love, to follow your bliss into a career, to never work a day in your life — has been examined by several researchers and found wanting, not because passion is bad but because making passion a prerequisite of legitimate work delegitimises the enormous quantity of necessary work that is not passionate and cannot be made so.[9] The nurse who works twelve-hour shifts in an understaffed ward, the warehouse worker who scans packages for eight hours, the care worker who washes and feeds elderly people who are frightened and sometimes unkind — these people may find meaning in their work, and many do, but the source of that meaning is not passion for the task. It is something older and more durable: the knowledge that the work matters, that someone needed it done, that it was done well.

This is, it turns out, an adequate source of meaning for most people, and considerably more achievable than the instruction to find your calling and pursue it with everything you have. The meaning of work is not located primarily in how it feels. It is located in what it does — what it makes, who it serves, what it sustains. The carpenter who makes furniture that lasts, the teacher who teaches a child to read, the plumber who fixes the leak at midnight — these people are not required to be passionate about their work to find it meaningful. They are required to do it well, and to know why it matters.

In an economy organised around the performance of productivity, the maintenance of availability, and the persistent suggestion that your output is the measure of your value as a person, this older and more robust relationship to work is difficult to sustain. But it is there, and it is recoverable, and recovering it is one of the more useful things this chapter can suggest.

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[9] Cal Newport, in So Good They Can't Ignore You(2012), makes the argument that the "passion hypothesis" — find what you love and make it your career — not only fails as practical advice but actively harms people by directing them away from the development of valuable skills and toward an impossible standard of permanent emotional fulfilment at work. The book's title is, admittedly, less calming than its content.

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V. Gender and Work

The working lives of men and women in 2026 are, in many respects, more similar than at any previous point in history. Women make up approximately half the workforce in most developed economies. The legal framework of equal employment has existed, in most of these economies, for several decades. The blatant exclusions of 1920 are, formally at least, gone.

They have been replaced by subtler ones.

The gender pay gap — the aggregate difference in earnings between men and women across the economy — persists at between fifteen and twenty percent in most developed countries, depending on how it is measured and which industries are included.[10] The causes are complex and disputed. Some portion is explained by occupational segregation: the fact that professions dominated by women (care work, nursing, early childhood education, social work) are systemically undervalued relative to those dominated by men. Some is explained by the career interruptions associated with childbirth and primary parenting, which fall disproportionately on women in most households. Some is explained by negotiation behaviour, by unconscious bias in promotion decisions, and by the structural design of organisations around the assumption of an unencumbered worker — someone who does not have primary responsibility for the care of children, elderly parents, or anyone else — which continues, in most large organisations, to be assumed to be male.

The domestic labour issue is still present and still unresolved. Studies consistently find that in households where both partners are employed full-time, women perform more unpaid domestic and care work than men — a finding that has been replicated across countries, decades, and political systems with a reliability that suggests it is not primarily a cultural anomaly but a deeply embedded structural pattern.[11] The second shift has not ended. It has been partially repackaged as a choice.

For men, the working landscape of 2026 presents a different set of pressures. The decline of manual and industrial employment — the sectors that provided not just income but identity and community to men with lower educational attainment — has not been adequately replaced in cultural or economic terms. The labour market has shifted toward cognitive and service work, which is more accessible to those with credentials and less accessible to those without, creating a significant group of men who are structurally disadvantaged in the new economy and for whom the traditional framework of masculine worth — provider, builder, fixer — has become difficult to inhabit. The consequences are visible in mental health statistics, in educational underperformance, and in the susceptibility to the online ideologies that offer simple explanations for complex economic disappointments.

Neither the feminist analysis nor the analysis of male disadvantage cancels the other. They are both true. They are also, if examined carefully, products of the same underlying structure: an economy and a culture that has not yet worked out what it believes about the value of different kinds of work, the fair distribution of domestic labour, or what men and women owe each other in the domain of paid and unpaid contribution. These are not small questions. They are not close to being settled.

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[10] The ONS publishes annual gender pay gap data for the UK; comparable data exists for all OECD countries. The figures depend significantly on whether you measure the gap in median hourly earnings, mean hourly earnings, or total annual income — each of which tells a somewhat different story. The consistent finding across all measures is that the gap exists, has narrowed over the past fifty years, and has not closed.

[11] The most recent comprehensive international data on this is from the OECD's time-use surveys, which collect information on how people in different countries spend their days. The finding — that women in virtually every country surveyed perform more unpaid household and care work than men, regardless of their employment status — has been consistent since the surveys began.

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VI. The Attention Problem at Work

We spent a chapter on attention, and we will not retread it entirely. But the attention problem has a specific workplace manifestation that deserves its own brief examination.

The contemporary knowledge worker is, on most measures, less productive per hour than their equivalent from thirty years ago, despite having access to tools of extraordinary power.[12] The reason, on the available evidence, is interruption. The average knowledge worker is interrupted approximately every three minutes during the working day. After each interruption, it takes an average of twenty-three minutes to fully return to the task that was interrupted. The arithmetic of this is not encouraging.

The specific mechanisms are email, instant messaging, and the cultural norm of rapid response that both have generated. The email that arrives mid-morning and sits unread until lunch is experienced, by most people, not as a deferred task but as an active presence — a low-level awareness that something is waiting, that needs to be checked, that might be urgent. This background hum of unprocessed communication consumes attentional resources even when it is not being actively addressed.

The open-plan office — which became the dominant workspace design of the early twenty-first century on the theory that proximity would promote collaboration and innovation — has contributed significantly to this problem. Open-plan offices are, on most measures, noisier, more interruptive, and less conducive to concentrated work than the cellular offices they replaced, and the research suggesting this has been available for over a decade.[13] They have remained the dominant design because they are cheaper to fit out and because the language of collaboration makes them easy to defend. Collaboration is genuinely valuable. Concentration is also genuinely valuable. The open-plan office optimises for neither and averages down from both.

Remote work — which the pandemic normalised at a scale no policy could have achieved — partially solved the interruption problem and entirely created the boundary problem. The home office is quieter than the open-plan floor. It is also adjacent to the rest of your life in a way that makes the separation of work from not-work, which was previously maintained by geography, now a matter of personal discipline. Personal discipline is not an unlimited resource.

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[12] This is a contested area, because productivity measurement in knowledge work is notoriously difficult — what are the units? — and the tools available to knowledge workers in 2026 are genuinely more powerful than those available in 1996. The claim is not that individuals are lazier but that the attentional environment is more destructive of the focused work that productivity depends on. Cal Newport's Deep Work(2016) makes the case most clearly and with the most practical specificity.

[13] The most frequently cited study is probably a 2018 paper by Ethan Bernstein and Stephen Turban, published in Philosophical Transactions of the Royal Society B, which used electronic monitoring to track actual interactions in offices before and after conversion to open-plan layout and found that face-to-face interaction decreased by approximately seventy percent after the transition, as people put on headphones and retreated into digital communication. The open-plan office, designed to increase interaction, was producing less of it. This was reported in the business press, briefly, and then filed under findings-we-are-not-going-to-act-on.

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Navigation: The Tools for This Chapter

Psychologically: Define the edges of your working day and defend them with the seriousness you would bring to any other important commitment. This is not advice about work-life balance — a phrase so thoroughly colonised by corporate wellness programmes that it has lost most of its meaning — but about cognitive architecture. The working mind needs a beginning and an end in order to work well. Without edges, it does not expand to fill the available time productively. It seeps, thinly and inefficiently, across all available time, producing the feeling of always working alongside the reality of working poorly.

A practical starting point: choose a time at which work ends. Not a time at which you stop being at your desk, but a time at which you close the applications, put the phone somewhere else, and are no longer available to work-related communication. Treat violations of this boundary with the same slight guilt you would bring to breaking any other important commitment, and use that guilt as information: something in the structure needs adjusting, not the boundary.

Physically: The body, in the contemporary working life, is primarily a vehicle for transporting a brain to and from a desk. It has, on the whole, views about this arrangement that are not adequately consulted. The minimum requirement, for a body that spends six to eight hours per day seated, is movement that is not incidental — not the walk to the coffee machine, not the commute — but deliberate. Thirty minutes of sustained movement, daily, has more evidence behind it than any supplement, any cognitive training programme, or any workplace wellness initiative currently being offered. Get outside if possible. The combination of movement, natural light, and the mild attentional restoration that natural environments provide is, per hour of investment, the most cost-effective intervention available to the knowledge worker.

For those who work at desks: the standing desk is helpful if used properly, which means alternating between sitting and standing rather than standing all day, which is its own variety of physical stress. The most useful single postural intervention is probably the simplest: once an hour, stand up, look at something at least six metres away for twenty seconds, and take three deliberate breaths. This takes approximately ninety seconds. It costs nothing. It will not transform your working life. It will, if done consistently, prevent the slow accumulation of physical tension that by four in the afternoon has made you rigid, headachey, and less capable of the work still remaining.

Spiritually: Work is not your identity, regardless of how thoroughly the working culture of the last thirty years has tried to persuade you otherwise. You are not your job title, your output metrics, your LinkedIn summary, or your employer's annual revenue. You are, among other things, a person who does some work — work that may be interesting or tedious, well-paid or not, recognised or invisible — and that work is one part of a life, not the other way around.

This sounds obvious. It is not, in practice, easy to maintain. The economic pressures of 2026 make work feel like the only secure ground in an insecure landscape, and the cultural pressures make the failure to be passionate about it feel like a personal deficiency. Neither of these is true, and both of them will be present anyway.

The older relationship to work — as a form of service, as the exercise of a skill in the world's direction, as the thing you do well and reliably and with care, without requiring it to complete you — is not naïve or resigned. It is, if anything, more robust than the passionate-purpose model, because it does not depend on the work being permanently rewarding in order to be permanently worth doing. The carpenter does not need to love every plank. They need to make it level.

Find, if you can, the version of your work that is about what it does rather than how it makes you feel. Ask who it serves. Ask what it makes. Ask what would be worse if it were not done. The answers to these questions are more durable than the answer to does this fulfil me? — which changes with the weather, and always will.

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Next: Chapter Four — Love and Intimacy: Hearts in the Network

In which we discover that the dating app, while a genuine feat of engineering, has approached the problem of human longing with roughly the same sensitivity as a spreadsheet approaches the problem of love.

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Chapter Four: Love and Intimacy — Hearts in the Network

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There is a well-known psychological experiment in which subjects are offered a choice between two jams. Offered two options, most people choose one without particular difficulty. Offered twenty-four options, most people experience significant decision paralysis, make a choice with less confidence than in the two-jam condition, and report lower satisfaction with the jam they selected — even if it is, objectively, excellent jam.[1]

The dating app is the jam experiment, conducted on human beings, at scale, with feelings.

This is not a frivolous comparison. The paradox of choice — the finding that an abundance of options does not improve decision-making but frequently impairs it, by raising the implicit standard against which any particular choice is measured — has been replicated across dozens of contexts, and it applies with unusual force to the domain of romantic selection, where the stakes are higher than jam and the tendency to wonder whether something better might be available is both universal and, in the swipe economy, actively encouraged.

We have built, in the dating app, an instrument of extraordinary efficiency for generating the experience of romantic abundance while simultaneously making it harder to choose, harder to commit, and harder to tolerate the inevitable ordinariness of any real relationship when the phone in your pocket contains, notionally, several thousand alternatives. This was not the intention. It was the outcome. The engineers were solving the problem of how to meet people. They did not notice, or did not fully consider, that the problem of meeting people and the problem of loving someone are different problems that happen, sometimes, to overlap.

In this chapter we will examine what has happened to love, intimacy, and friendship across the three lenses — and what the current arrangement is doing to our capacity for the kind of connection that the human animal, by every available measure, cannot do without.

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[1] The jam study is the work of psychologists Sheena Iyengar and Mark Lepper, published in 2000. The finding — that more choice produces less satisfaction — has been contested and refined in subsequent research, but the core phenomenon is robust. The psychologist Barry Schwartz named it "the paradox of choice" in his 2004 book of the same name, which managed to be simultaneously about jam, consumer goods, and the existential condition of modernity. As most good books are, to some degree.

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I. Through the First Lens: 1920

Courtship in 1920 was, by modern standards, a process of almost geological slowness, conducted largely in public, under varying degrees of social supervision, and with consequences — social, familial, financial — that gave it a weight the contemporary first date has largely been relieved of.

You met the people you might love in the places where your life already was. The parish. The workplace. The dance hall on a Saturday evening, where the choice of partner was determined not by an algorithm but by who happened to be standing nearby and whether they would dance with you when you asked, which was its own unpredictable system with its own particular anxieties.[2] The pool of candidates was small — defined by geography, class, religion, and the intersection of family social networks — which is a significant constraint by any modern standard and also, functionally, a significant simplification.

The smallness of the pool had consequences. It meant you were likely to know, or to be able to find out, a great deal about any person you were considering before the relationship progressed very far. It meant that the people around you knew them too, and had views, and would express those views, invited or not. It meant that the choice was made with reference to a shared context of which both parties were aware.

It also meant, in practical terms, that the decision to enter a formal courtship was a more serious step than the decision to match with someone on an app, and was understood to be. You did not, typically, court someone casually. The social cost of beginning something and not completing it was real for both parties, and more real for women, for whom a failed courtship carried a reputational weight that it did not carry for men. This asymmetry was unjust. It also gave the process a seriousness of intent that the swipe lacks.

Physical intimacy before marriage was not absent — the historical evidence suggests that it was considerably more present than the official moral framework of the period acknowledged — but it was conducted within a social architecture that made it consequential, which is not the same as saying it made it happy, or free, or particularly enlightened about the desires of women.[3]

Love letters existed. They are, in the archives, extraordinary. The slowness of correspondence — the days between sending and receiving — meant that the letter had to carry everything: feeling, intention, information, the texture of daily life. People who wrote them became, by necessity, writers. They made arguments. They made jokes. They described what they saw and thought and wanted with a precision that the instant message, which arrives before the thought has finished forming, cannot replicate and has not replaced.

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[2] The social anxiety of asking someone to dance in 1920 is not, it should be noted, a vanished experience. It has been precisely reproduced, with minor modifications, in the experience of sending the first message on a dating app — the awareness of potential rejection, the calculation of how to present yourself advantageously while remaining recognisably yourself. Human beings turn out to be remarkably consistent across technological transitions.

[3] The social historian Claire Langhamer's work on love and courtship in twentieth-century Britain is among the most careful and most readable accounts of what romantic life actually looked like across the period. Her finding that ordinary people's internal experience of love was considerably richer and more nuanced than the cultural frameworks available to express it is probably not surprising. It is, however, worth stating.

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II. Through the Second Lens: 1995–2006

By the mid-nineties, the social architecture of courtship had loosened considerably. The dance hall had become the bar and the nightclub. Marriage was no longer the presumed destination of a relationship from its early stages. Cohabitation before marriage had normalised. The women's liberation movement had, over several decades, shifted the legal and cultural framework of relationships enough that women could, in most of the developed world, own property, maintain financial independence, and leave a relationship that was not working without the same social and economic consequences that had made such decisions catastrophic in 1920.

These are genuine gains. They are worth naming as such before noting what else was happening.

What was also happening, in the late nineties, was that the mobile phone was beginning to complicate the temporal structure of romantic communication. The text message introduced a new intimacy — brief, casual, immediate, available at any hour — and with it a new set of anxieties. The text that had not been replied to. The deliberate ambiguity of a message that could mean several things and whose meaning was now being analysed, by its recipient, for longer than its composition had taken. The question of when it was appropriate to text, how often, at what hour, with what degree of apparent nonchalance — questions that the letter-writing tradition had resolved through convention over centuries, and that the text message had reset to zero.

Friendship in the late nineties was still primarily local and primarily physical. The friends you had were the people in your immediate life — your school, your workplace, your neighbourhood, the regulars at the pub you used. The maintenance of friendship required presence: showing up, making plans, being in the same room. The phone call was long and sometimes embarrassing in the way that extended telephone conversations can be when you have run out of things to say but neither party wants to be the one to end it. Email was beginning to supplement the postcard for distant friendships. Neither had yet developed the always-available, always-on character that would define the next decade.

Loneliness existed. Depression existed. Relationship breakdown existed at rates that were not, by contemporary standards, low. The nineties were not a golden age of interpersonal wellbeing. But the structures through which people connected to each other — the physical third places, the unscheduled encounters, the conversations that happened because you were both in the same room and there was time to fill — were still largely intact, and would remain so for perhaps another decade.

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III. Through the Third Lens: 2026

Dating

There are, in 2026, approximately three hundred and fifty million people using dating apps globally.[4] This number is both enormous and, in the context of what it represents, slightly melancholy. Three hundred and fifty million people have concluded — reasonably, given the alternatives available to them — that the best available technology for solving the problem of human loneliness is a sorting algorithm.

The algorithm does not know what you are looking for. It knows what you say you are looking for, which is different, and it knows what your behaviour suggests you are looking for, which is different again, and it optimises for the thing most likely to keep you using the platform, which is different from all of the above.

The dating app is not, despite its marketing, in the business of finding you a partner. It is in the business of finding you enough almost-partners to keep you swiping. A partner, once found, leaves the platform. A user who hasn't quite found one yet stays, and stays, and stays.[5]

The swipe mechanic — right for yes, left for no — reduces the initial assessment of a potential partner to approximately one second of visual evaluation. This is not, researchers have found, dramatically worse than the initial assessment made in a room — humans form first impressions in fractions of a second and these impressions are not obviously improved by longer exposure in the early stages. But the swipe strips the assessment of every dimension except the visual, and it happens so quickly, and at such volume, that it trains the evaluative faculty in a direction that may not be helpful when you are sitting across a table from an actual person who is more complicated than their photographs suggested.

Ghosting — the practice of ending a relationship, or the early stages of one, by simply ceasing to communicate without explanation — has become so common in app-mediated dating that it is no longer considered remarkable, which is itself remarkable.[6] It is the behavioural expression of a structural feature: when the other person is a profile rather than someone embedded in your social world, the social cost of disappearing is close to zero. They cannot tell your mutual friends, because you have no mutual friends. They cannot see you at the pub, because you don't share a pub. They are, in the architecture of the app, essentially strangers who happen to have exchanged photographs and some messages, and the ending of a relationship with a stranger carries less weight than the ending of one with someone whose reality is more present to you.

This is psychologically consequential for both parties, but differently. The person who disappears is exercising a freedom that the digital environment makes available, at the cost of a small normalisation of treating other people as discardable. The person who is disappeared on is experiencing a specific and unresolved pain — the absence of closure, the inability to make sense of an ending that was given no form — for which the social framework of 2026 has not yet developed an adequate response. There is no ritual for being ghosted. There is no community acknowledgement. There is only the rereading of messages for clues, in the small hours, with the algorithm waiting patiently just below the surface, ready to offer more options.

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[4] Statista puts the global dating app user base at approximately 370 million in 2025, projected to rise. Tinder alone has been downloaded over 530 million times. These figures are cited not because they are precise — dating app usage statistics are notoriously difficult to verify — but because the order of magnitude is informative. This is a very large number of people looking for love on their phones.

[5] Several former dating app employees have said versions of this publicly. The clearest formulation comes from a 2022 interview with a former product designer, who noted that the incentive structure of subscription-based dating apps creates a direct financial interest in users not finding permanent partners. Whether this actually shapes product decisions varies by company and is genuinely contested. The structural incentive exists regardless.

[6] A 2019 survey by YouGov found that approximately one in four British adults had been ghosted by a romantic interest. Comparable figures exist for North America and Australia. The figure is higher among younger adults and among app users specifically.

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Intimacy at a Distance

There is a question that the dating app era has raised, quietly and without much public discussion, about what intimacy actually is.

The traditional model — physical proximity, shared experience over time, mutual vulnerability progressively disclosed — has not disappeared. It has been supplemented by forms of intimacy that look quite different and whose emotional reality is not, on the available evidence, less real for being differently structured.

People fall in love over text. People maintain genuine and important relationships entirely through digital communication, across distances that would have made those relationships impossible in 1920. People find, in online communities, a quality of understanding and acceptance that their immediate physical environment has not provided. The person whose particular configuration of identity, interest, or experience makes them anomalous in their immediate geography can, in 2026, find people like them anywhere in the world. This is not nothing. In many cases it is everything.

The question is not whether digital intimacy is real — it is — but whether it is adequate on its own. The body has requirements that text cannot meet. Physical presence — the quality of someone's voice in a room, the way they move, the unrepeatable specificity of being near another person — communicates information that no medium yet invented can fully transmit. Touch communicates things that no word can say, and the absence of touch, sustained over time, produces a specific kind of hunger that is well documented in developmental psychology and not adequately addressed in the architecture of remote relationships.[7]

The long-distance relationship, sustained entirely digitally, is a genuine relationship and is not being dismissed here. It is being observed with care, because the people in it deserve honest acknowledgement of what it costs as well as honest acknowledgement of what it provides.

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[7] The developmental literature on touch and attachment begins with the work of Harry Harlow on infant monkeys in the 1950s and extends through John Bowlby's attachment theory to contemporary research on skin-to-skin contact, therapeutic touch, and the physiological effects of physical proximity between bonded individuals. The consistent finding, across this entire body of work, is that the need for physical contact is not a cultural preference but a biological one, and its absence has measurable physiological and psychological consequences. We have, as a species, known this for approximately seventy years and have not yet built it into the design of our communication systems.

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IV. Friendship

Friendship is, in some ways, the orphan of the self-improvement discourse. There are libraries of books about romantic love, about marriage, about the parent-child relationship. There is a relative silence about friendship — about how it works, what it requires, what happens when it doesn't, and why it matters in ways that are not reducible to its emotional pleasures.

What it requires, in its healthy form, is time, consistency, and a willingness to be present for someone in ways that are not always convenient. These requirements are in structural tension with the contemporary life, which offers less time than previous generations had, rewards consistency of output over consistency of presence, and provides, through the phone, an always-available alternative to the sometimes-inconvenient demands of actual people.

The number of close friendships reported by adults in the developed world has declined steadily since the 1980s. The most frequently cited statistic — from a 2021 survey by the Survey Center on American Life — found that fifteen percent of men reported having no close friends, up from three percent in 1990.[8] The figure for women is lower but rising. The pattern is consistent across most developed countries and across age groups, though it is most acute among men in middle age and most acute of all among men who have recently experienced a major life transition: divorce, redundancy, relocation, retirement.

Why men specifically? Because male friendship, as it has been culturally constructed in most of the developed world, is activity-based rather than disclosure-based. Men tend to form and maintain friendships through doing things together — sport, work, shared practical projects — rather than through the direct expression of feeling and mutual vulnerability that characterises the friendship culture more common among women. This is not a failing. It is a different architecture, with different strengths and different vulnerabilities. The vulnerability is this: when the activity ends — when the job changes, the children grow up, the football knees give out — the friendship often has no other structure to fall back on. The men who were close at work discover, when the workplace is gone, that they do not quite know how to be close without it.[9]

Women's friendships are not without their own complications. The intimacy that characterises them at their best — the directness, the mutual support, the willingness to discuss difficulty — can also produce, at their worst, a social intensity that is difficult to sustain and painful to exit. The relational aggression documented in female social groups — the exclusion, the reputation management, the indirect conflict — is real, and the social media environment has given it new and more precise instruments. The Instagram group chat that falls suddenly silent. The story that everyone has been tagged in except you. These are small violences, and they accumulate.

Online friendship is a genuine thing. The communities that form around shared interests — gaming, creative work, political commitment, identity — can provide real belonging to people who do not find it easily in their immediate geography. But online friendship is subject to the same structural problem as parasocial relationship: it is easier than the real thing in ways that may, over time, reduce the appetite and the capacity for the real thing. The friend you only know through text is a friend from whom you can disengage by closing a window. The friend in the same room cannot be closed.

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[8] The Survey Center on American Life published this data in May 2021, in a report titled "The State of American Friendship: Change, Challenges, and Loss." The full dataset is worth examining in detail; the headline figure on male friendlessness is striking but the broader picture — a consistent decline in social connection across gender, age group, and political affiliation — is more striking still.

[9] The sociologist Ray Pahl, in his 2000 book On Friendship, distinguishes between "contextual" friends (formed within a shared context and maintained by it) and "pure" friends (maintained independent of shared context, through mutual choice). His argument — that the shift toward more mobile, individual lives has eroded contextual friendship without always replacing it with pure friendship — has aged well.

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V. Gender, Vulnerability, and the Architecture of Connection

The difference between how men and women tend to relate to intimacy and connection is one of the more reliably documented patterns in social psychology, and also one of the most frequently misused — cited as evidence either for biological determinism ("men are just like that") or dismissed as cultural stereotype that serves nobody. Both responses miss the point.

The patterns are real. They are also contextually produced and not fixed. They can be changed — by individuals, by relationships, by cultures that decide to value different things. But they cannot be changed without being acknowledged, and acknowledging them clearly is one of the things this book is committed to doing.

Women, on average, tend to form deeper emotional bonds with more people, express vulnerability more readily in friendship, and use conversation as a primary mode of both connection and distress regulation. This produces richer social support networks and also, in the social media environment, greater exposure to social comparison and relational distress: the hurt of being excluded, the pain of a public falling-out, the specific misery of watching other people's friendships on Instagram and finding your own lacking.[10]

Men, on average, tend toward smaller friendship networks with less explicit emotional content, use activity as the primary medium of connection, and experience significant cultural pressure against the expression of vulnerability — a pressure so consistent and so early-installed that many men are genuinely uncertain whether they have an inner emotional life of the kind that the vulnerability literature describes, or whether they are simply not describing the one they have. The male suicide rate — which is approximately three times the female rate in most developed countries — is the most extreme expression of the cost of this uncertainty, and it is worth naming without softening.[11]

The navigation of intimacy in 2026, for both men and women, requires some conscious effort to move against the defaults that the environment has set. For women, that effort is often toward less social comparison, less social media, less of the surveillance of others that produces the particular misery of knowing too much about other people's curated versions of their lives. For men, it is often toward more — more explicit communication about what they feel and need, more willingness to maintain friendships through effort rather than waiting for shared context to do it automatically, more permission to ask for help in ways the culture did not teach them to ask.

None of this is easy. All of it is possible. The Navigation section that follows is addressed equally to both, with the understanding that the specific obstacles differ.

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[10] The Pew Research Center's 2025 report on teens and social media found that girls were significantly more likely than boys to report negative experiences on social media, including being made to feel bad about their appearance, feeling left out, and being targeted by rumours. The report also found that girls

were more likely to report positive experiences — feeling supported, finding communities of shared interest — which is consistent with the bidirectional nature of the relationship between social media and social comparison.

[11] The Samaritans' annual Suicide Statistics Report consistently shows that men account for approximately three-quarters of all suicides in the UK. The figure is similar across most high-income countries. The relationship between male loneliness, limited help-seeking behaviour, and this statistic is well established in the research literature and represents one of the clearest public health consequences of the cultural architecture of male emotional life.

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VI. The New Pressures

Two aspects of intimacy in 2026 require specific attention because they are new enough that the cultural frameworks for navigating them are still forming, and the people most affected — primarily, though not exclusively, young people — are navigating them largely without maps.

Sexting and image-based intimacy. The sending of intimate images between consenting adults is neither new nor inherently harmful. What is new is its normalisation among increasingly young people, the technical permanence of digital images, and the emergence of image-based sexual abuse — the non-consensual sharing of intimate images, historically called revenge porn and now more accurately termed image-based abuse — as one of the more prevalent and underreported forms of online harm.

Approximately one in four young people has sent a sexually explicit image of themselves.[12] The image, once sent, is outside the sender's control. This is not a reason to catastrophise, but it is a reason to think, and it is a reason that the cultural conversation about digital intimacy has not yet produced adequate guidance for young people — partly because that conversation is still being held primarily by adults who are embarrassed, by platforms that are legally exposed, and by schools that don't have a curriculum for it.

We will address this more specifically in Chapter Five, in the context of parenting and adolescence. Here it is enough to note that the body, in the digital environment, has become a form of communication in ways that carry risks that were not present when communication required physical presence — and that those risks fall disproportionately on young women, who are more likely both to send images under social pressure and to be harmed by their subsequent misuse.

AI companionship. There are, in 2026, several commercially available AI companions — conversational systems designed to provide the experience of emotional connection, to listen without judgement, to remember what you said last time, to be there at three in the morning when there is no one else.[13] Several million people use them regularly. For some — the isolated, the grieving, the socially anxious — they provide something genuinely useful. For others, they are providing, in high fidelity, the experience of being listened to and understood, without the person.

The question this raises is not whether AI companionship is real in some technical sense. It is whether a need that is met by a simulation of connection diminishes the urgency of seeking the real thing. Whether the edge is taken off the loneliness in ways that reduce the motivation to address its cause. Whether we are, in providing the experience of intimacy without the cost of it, doing something that helps people or something that helps them stay exactly where they are.

The answer is probably both, for different people at different stages. The concern is worth naming. It does not require a verdict.

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[12] The figure is from research by Florida Atlantic University, published in 2019, which found that approximately twenty-eight percent of the young people surveyed had sent a sext. The figure varies by age, gender, and platform use, and has likely increased in the years since the study was conducted.

[13] The largest AI companion platforms — Replika, Character.AI, and several others — collectively have tens of millions of registered users. The companies are explicit about the emotional function of their products. The FDA, various national regulators, and the academic research community are, as of 2026, still working out what regulatory framework, if any, should govern them.

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Navigation: The Tools for This Chapter

Psychologically: The most useful single concept for navigating modern intimacy is probably differentiated attachment — the capacity to want connection without requiring it on specific terms. Loneliness is not the absence of people. It is the absence of people who know you. The distinction matters, because the response to the first problem (go to more places, use the app) is different from the response to the second (be more knowable, which requires being more known, which requires disclosure, which requires risk). Most of the default solutions to loneliness in 2026 address the first problem while leaving the second untouched.

A practical suggestion: identify one relationship in your life that you would like to be deeper than it currently is. Not necessarily a romantic relationship — a friendship, a family connection, a colleague you like but don't know well. Take one small step toward depth: ask a question you haven't asked before, share something you haven't shared, suggest doing something together that isn't a group event. The compound interest of small steps toward real connection is the best available return on social investment.

Physically: Friendship, like most things that matter, is maintained by showing up. Not metaphorically — actually, physically showing up. This is more difficult in 2026 than it was in 1995, for reasons of geography, busyness, and the availability of lower-effort alternatives. It is not less important. Schedule the thing. Put it in the calendar. Treat the cancellation of it with the same reluctance you would bring to cancelling a medical appointment, because the evidence that social connection is a health matter of the first order is, at this point, overwhelming enough that treating it as optional is a category error.

For those for whom existing social infrastructure is thin — who have moved, or changed jobs, or emerged from a long relationship to find the friendship network has contracted — the most evidence-supported method of building new connection is repeated unplanned contact in a shared context. A class, a club, a choir, a running group, a local volunteer role. Not because these are guaranteed to produce friendship — they are not — but because they create the conditions in which friendship happens: regular presence, shared activity, the slow accumulation of small interactions that, over time, become the material of knowing someone.

Spiritually: Love, in its deeper sense, is not primarily an emotion. It is a practice — a decision, renewed daily, to remain present to another person's reality rather than to the version of them that is most convenient to you. This is harder than it sounds, and it is harder in an environment that offers, at every moment, the option of a less demanding form of engagement.

The oldest wisdom traditions agree on this with a consistency that is worth noticing. Love as practice rather than feeling: the choice to attend, to care, to remain. Not the absence of feeling — feeling is part of it — but the recognition that feeling alone is an insufficient structure for the sustained thing that actual love requires. The infatuation is real. It is also, neurologically, temporary, and when it subsides it leaves either the practice or nothing.

This does not mean settling. It does not mean staying in relationships that are harmful or joyless. It means understanding that the moment when love stops being effortless is not the moment it ends. It is, very often, the moment it begins.

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Next: Chapter Five — Raising Children, Raising Selves: Parenting and Teens

In which we acknowledge that parenting has always been difficult, that 2026 has found some inventive new ways to make it more so, and that the teenager in your house is navigating a social world that did not exist when you were their age and for which neither of you was given a map.

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Chapter Five: Raising Children, Raising Selves — Parenting and Teens

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Let us begin with a small act of honesty that most parenting books prefer to avoid.

Nobody knows what they are doing.

Not the parents who appear to have it together at school pick-up — the ones with the calm voices and the children who sit nicely and the faint air of having read the right books. Not the child psychologists, who have frameworks for most things but are also parents, and know the distance between the framework and the kitchen at seven in the morning when nobody will eat the breakfast and someone has lost a shoe. Not the people writing books about parenting, who are, without exception, working from incomplete data on a subject that will not sit still long enough to be studied properly, because the children keep growing and the world keeps changing and the goalposts are not merely moving but being replaced, periodically, with entirely different sporting equipment.

This has always been true. What is new, in 2026, is the particular character of the unknowing. Previous generations of parents did not know what they were doing, but they were not knowing it in a world that most of them had grown up in, which gave them at least the advantage of familiarity with the terrain. The parent of a teenager in 2026 is attempting to guide a young person through a social world that did not exist when that parent was a teenager, using instincts developed in a different landscape, toward a future that neither of them can clearly see.

This is not a crisis. It is a situation. Situations, unlike crises, can be navigated — slowly, imperfectly, with frequent recalibration and the occasional frank admission that you have no idea what to do next. The warm coach does not pretend to have all the answers. The warm coach has been on enough pitches to know which questions to ask.

This chapter is the longest in the book. It earns that length. The raising of children is, among the things human beings do, one of the most consequential and the most under-resourced, and the particular pressures of 2026 — on parents, on teenagers, and on the space between them — are significant enough to deserve serious and specific attention.

We will move through the landscape in sections: the digital architecture of family life, the specific social world of teenagers, gender and adolescence, practical tools for parents, and practical tools for teenagers themselves. The last category matters. Teenagers are not merely the subject of this chapter. They are its audience too.[1]

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[1] If you are a teenager reading this: the chapter was written with you in mind, not just your parents. The sections addressed to parents are about you but not to you. The rest is both. You will know which parts feel true and which feel like they were written by someone who has been a teenager but cannot quite remember what it was actually like. Please be patient with the latter. We are doing our best.

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I. The Digital Architecture of Family Life

There is a scene that plays out in households across the developed world, several times per day, in which a parent tells a child to put down a screen, and the child does not, and the parent tells them again, and the child does not, and the parent confiscates the device, and the child reacts to this as if something has been taken from them of approximately the same significance as oxygen.

The parent, observing this reaction, reaches one of two conclusions: either the child is catastrophically addicted and something must be done immediately, or the child is being dramatically manipulative and something must also be done, though a different something. Both conclusions, while understandable, are slightly wrong. They are both based on the assumption that the child's relationship to the screen is a behavioural problem, amenable to behavioural solutions.

The relationship to the screen is not primarily a behavioural problem. It is, as we established in Chapter Two, a neurological one. The phone or tablet or console is delivering something that the brain values highly — stimulation, social connection, reward, the satisfaction of skill in gaming, the dopamine of notification — and the removal of it is experienced, by the brain, as the removal of something it needs. This does not mean the child is right that they need it, in the way that you need food and water. It means that the brain has learned to want it with the same intensity, which is a different and considerably more solvable problem, but a problem that will not be solved by confiscation alone.

The confiscation model — ban the device, enforce the rule, win the battle — has several documented problems as a long-term parenting strategy for the digital age. The first is that it treats the symptom without addressing the underlying need the device is meeting. The child who is using their phone to manage social anxiety, or to maintain friendships that matter deeply to them, or to have the only private space available to them in a busy household, will not stop needing those things when the phone is taken away. They will find other ways to meet the need, or they will not meet it, and the unmet need will show up elsewhere.

The second problem is trust. Adolescence is, among its other qualities, the developmental period in which the child is constructing an identity independent of the parent — testing the limits of autonomy, establishing the self that will persist into adulthood. The relationship the teenager has with their parent during this period is the template for the relationship they will have with authority, with institutions, and with their own capacity for self-regulation in adulthood. A parenting strategy based primarily on surveillance and prohibition, however lovingly administered, tends to produce one of two outcomes: compliance in the presence of authority and non-compliance the moment that authority is absent, or outright rebellion. Neither is the goal.[2]

The goal — and this is the through-line of everything that follows — is self-regulation. The parent's job is not to be the regulator of the child's digital life. It is to help the child become their own regulator. This is a different and considerably more difficult brief. It cannot be achieved quickly, or by rule alone. It is achieved through conversation, through relationship, through modelling, and through the gradual transfer of responsibility that is, in fact, what growing up means.

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[2] The research on this is substantial and consistent. Diana Baumrind's foundational work on parenting styles in the 1960s established the distinction between authoritative parenting (clear expectations combined with warmth, responsiveness, and explanation) and authoritarian parenting (compliance-focused, high

control, low warmth), finding that authoritative parenting produced better outcomes on virtually every measure of adolescent wellbeing and functioning. Fifty years of subsequent research has refined but not fundamentally revised this finding. The application to digital parenting is direct: the parent who explains, negotiates, and stays in relationship with the child will, over time, produce a more capable self-regulator than the parent who simply bans.

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II. The Family Tech Covenant

The most useful practical framework we have for the digital architecture of family life is one that has developed organically, in various forms, across many households and schools: the negotiated agreement. We call it here the Family Tech Covenant, though the name matters less than the principle.

The Covenant is not a set of rules handed down from parent to child. It is an agreement, arrived at through genuine negotiation, about how digital technology will be used in the household — by the children and by the adults. It has several components that distinguish it from a simple ban or a list of restrictions.

It is mutual. The covenant applies to everyone, including the parents. If the rule is no phones at dinner, that rule applies to all the phones at dinner, including the one belonging to the person who earns the money that paid for the dinner. This is non-negotiable. Children are exquisitely sensitive to hypocrisy, and they are, on this particular issue, entirely right to be. You cannot ask a teenager to manage their relationship to a device while failing to manage your own. You will not be believed, you will not be respected, and you will not succeed.[3]

It is explained. The child who understands why a limit exists — who has been given the actual reasoning, the neurological, social, and psychological argument, not just "because I said so" — is more likely to internalise the value behind the limit and carry it forward when you are not there. You do not need to deliver a lecture on dopamine mechanisms. You need to treat the child as someone capable of understanding that the phone was designed to be difficult to put down, that this is not an accident, and that managing that design is a skill worth developing.

It is flexible and revisable. The covenant is not a permanent settlement. It is a living document, revisited as the child grows and circumstances change. A twelve-year-old and a sixteen-year-old are different people with different needs and different capacities for self-regulation, and treating them identically serves neither. The conversation about the covenant is as important as the covenant itself: the regular, non-crisis discussion of what is working, what isn't, and what might need to change.

It includes phone-free times and spaces. These are the structural core of the covenant, and they are non-negotiable. At minimum: bedrooms at night (the phone charges outside the bedroom, for everyone, including parents), mealtimes, and one period per day of family time without devices. These are not punishments. They are the conditions under which the human beings in the household get to be in the same room together without the room being populated, also, by several billion other people.

It includes digital curfews. No screens — for children, and ideally for parents — after a defined time in the evening. This serves sleep hygiene, which we have discussed in earlier chapters, and it serves something less easily named: the experience of an evening that belongs to the household and not to the internet. The precise time will vary by age and by household. The principle is the same.

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[3] A 2023 study by researchers at the University of Michigan found that parents' own smartphone use was the strongest predictor of children's problematic smartphone use — stronger than peer influence, stronger than the child's own personality characteristics, stronger than time spent on devices. The model is the message. There is no version of this that allows you to exempt yourself.

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III. The Social World of the Teenager in 2026

To understand the social world of the contemporary teenager, it helps to remember what the social world of the teenager has always been, underneath the technological layers.

The teenager's project — the defining psychological work of adolescence — is the construction of an identity that is theirs, distinct from the family, recognised by peers, and capable of sustaining them in the adult world. This project is inherently social: it requires an audience, a community of equals against whom the emerging self can be measured and tested and revised. The teenager who says they don't care what anyone thinks is, in almost every case, thinking very carefully about what anyone thinks. The peer group is not a distraction from the developmental task. It is the developmental task.

This has always been true. What has changed is the scale, the permanence, and the architecture of the peer group in which the contemporary teenager is conducting this project.

The peer group of 2026 is not the class, or the year group, or the neighbourhood. It is, potentially, the entire internet. This is both an expansion and a complication. The expansion is real: the teenager whose particular configuration of identity makes them anomalous in their immediate environment — whose interests, sexuality, creative inclinations, or simply personality do not fit the available local template — can find community online that their geography would never have offered. This is not trivial. For many young people it is lifesaving, in both the literal and the non-literal sense.

The complication is the scale and the permanence of the audience. The teenager of 1990 was embarrassed in front of perhaps thirty people and recovered, because the thirty people had the same memory span as everyone else and moved on. The teenager of 2026 is embarrassed in front of potentially thousands of people, and the embarrassment is recorded, shareable, and searchable. The social mistake is no longer an event. It is a document.[4]

The social world is also, in 2026, continuous. There is no school bell that ends the social day and no walk home that provides transition. The peer group follows the teenager into their bedroom, into their evening, into the small hours of the morning when anxiety is worst and judgement is least reliable and the phone is glowing on the nightstand with the things people said and the things people didn't say and the stories that everyone was tagged in except possibly them.

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[4] The concept of the "context collapse" — the flattening of distinct social contexts into a single public record — was described by the scholar danah boyd in her 2014 book It's Complicated: The Social Lives of Networked Teens, which remains among the most careful and least condescending analyses of teenage

social media use available. Her core argument — that teenagers are not passive victims of social media but active navigators of a complex social environment they did not design and were not given instruction manuals for — is one this chapter endorses.

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Likes as Currency

The social hierarchy of the contemporary school is not organised, as it was in previous generations, solely around physical attractiveness, athletic ability, or social confidence. It is organised, additionally, around follower counts, like counts, and the metrics of online visibility — which are both more legible than the old hierarchies and, in some ways, crueller, because they are quantified.

The teenager who receives fifty likes on a post and watches a peer receive five hundred is not experiencing an abstract sense of inferiority. They are receiving, from a number, a precise assessment of their relative social value, delivered in public, in a format that can be screenshot and shared. The number may be wrong — it is certainly an inadequate measure of anything that actually matters — but the number is there, and it is specific, and the adolescent brain, which is in the precise developmental period where social belonging feels like survival (because evolutionarily it was), treats it accordingly.

This is not vanity. It is neurology. The regions of the brain that process social acceptance and rejection in adolescents are the same regions that process physical pain. Social exclusion, during adolescence, is experienced by the body as a form of injury.[5] Providing the social hierarchy with a numerical scoring system and delivering that system to a population for whom social standing is neurologically equivalent to physical safety is, with hindsight, a design decision of some audacity.

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[5] The neuroscience here is associated with the work of Naomi Eisenberger at UCLA, whose research using fMRI imaging showed that the neural pathways activated by social rejection — the anterior cingulate cortex and anterior insula — are the same pathways activated by physical pain. "Social pain" is not metaphor. It is physiology. Adolescents, whose social-pain systems are more sensitive than adults', are the population most exposed to the stimuli most capable of activating these systems. The algorithm is, again, indifferent to this.

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Identity Scanning

The adolescent identity project has always involved experimentation: trying on different versions of the self to see what fits. The teenager who goes through a goth phase, a political phase, a musical phase, a phase of inexplicable interest in extreme sports — these are not inconsistencies. They are the normal process of trying things on until something fits and keeping what works.

This process has been complicated, in the online environment, by the fact that every phase is now public and permanent. The political opinion expressed at fourteen is recoverable at twenty-four. The aesthetic choices of early adolescence are documented in a photo archive that does not naturally decay. The self that was being tried on as a temporary thing is recorded as a permanent statement.

More significantly, the online environment does not merely document the identity project. It shapes it. The algorithm surfaces communities — ideological, aesthetic, political, subcultural — and the teenager, looking for a self, is presented with ready-made versions. Some of these are genuinely useful: the community of young writers, or young scientists, or young queer people finding each other. Others are less so.

The pipeline from ordinary adolescent discontent into online ideological communities — particularly communities organised around grievance, identity politics, or conspiratorial worldview — is a well-documented phenomenon, and it operates through the same mechanics we described in the Andy section of Chapter Two.[6] The lonely teenager, seeking belonging and explanation, finds a community online that offers both. The community provides identity, validation, and a ready-made understanding of why things are difficult. In exchange, it requires ideological conformity and, often, increasing distance from people outside the community who do not share its framework.

This is not specific to any one end of the political spectrum. It occurs across the range, and it has the same structure regardless of the specific ideology: a genuine need, a community that meets it, and a price that is not clearly stated in the welcome message.

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[6] The academic literature on online radicalisation is large and contested, but several consistent findings emerge: young people are most vulnerable during periods of identity uncertainty (which is, by definition, adolescence); the entry points are rarely the most extreme content but rather moderate content that shares emotional register and social architecture with more extreme material; and the most effective counter is not exposure to counter-argument but the provision of alternative sources of belonging. You cannot argue someone out of a community they are in because they are lonely. You can provide something else to belong to.

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Gaming

Gaming deserves its own moment, because it is frequently discussed as a monolith — gaming bad, child in bedroom, social isolation — in ways that obscure a more complicated reality.

Gaming is, for many young people, primarily a social activity. The teenager who is playing a multiplayer game for four hours is not, in most cases, alone. They are in a persistent social world with friends — sometimes local friends, sometimes online friends they have known for years — communicating constantly, collaborating, competing, maintaining relationships through a shared activity. This is, in structure, not different from the football in the park that a previous generation's parents would have considered unambiguously healthy. The medium is different. The social function is similar.

This does not mean gaming is without problems. The problems are real and specific. The same variable reward mechanisms that make social media compulsive make certain game designs compulsive — and game design in the era of live service games and loot boxes has become, in some cases, explicitly engineered around compulsive use, with the specific targeting of adolescent male psychology.[7] Gaming disorder — defined by the WHO as a pattern of gaming behaviour that is prioritised over other activities to the extent of impairing functioning — is a real clinical phenomenon, though its prevalence is significantly lower than the moral panic around gaming implies.

The distinction between gaming as social activity and gaming as compulsive avoidance is important, and it is legible if you know what you are looking for. The teenager who plays games with friends, who can stop when asked without significant distress, who maintains interests and relationships outside gaming, who sleeps adequately and attends to school — that teenager is playing games. The teenager who is using gaming to avoid a social world that has become intolerable, who cannot stop without extreme distress, who has withdrawn from everything outside the game — that teenager needs something that is not primarily about the game.

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[7] The loot box mechanic — paying for random in-game rewards — has been classified as gambling in several countries and is the subject of ongoing regulatory debate in most others. Its specific targeting of adolescent players, who are both more susceptible to variable reward mechanisms and less able to manage financial impulse, is documented in the academic literature and disputed by the industry. This is the same structure as the Facebook internal research situation described in Chapter Two, and it produces the same epistemic uncertainty for the consumer.

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IV. Gender and Adolescence

The experience of adolescence in 2026 differs significantly by gender, and the differences are specific enough to warrant their own section.

Girls

The research on social media and adolescent girls is, by now, among the most consistent bodies of evidence in developmental psychology. The direction is not ambiguous: heavy social media use is associated, in girls, with significantly elevated rates of anxiety, depression, body dissatisfaction, and disordered eating, and the association is strongest for the platform features most specifically organised around appearance and social comparison.[8]

The mechanism is not mysterious. Instagram, TikTok, and the visual platforms present an environment in which the appearance of other girls — filtered, selected, professionally lit in some cases — is the primary content. The adolescent girl, whose developing sense of self is heavily weighted toward social comparison and whose body is undergoing changes that she has been given, in most cases, inadequate frameworks to understand or feel positive about, is navigating a daily landscape of images that are curated to represent an unachievable standard while presenting themselves as ordinary life.

The harm is not simply to body image, though that harm is real and significant and has a direct connection to the rise in eating disorder presentations among adolescent girls that clinicians have documented since approximately 2015. The harm is also to the sense of self: the steady erosion of internal standards of self-assessment by external ones, the gradual transfer of the question how do I feel about myself? to the question how do I appear to others?, and the anxiety that accompanies the knowledge that the appearance is being continuously assessed and that the assessment is partially outside your control.

Girls are also disproportionately affected by online relational aggression — the social exclusions, the reputation attacks, the rumour-spreading that has been part of female social dynamics for as long as female social dynamics have existed, now equipped with the tools of mass communication and permanent record. The group chat that turns on its member. The coordinated unfollowing. The story posted to convey, to everyone who sees it, exactly who was not invited. These are not new behaviours. They are old behaviours with new instruments, and the instruments make them more precise, more scalable, and considerably harder to escape.[9]

Boys

Boys and social media are a less-researched and more complicated picture, in part because the harms are less immediately visible and in part because the research community has, until recently, focused its attention on the more obvious female crisis.

The picture that is emerging is this: boys are significantly more likely than girls to use gaming and online communities as primary social environments, with the risks to real-world social development that we have described. Boys are more likely to be exposed to radicalising online ideologies — both political and gender-based — that offer simple explanations for complex social experiences. Boys are significantly less likely to seek help when things are difficult, less likely to have friendship networks that include explicit emotional support, and significantly more likely to suppress or misidentify the emotional distress that they are, on the evidence, experiencing in comparable quantities to girls.[10]

The specific pressure of 2026 for boys is the intersection of traditional masculine culture — which values self-sufficiency, emotional control, and competitive dominance — with an online environment that has, in several corners, developed a highly specific and commercially motivated ideology of masculinity. The influencer economy has produced, in the last decade, a substantial industry organised around the premise that young men have been failed by feminism, that traditional masculinity is under attack, and that the path to self-respect runs through a specific set of physical, financial, and relational dominance practices.

This ideology is not serving the boys who consume it. It is serving the people selling it. But it is meeting a real need — the need for a legible masculine identity in a cultural moment that has rightly challenged many of the old models without always offering clear alternatives — and meeting a real need badly is still meeting it, which is why the content finds its audience.[11]

The parent of a boy who is consuming this content is rarely going to succeed by telling him the content is wrong. They will succeed by understanding what need it is meeting and by working, patiently and without contempt, to meet that need differently.

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[8] The most comprehensive recent data is from Jean Twenge's research, collected in her books iGen (2017) and Generations (2023), which tracks generational trends in mental health using large national datasets. Her finding that the mental health of adolescent girls deteriorated sharply from approximately 2012 — the year smartphones became ubiquitous among teenagers — has been replicated by multiple independent researchers and is now the mainstream position in the field, though debate continues about mechanism and causality.

[9] The term "relational aggression" was established in the research of developmental psychologist Nicki Crick in the 1990s, who documented the gender difference in aggressive behaviour: boys tend toward physical and direct verbal aggression, girls toward social manipulation and exclusion. Both forms of aggression cause harm. The relational form was, for several decades, less visible in research and less taken seriously in schools. The social media environment has made it considerably more visible by giving it infrastructure.

[10] The AMHS (Adult Psychiatric Morbidity Survey) and comparable studies in other countries consistently find that men report lower rates of mental health difficulties than women — a finding that most mental health researchers interpret not as evidence that men experience fewer difficulties, but as evidence that men are less likely to identify and report them. The gap between reported and estimated actual prevalence is large enough to represent a significant public health problem in its own right.

[11] The academic literature on online masculinity movements is growing. Richard Reeves's 2022 book Of Boys and Men provides the most balanced and research-grounded account of the genuine challenges facing young men in the contemporary economy and culture — distinct from the ideological version of the same argument that the manosphere has developed. The distinction matters: the genuine problem is real and deserves serious response; the ideological response to it is both inaccurate and harmful.

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V. Specific Pressures: A Practical Inventory

Sexting and Image-Based Harm

We touched on this in Chapter Four. In the context of adolescence it requires more specific treatment.

Approximately one in four teenagers has sent a sexually explicit image of themselves. The majority who do so are not doing so under extreme coercion — many describe it as a normal part of romantic communication in their peer environment, something that is expected and unremarkable. This does not make it without risk. The image, once sent, is permanently outside the sender's control, regardless of the promises made at the time of sending. The teenage brain — whose prefrontal cortex, responsible for risk assessment and long-term consequence modelling, is not fully developed until the mid-twenties — is not well equipped to fully inhabit the long-term implications of a short-term decision made under social or romantic pressure.

Image-based abuse — the non-consensual sharing of intimate images — affects girls and young women disproportionately and has significant and documented consequences for mental health, school functioning, and in some cases physical safety. It is also, in most jurisdictions, a criminal offence, though enforcement is inconsistent and reporting rates are low.[12]

The conversation parents need to have with their teenagers about this is not the conversation most parents are currently having, which is either no conversation or a version of don't send naked pictures, end of conversation. The conversation that is actually needed is about consent, about pressure, about what to do if something goes wrong, and about the fact that the shame, if it goes wrong, belongs to the person who shared the image without permission and not to the person who sent it in what they understood to be a private context.

Cyberbullying

Bullying is not new. The experience of being targeted, excluded, humiliated, or physically threatened by peers is as old as childhood, and its psychological consequences are as serious as they have always been. What the digital environment has added is persistence, scale, and the removal of the home as refuge. The bullied teenager of 1990 could, at some point in the day, leave the school and be, in a limited but real sense, safe. The bullied teenager of 2026 cannot leave. The phone brings the bullying into their bedroom, their mealtimes, their sleep.

The response to cyberbullying requires the same core elements as the response to physical bullying — taking it seriously, not dismissing it as drama, involving appropriate authorities when necessary — and one additional element: the understanding that the digital record is both the evidence and the problem. Screenshots are evidence. Document them. But the ongoing engagement with the bullying content — the checking, the rereading, the tracking of what is being said — is also something to attend to, because the compulsive monitoring of the thing that is causing harm is itself causing harm.[13]

AI, School, and Academic Pressure

The relationship between artificial intelligence and education is, in 2026, in a state that might charitably be described as transitional and less charitably as confused. Students have access to tools that can write their essays, solve their maths problems, and generate credible-sounding answers to almost any question that might appear on an exam. Schools have policies about this that range from comprehensive ban (unenforceable) to unrestricted use (pedagogically complex) to somewhere in between that nobody has quite defined clearly.

The honest position, for both parents and teenagers, is this: AI tools are not going away, and the ability to use them well — to prompt effectively, to evaluate outputs critically, to know when the tool is useful and when it is leading you astray — is itself a skill of genuine value in the world the teenager is entering. The academic integrity question is real, but it is a question for institutions to resolve, not individual families, and the family's job is less to police AI use than to ensure the teenager understands the difference between using a tool and outsourcing their thinking.

The deeper concern is the relationship to difficulty. Learning requires struggle. The productive struggle of not knowing how to do something and working out how is where most of the cognitive development happens — where the capability grows, where the confidence is earned. The AI that removes the struggle removes, also, the growth. The teenager who never writes a difficult paragraph themselves, because the paragraph can always be generated, will not develop the capacity for the thing that generates the paragraph.[14] This is the argument to make to teenagers, because it is true and because it is not primarily a moral argument but a practical one.

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[12] The Online Safety Act 2023 made cyberflashing and the sharing of intimate images without consent criminal offences in England and Wales. Equivalent legislation exists in Scotland, and in many other jurisdictions. The existence of legislation does not resolve the enforcement and reporting problems, but it establishes the legal framework and — importantly — the cultural signal that this is harm, not a private matter.

[13] The phenomenon of compulsive monitoring of harmful content — checking repeatedly to see what is being said about you — has been described by researchers as a form of "hypervigilant checking" and is associated with elevated anxiety and prolonged psychological distress. The clinical guidance is to limit checking to a defined, brief window rather than continuous monitoring, which reduces overall exposure while allowing the person to stay informed if they need to be.

[14] This argument is made most clearly by the cognitive scientist Stanislas Dehaene in his work on learning and neuroplasticity, which establishes that the brain's capacity for a skill is built through the effortful practice of that skill, not through exposure to its outputs. You do not develop the ability to write by reading good writing or by having good writing generated on your behalf. You develop it by writing, struggling, revising, and writing again. This is inconvenient but not negotiable.

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VI. Tools for Teenagers

This section is addressed to the teenagers in the room — or the teenagers in the house, who may or may not be in the same room.

You are navigating something genuinely difficult. Not catastrophically difficult — you are not the first generation to face significant pressure, and the generations before you faced their own versions, some of which were considerably worse in material terms. But the specific difficulty of your moment is real, and it is not adequately addressed by telling you to put down your phone and go outside, though putting down your phone and going outside is, it turns out, among the most evidence-supported interventions available. Life is full of these irritating situations.

Here are some things that are actually useful.

On the social world:

The social hierarchy of school — the likes, the followers, the who-is-in-and-who-is-out — is a real system with real consequences in the present. It is also, in the frame of your actual life, quite brief. The people who determine your social standing at fifteen are not, in the overwhelming majority of cases, the people you will be close to at twenty-five. The skills that will matter most in adulthood — the capacity to be genuinely interested in people, to listen, to be reliable, to handle difficulty without collapsing — are not the skills the school social hierarchy rewards. They are developed in the margins of it, in the friendships that aren't the cool ones, in the activities that aren't the popular ones, in the quiet practice of being yourself in circumstances that prefer a different version of you.

This does not make the present easier. It makes it more endurable, which is different and still useful.

On the phone:

You already know, with some part of your mind, that the phone is making certain things worse. The hour spent scrolling that leaves you feeling vaguely bad about yourself without being able to explain why. The checking of someone's story at midnight when you should be asleep. The comparison that you didn't mean to make but made anyway and then couldn't unmake. You know this. You don't need to be told it.

What you might not know is that the discomfort of not checking — the itch, the pull, the low-level anxiety of having the phone in the other room — is temporary. It lasts about ten minutes, on average, and then it passes. On the other side of it is something that feels, quietly, better than the scrolling felt. This is not a moral argument. It is a neurological one, and it is worth testing.

On identity:

You are not the version of yourself that is most visible online. You are also not the version that is least visible. You are a person in the process of becoming something, and the process is messier and slower and more interesting than any profile can capture. The pressure to have a fixed, legible, consistent identity at the age when you are actively constructing it is one of the crueller demands of the current moment. You do not need to know yet. You are allowed to be uncertain. The uncertainty is not a problem to be resolved. It is the condition of being fifteen, or seventeen, or twenty-one, and it deserves something better than the anxious curation of an identity that feels right enough to post.

On asking for help:

If things are bad — not just difficult, but genuinely bad; if you are in the dark and not finding a way through it — please tell someone. A parent if you can. A friend if you can't. A teacher, a counsellor, a relative, a helpline if those feel like too much. The help exists and it works and the reluctance to ask for it is a feeling, not a fact, and feelings can be moved through.

You do not have to be in crisis to ask for help. You can ask for help when things are merely hard. This is, in fact, the ideal time to ask for it.

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VII. Tools for Parents

On the conversation:

The most important thing you can do, as a parent of a teenager in 2026, is to remain in conversation with them about the digital world — not as an authority delivering judgements, but as a curious and reasonably well-informed adult who is genuinely interested in how they are navigating something you did not have to navigate at their age.

This requires a particular kind of listening. Not the listening that is waiting for the right moment to make your point. The listening that is actually trying to understand what their experience is — what the social world they are navigating feels like from inside it, what the pressures are that you might not have identified, what they find hard and what they find manageable. The conversations that begin with tell me what it's like are more useful than the conversations that begin with I read an article about.

It also requires consistency. The teenager who knows that a conversation is always available — not just when something goes wrong, not just when you are worried — is the teenager most likely to come to you when something actually goes wrong. The relationship has to exist before the crisis for it to be available during it.[15]

On modelling:

We have said this and will say it again because it bears repetition: your relationship to your own phone is the primary lesson you are teaching about the appropriate relationship to a phone. Not the rules you set. Not the conversations you have. The thing they see you do, every day, at dinner, in the car, when they are trying to tell you something and the phone is in your hand.

Put the phone down when they are talking to you. Not face-down — away. There is a difference, and they notice the difference, and they will remember the difference long after they have forgotten what you were saying.

On the sex and tech conversation:

This conversation needs to happen before the situation does. The parent who waits until there is a problem to discuss sexting, image-based abuse, or online safety is the parent who is having the hardest possible version of the conversation at the worst possible time.

The conversation is not primarily about prohibition. It is about information, about your values, and about what they should do if something goes wrong. It needs to include, explicitly: the permanence of digital images, the concept of image-based abuse and the fact that it is both harmful and illegal, the nature of social pressure and how to recognise it, and — crucially — the message that if something goes wrong, they can tell you, and telling you will not result in blame directed at them.

That last part is the most important and the hardest. It requires the parent to have genuinely resolved, in advance of the conversation, that if their child comes to them having made a mistake in this domain, the first response will be support and not anger. This is difficult. It is necessary.

On the gaming teenager:

The question to ask is not how many hours but what the gaming is doing. Is it the primary social world, maintained alongside real-world relationships? Is it a hobby pursued with evident enjoyment and the capacity to stop? Or is it the place the teenager is going because everywhere else has become intolerable? The answer to that question determines the response.

If the answer is the first two, your job is primarily to ensure that the gaming is not displacing sleep, school, and the maintenance of real-world connection. If the answer is the third, the gaming is a symptom, and addressing the gaming without addressing what it is a symptom of will not work.

On compassion for yourself:

Parenting is harder than it was, in the specific sense that the digital world has added a dimension of complexity — social, psychological, technical — that no previous generation of parents was required to navigate. You were not trained for it. The school was not trained for it. The research, while growing, is still incomplete. You are making decisions with inadequate information under conditions of genuine uncertainty about a matter of significant consequence.

You will get some things wrong. This is not optional. The parent who gets everything right about the digital world does not yet exist, because nobody has been doing this long enough to have the finished picture. What you can do is stay in relationship, stay curious, stay honest, and repair the things that go wrong as soon as you can.

That is enough. It is, in fact, exactly what is needed.

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[15] The research on adolescent help-seeking consistently finds that the most important predictor of a teenager seeking parental support in a crisis is the prior quality of the parent-teenager relationship — not the absence of conflict, which is both normal and healthy, but the presence of a general sense of safety and accessibility. The relationship is the infrastructure. The infrastructure needs to be maintained in the quiet times.

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Navigation: The Tools for This Chapter

Psychologically: The Family Tech Covenant is itself a psychological tool, because the process of negotiating it — sitting together, discussing values, acknowledging competing needs — does something more important than the agreement it produces. It establishes the family as a place where these things are talked about. That is the foundation everything else rests on.

For teenagers specifically: the mindfulness research in adolescent populations is clear — brief, daily practices of present-moment attention (five minutes in the morning before the phone, a minute of breathing before sleep) produce measurable reductions in anxiety and improvements in emotional regulation. The adolescent who finds the word "mindfulness" cringe-worthy (which is a reasonable aesthetic response) might find the same practice more accessible under a different name. Sit quietly for five minutes. Notice what you notice. That's it. The name doesn't matter. The practice does.

Physically: Teenagers need more sleep than adults and are, systematically, getting less — partly because of screens, partly because of school start times that require them to be functioning at hours that conflict with the adolescent circadian rhythm, which runs approximately two hours later than the adult rhythm.[16] The most impactful single physical intervention available to a family with teenagers is the phone-out-of-bedroom rule. The second is negotiating, where possible, a regular outdoor activity — not because nature is magically curative, though it is somewhat, but because the body in motion outdoors is doing several useful things simultaneously: moving, breathing, looking at distances, and not looking at a screen.

Spiritually: Family rituals — the shared meal, the regular walk, the annual tradition, the particular way your family marks the things that matter — are not small things. They are the structure through which belonging is communicated and maintained. The teenager who rolls their eyes at the Sunday dinner is, on the available evidence, the teenager who will miss the Sunday dinner most acutely when it is gone. Keep the rituals. Adapt them as the family changes. Let the teenager complain about them. The complaining is part of the ritual.

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[16] The research on adolescent sleep is associated with Mary Carskadon at Brown University, who has spent decades documenting the biological shift in the adolescent circadian rhythm and its incompatibility with early school start times. The American Academy of Pediatrics issued a policy statement in 2014 recommending that middle and high schools start no earlier than 8:30am, citing the sleep research. Most schools have not changed their start times. This is, in the literature, considered a public health failure of some significance.

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Next: Chapter Six — Your Body, Your Temple: Health and the Physical Self

In which we establish that the body has not changed significantly in the last hundred thousand years, that the environment has changed beyond recognition in the last twenty, and that the body is, in the circumstances, doing its considerable best and deserves rather more credit than it is currently receiving.

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Chapter Six: Your Body, Your Temple — Health and the Physical Self

✦

Here is something that does not receive sufficient acknowledgement: your body has been doing an extraordinary job.

Not a perfect job — the body is not without its complaints, its failures of engineering, its occasional dramatic overreactions to things that were not actually threatening. But an extraordinary job, given the circumstances. It was designed, through several hundred thousand years of iterative development, for a life that involved substantial daily movement, exposure to natural light across the full spectrum of the day, varied physical effort, regular periods of deep sleep, food that required some effort to obtain, and a social environment of roughly a hundred and fifty people whose faces it could recognise and whose intentions it could read.

What it has been given, in 2026, is a chair.[1]

Also a screen, which it stares at for approximately seven hours per day under artificial light that is calibrated for visibility rather than biological comfort. Also food that arrives with minimal physical effort and is engineered, with considerable skill, to be consumed in quantities larger than the body's hunger signals intended to request. Also a sleep environment in which the natural darkness that triggers the hormonal preparation for sleep is replaced by the glow of the device on the nightstand, patiently undermining the one restorative process that the day's other insults most urgently require.

The body is, under these conditions, doing its best. Its best is somewhat compromised. The question is what can be done about it — not dramatically, not with a radical lifestyle overhaul that most people will sustain for eleven days before returning to their previous arrangements, but practically, consistently, and with an honest account of what the body actually needs and why the current arrangement is providing so little of it.

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[1] This is, admittedly, a simplification. The body was also designed for exposure to cold, for seasonal food scarcity, for parasitic infection, and for the occasional encounter with something that wanted to eat it. We have solved most of these problems. We have replaced them with the chair, which produces slower and quieter harms but harms nonetheless.

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I. Through the Three Lenses: The Body in Time

1920

The body in 1920 did not require a gym membership.

Physical activity was not a category of experience separate from daily life — a thing you scheduled, drove to, and did in special clothing before driving home. It was simply what daily life consisted of. Agricultural labour, domestic work, walking as the primary mode of local transport, trades that required the use of the upper body, housework conducted without the assistance of the machines that have since made it require approximately one-third the physical effort. The average daily step count of a person in 1920 has been estimated at between fifteen and twenty thousand.[2] The contemporary average, across the developed world, is between four and five thousand.

Sleep in 1920 followed the light. Before electrification became universal, darkness was genuinely dark, and the body's melatonin system — which responds to light levels with a reliability that has not changed in ten thousand years — could do its job without interference. Average sleep duration in the pre-electric era was approximately seven to nine hours, with evidence of a two-phase sleep pattern: a first sleep in the early evening hours, a period of wakefulness in the middle of the night during which people prayed, talked, made love, or simply lay thinking, and a second sleep toward morning.[3]

This is not the sleep of people who had perfected the conditions for rest. It is the sleep of people whose bodies were doing what bodies do when the environment allows them to. The environment allowed it.

Food in 1920 was, for most people, local, seasonal, relatively unprocessed, and obtained through some combination of personal effort and community network. This does not mean the diet was ideal — nutritional deficiencies were common, variety was limited, and the caloric adequacy of the diet was directly determined by economic circumstance in ways that were frequently inadequate. But the food was not engineered to circumvent satiety signals, was not available in unlimited quantities at all hours, and did not arrive pre-selected for maximum palatability at minimum nutritional cost.

1995–2006

The body, by the mid-nineties, was living a more sedentary life than it had in 1920, but the sedentariness was still interrupted, regularly, by the physical requirements of daily existence. The commute involved walking. The shopping involved carrying. The domestic work, while substantially mechanised, still required physical presence in a way that ordering online and receiving delivery does not.

The gym had arrived, in this period, as a cultural institution — and its arrival is, in retrospect, a significant moment in the history of the body. Because the gym is, essentially, the institutionalisation of the body's need for movement in the form of a scheduled, paid activity that you perform separately from the rest of your life. Which is a reasonable solution to the problem of insufficient movement. It is also the first sign that movement and life have been separated — that you can live a life that does not, in its ordinary texture, require the body to do very much, and compensate for this by going somewhere specific to make it do things.[4]

Food had become significantly more processed. Fast food had moved from occasional treat to regular meal for a substantial portion of the population. The supermarket had made an extraordinary variety of food available at all hours and at low cost, and the food industry had learned, with increasing sophistication, how to engineer products that were consumed more readily than the body's satiety mechanisms intended. The obesity rate was rising. The data was becoming visible. The public health response was beginning, with the particular urgency of people who have not yet realised that informing people about a problem does not, on its own, solve it.

2026

The body in 2026 is, in many developed countries, in a state of quiet crisis that is remarkable primarily for how thoroughly it has been normalised.

Approximately two-thirds of adults in the United Kingdom are overweight or obese, a figure that has more than doubled since 1980.[5] Approximately one in three adults fails to meet the minimum recommended physical activity guidelines, which are themselves modest enough that their failure to be met constitutes a significant underperformance. Musculoskeletal problems — back pain, neck pain, repetitive strain — are among the leading causes of work absence and disability, and they are, in the majority of cases, directly associated with the posture and movement patterns of sedentary, screen-based work.

Sleep, as we have discussed, is impaired at a population level by the blue light of devices, the stimulation of the social media environment, and the management of work communication into hours that were previously available for rest. The average adult is sleeping approximately six and a half hours per night.[6] The recommended minimum for cognitive function and physical health is seven hours; for optimal function it is closer to eight. The gap between what people are getting and what they need is, accumulated over weeks and months, a significant physiological debt.

And yet: none of this feels, from the inside, like crisis. It feels like normal. The back that aches slightly at four in the afternoon feels like the normal back. The tiredness that is present most mornings feels like the normal level of tiredness. The difficulty concentrating in the afternoon, the mild anxiety that sits under the surface of most days, the food choices made not from hunger but from the combined pressure of engineered palatability, emotional state, and habit — these feel like the normal conditions of life, because they are the consistent conditions of life, and the brain's calibration system adjusts to whatever is consistent and calls it baseline.

This is the most important thing to understand about the body's current situation: what is normal is not the same as what is well.

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[2] The figure is derived from occupational and archaeological research on pre-industrial activity levels and is, necessarily, an estimate. The point is the order of magnitude: physical activity in 1920 was not a scheduled supplement to daily life but the content of it.

[3] The historian A. Roger Ekirch documented the two-phase sleep pattern in extensive archival research, published in his 2005 book At Day's Close: Night in Times Past. He found references to "first sleep" and "second sleep" in literature, legal documents, and personal correspondence across multiple centuries and cultures, and argues that the consolidated eight-hour sleep we now regard as natural is a product of the industrial era and artificial lighting, not a biological default.

[4] The philosopher Albert Borgmann called this the "device paradigm": the tendency of modern technology to provide the commodity (warmth, nourishment, entertainment, movement) while concealing and eliminating the practice through which the commodity was previously obtained. The central heating that provides warmth without a fireplace. The processed food that provides nourishment without cooking. The gym that provides movement without the physical life that once required it. The commodity is real. The practice — and the focal engagement with the world that the practice provided — is what disappears.

[5] NHS Digital, Statistics on Obesity, Physical Activity and Diet, England, 2024. The trend is consistent across most high-income countries, with the United States, Australia, and New Zealand showing comparable or higher rates.

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II. Sleep: The Most Underrated Health Intervention Available

Sleep is, among the evidence-based health interventions available to the general public, both the most effective and the least commercially interesting, which is probably why it does not receive the cultural attention it deserves relative to supplements, diets, and fitness regimes.

During sleep, the brain does things it cannot do when awake. It consolidates memory — transferring the events and learnings of the day from short-term to long-term storage, a process that requires the hippocampus to be offline from sensory input in a way that wakefulness does not allow. It clears metabolic waste — the glymphatic system, which operates primarily during deep sleep, flushes the brain of the toxic proteins, including amyloid beta, that are associated with neurodegenerative disease.[7] It regulates the hormones that govern hunger, immune function, stress response, and emotional regulation. It repairs tissue, consolidates motor learning, and runs what is essentially a nightly system maintenance cycle whose outputs are visible in every domain of waking function.

The sleep-deprived person is not simply tired. They are immunologically compromised, metabolically dysregulated, emotionally volatile, cognitively impaired, and physically at elevated risk of a range of conditions including cardiovascular disease, type 2 diabetes, and depression. They are also, and this is the detail that tends to escape notice, significantly impaired in their ability to assess how impaired they are. The subjective sense of having adapted to reduced sleep — I'm fine on six hours, I've got used to it — is itself a product of sleep deprivation, which impairs the metacognitive processes that would otherwise notice the impairment.[8]

None of this is controversial. It is among the most robustly replicated bodies of evidence in medicine. And yet the conditions we have described — the devices in the bedroom, the work email at nine in the evening, the stimulating content available at midnight — are precisely the conditions most effective at degrading sleep quality and duration.

The practical response is not complicated. It is merely effortful:

The phone charges in another room. Not face-down. In another room. The bedroom is for sleep and intimacy, and the introduction of a device whose primary function is to deliver stimulating content and social anxiety into that space is a design decision that does not serve either of those purposes.

A consistent sleep and wake time, including at weekends, is the single most effective structural intervention for sleep quality. The body's circadian clock is calibrated by light and by consistency; irregular timing disrupts the calibration and reduces sleep quality independently of total duration.

The hour before bed is, ideally, low-stimulation. This does not require formal relaxation practice, though that helps. It requires the cessation of the activities most likely to activate the nervous system: work communication, news, social media, anything that generates strong emotional responses. Reading a physical book is not mere nostalgia — the light profile and the engagement pattern of a physical book are materially different from those of a screen, and the difference is measurable in sleep onset and quality.

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[6] The figure is from the Sleep Council's Great British Sleep Survey, 2023. Comparable figures exist for other developed countries; the American Academy of Sleep Medicine finds similar patterns in US data.

[7] The glymphatic system was described in detail by Maiken Nedergaard and colleagues at the University of Rochester in 2013, in a paper that attracted significant attention partly because it explained, for the first time, a clear mechanism by which sleep deprivation might contribute to neurodegenerative disease. The finding that the brain has its own waste-clearance system that operates almost exclusively during sleep is one of the more consequential discoveries in neuroscience of the last decade, and it has not yet reached the cultural prominence it deserves.

[8] This is documented in research by David Dinges and colleagues at the University of Pennsylvania, who found that subjects who were sleep-restricted to six hours per night showed progressive cognitive impairment over two weeks but consistently rated their own performance as adequate. The inability to accurately assess one's own sleep deprivation is not a personality trait. It is a physiological effect of sleep deprivation.

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III. Movement: The Thing the Body Was Built For

The evidence for the health benefits of regular physical movement is, at this point, so extensive and so consistent that summarising it risks giving the impression that it might be one consideration among several. It is not. It is the consideration.

Regular moderate exercise — the equivalent of a thirty-minute brisk walk, five days per week — reduces the risk of cardiovascular disease by approximately thirty-five percent, type 2 diabetes by fifty percent, depression by thirty percent, and all-cause mortality by roughly thirty percent.[9] These are not modest effects. These are effects that, if they were produced by a pharmaceutical intervention, would represent one of the most significant medical advances in history. The pharmaceutical intervention does not exist. The walk does.

The mechanism by which movement produces these effects is not singular — exercise affects the cardiovascular system, the metabolic system, the immune system, the endocrine system, and the brain simultaneously, through overlapping mechanisms that are still being fully mapped. But among the most significant and most relevant to the concerns of this book is the effect on the brain. Exercise increases the production of brain-derived neurotrophic factor (BDNF), a protein sometimes described as "fertiliser for the brain," which supports the growth and maintenance of neural connections, the consolidation of memory, and the regulation of mood.[10] The person who exercises regularly is not merely physically healthier. They are cognitively sharper, emotionally more stable, and meaningfully more resilient to the psychological stressors of daily life.

The body was designed to move. It was not designed to move in the specific ways that a gym membership offers, or a fitness class, or a Couch to 5K programme, though all of these are perfectly good methods. It was designed to move through the world as part of the ordinary texture of living: walking, carrying, climbing, stretching, occasionally running, frequently bending, regularly doing things with the hands that the hands were made for. The modern sedentary life has removed most of these movements from the

ordinary texture of living and replaced them with the option to do scheduled exercise instead, which is better than nothing but which does not replicate the distributed, varied, integrated movement that the body evolved within.

The most accessible and most evidence-supported response to this is the walk. Not the power walk in the heart-rate training zone, though that too is fine. The walk. Outside, ideally, because the combination of movement and natural environment produces effects on the stress response and the attentional system that indoor exercise does not replicate with the same efficiency.[11] Long enough to notice a change of state — twenty minutes at minimum. With the phone in your pocket rather than in your hand, because a walk in which you are looking at the phone is a walk in which you are not, quite, outside.

The standing desk deserves a brief note: it is genuinely useful when used as intended — alternating between sitting and standing — and genuinely useless when used as a standing-all-day arrangement, which produces its own variety of musculoskeletal stress. The body does not want to stand still any more than it wants to sit still. It wants to move. The standing desk that is adjusted once and never moved is a piece of furniture. The standing desk that is adjusted several times per day, in response to what the body is asking for, is a tool.

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[9] These figures are from systematic reviews and meta-analyses; the cardiovascular figure is from a 2016 meta-analysis in the British Journal of Sports Medicine, the diabetes figure from a Cochrane review of exercise interventions, the depression figure from a 2013 meta-analysis in the Journal of Psychiatric Research, and the all-cause mortality figure from a 2012 analysis in The Lancet. All figures are approximations across study populations and will vary by individual, but the order of magnitude is consistent.

[10] John Ratey's Spark: The Revolutionary New Science of Exercise and the Brain (2008) remains the most accessible and well-documented account of the relationship between exercise and brain function. The BDNF research it draws on has been substantially extended since publication, consistently in the direction of confirming and expanding the original findings.

[11] The "attention restoration theory" of Rachel and Stephen Kaplan, developed in the 1980s and substantially extended since, proposes that natural environments restore directed attentional capacity — the deliberate, effortful attention of concentrated work — by engaging the involuntary attention that is activated by nature without depleting directed attention. Subsequent research has measured reductions in cortisol, blood pressure, and amygdala activity following exposure to natural environments, providing physiological grounding for what most people experience intuitively: being outside, among trees and open space, feels restorative in ways that being inside does not.

✦

IV. Posture, Pain, and the Architecture of Screen Life

The human head weighs approximately five kilograms. This is a reasonable weight for a head, and the cervical spine — the seven vertebrae of the neck — is designed to support it comfortably when the head is upright and balanced over the shoulders.

When the head is tilted forward at the angle typical of phone use — approximately sixty degrees — the effective load on the cervical spine increases to approximately twenty-seven kilograms. This is the equivalent of carrying a seven-year-old child on your neck for several hours per day, which is an arrangement that most people would recognise, if it were presented to them in those terms, as not entirely comfortable.[12]

The consequences of sustained forward head posture are not, in the short term, dramatic. A slight tightness in the upper back. Occasional headaches. The neck that stiffens after a long drive. These are the early signals. Sustained over years, the consequences include structural changes to the cervical spine, chronic pain in the neck and upper back, reduced range of motion, and the muscle imbalances that produce the characteristic rounded-shoulder, forward-head posture of the heavy screen user — an arrangement that, once established, perpetuates itself, because the shortened muscles of the chest and front of the neck resist the correction that the weakened muscles of the upper back can no longer provide without significant effort.

The remediation is straightforward in principle and requires consistency in practice: frequent postural resets throughout the working day (the chin tuck, in which you draw the chin back and down, lengthening the back of the neck, can be done in any chair without attracting comment), strengthening of the muscles of the upper back and posterior shoulder, stretching of the chest and anterior neck, and the reduction of the time spent in the forward-head position through the arrangements already described: raising the screen height, supporting the device rather than holding it, using a laptop stand, getting up and moving.

The low back deserves a separate mention. Prolonged sitting — regardless of posture — increases the compression load on the lumbar discs and reduces the circulation in the muscles of the lower back, producing the familiar ache of the long working day. The response is not to find the perfect chair, though a reasonably supportive chair helps. The response is to sit less and move more, which is, again, simple in statement and requires genuine effort to implement in a working life that is organised around sitting.

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[12] The figure is from the study by Kenneth Hansraj cited in Chapter Two. It is worth repeating here because it is, in the context of this chapter, not an amusing detail but a clinical one. The structural consequences of sustained forward head posture are among the most preventable musculoskeletal problems in the contemporary population, and they are being prevented with insufficient vigour.

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V. Food, Appetite, and the Engineered Environment

Food is a domain in which the three-lens comparison is particularly illuminating, because the change in the food environment over the last hundred years is not, primarily, a change in knowledge or intention but in the engineering of what is available.

The human appetite system was designed in a nutritional environment of relative scarcity and considerable physical effort. The mechanisms it uses to regulate intake — hunger and satiety hormones, the palatability signals of sweetness and fat, the hedonic reward of calorie-dense food — were calibrated for a world in which calorie-dense food was difficult to obtain and physical activity was unavoidable. They were not

calibrated for a world in which calorie-dense food is available at every hour, at low cost, specifically engineered to be more palatable than the hunger signal intended to request, and in which physical activity is optional.

The food industry of 2026 is not, in the main, trying to make you unwell. It is trying to make you buy things and come back and buy them again, which requires making them as appealing as possible, which has produced, as a byproduct, a food environment that the appetite system cannot navigate using the tools evolution provided for the purpose. This is not a moral failing of the food industry alone, and it is not a moral failing of the people eating the food. It is a mismatch between a regulatory system and the environment it was designed for — the same mismatch that produces the attention problem with the phone, and the sleep problem with the screen, and the social connection problem with the algorithm. The system is doing what it was built to do. The environment has changed faster than the system can adapt.

The practical response to the engineered food environment is not primarily about willpower, which is a finite resource that is further depleted by stress, sleep deprivation, and decision fatigue — exactly the conditions most likely to produce poor food choices. It is about environment design: making the foods that support health more accessible and more convenient than the foods that don't, which is a task that operates at the level of the kitchen and the shopping trip rather than the moment of choice.[13]

Cook when you have energy. Batch prepare when the gap allows. Make the fruit bowl more visible than the biscuit tin. Eat at a table, without a screen, with enough attention to notice what you are eating and whether you are still hungry. This last point is not a mindful eating lecture — it is a practical observation that eating while looking at a screen consistently produces greater consumption than eating while attending to the food, because the satiety signals require attention to register, and attention directed at a screen is not attending to the body.

✦

[13] The behavioural economist Richard Thaler coined the term "choice architecture" to describe the design of environments in ways that make certain choices easier or more likely than others, without removing options. His co-authored book Nudge (2008) provides the theoretical framework; the food environment application is straightforward: you are significantly more likely to eat what is available and accessible than to make a deliberate choice from a wider menu. Design the available and accessible accordingly.

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VI. The Body You Have Forgotten You Are In

There is a specific experience of the knowledge worker, and it is, once named, immediately recognisable.

You are in a Zoom call. You have been in it for forty-five minutes. You will be in it for fifteen more. You notice, with a mild surprise that carries the quality of something that should have been obvious earlier, that you are not breathing properly. Not dramatically — you have not stopped breathing, which would have resolved the matter sooner. You have been breathing shallowly, in the upper chest, in the manner of someone who is slightly stressed and has been slightly stressed for so long that they have forgotten it is not the default setting. You take a breath. A proper one. And for a moment — before the screen claims your attention again — you are, briefly and unmistakably, in your body.[14]

The experience of inhabiting the body is not, for most people in 2026, the baseline condition. The baseline condition is inhabiting the screen — the attention directed outward, toward the content, while the body manages itself as best it can in the background. This is not comfortable, in the way that most discomfort goes unnoticed only because it has been present long enough to register as normal. It is a narrowing. A reduction. The body is not a vehicle for the mind. It is the mind, in the sense that the mind emerges from it, is constituted by it, and is profoundly affected by what is done to and with it. The person who is never in their body is not experiencing the full version of their mind.

The recovery of embodied awareness does not require yoga or meditation or any other practice that might feel, given your relationship to your body at this particular moment, like an absurd overcorrection. It requires the development of a habit of checking in — briefly, regularly, without drama — on what the body is doing and what it is telling you. Are you breathing? Fully, into the belly, or shallowly, in the chest? Are you tense somewhere — the jaw, the shoulders, the hands? Have you drunk water recently? Have you moved in the last hour?

These are not spiritual questions, though they can become spiritual ones. They are the minimum maintenance questions that the body is entitled to expect from the person who is living in it.

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[14] The comparison between forgetting to blink in a Zoom call and forgetting to breathe in a panic is, on examination, not as absurd as it initially sounds. Research on videoconferencing has found that people blink significantly less frequently during video calls than in face-to-face conversation — approximately one-third as often — producing the dry, tired eyes that many people associate with a long day on calls. The body's automatic processes, which operate reliably in the conditions they evolved for, are disrupted by conditions they did not evolve for. The blink, like the breath, can become a conscious act rather than an automatic one. Neither is improved by the transition.

✦

VII. Gender and the Body

The experience of the body in 2026 is not identical for men and women, and the differences deserve acknowledgement.

Women, on average, face a more intense and more commercially organised pressure in relation to body appearance than men. The beauty and diet industries — worth, combined, several trillion dollars globally — are directed primarily, though not exclusively, at women, and the messages they deliver are consistent across the decades even as the specific ideal they promote shifts: the body you have is insufficient, and the body you should have is available, for a price, through the correct products and practices. Social media has amplified and accelerated this message to a degree that is visible in clinical data: eating disorder presentations among young women have risen sharply since approximately 2012, with the sharpest increases in the age groups with the highest social media use.[15]

Men face body pressure of a different character. The ideal male body promoted by social media and the influencer economy — the specific combination of musculature, leanness, and physical imposingness — is equally unrepresentative of ordinary male bodies and increasingly associated, in clinical research, with

elevated rates of muscle dysmorphia (the persistent belief that one's body is insufficiently muscular), anabolic steroid use among young men, and exercise patterns driven by anxiety rather than health. The male body image problem is real, less discussed, and growing.[16]

Both pressures — and the distinct forms of suffering they produce — are, in the main, commercially generated. They serve the industries that sell the solution to the problem they have created. The Navigation section at the end of this chapter will offer some tools for both, but the first and most useful tool is simply recognising the mechanism: that the discomfort you feel about your body is, in significant part, an engineered discomfort, and its engineer is not your mirror.

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[15] Beat Eating Disorders, the UK charity, reported in 2023 that eating disorder referrals to NHS services had increased by approximately ninety percent over the previous five years, with the steepest increases in younger age groups. The causal relationship with social media is supported by correlational research and by the platform's own internal studies; establishing direct causality at a population level is methodologically complex, but the direction of the association is consistent.

[16] Muscle dysmorphia — sometimes called "reverse anorexia" — was formally described by Harrison Pope and colleagues in the late 1990s and has been the subject of growing research attention as rates appear to increase. A 2022 survey by the Mental Health Foundation found that one in five men had experienced depression because of concerns about their body image, a figure that is likely an underestimate given the documented tendency of men to underreport psychological distress.

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Navigation: The Tools for This Chapter

Psychologically: The relationship to the body in 2026 is, for many people, adversarial. The body is too tired, too heavy, too achy, too unreliable — a source of problems rather than a home. The psychological reorientation required is not dramatic self-love, which is a large ask and perhaps not the right frame for everyone. It is, more modestly, curiosity. What is the body telling you, when you pay attention? What does it need, when you ask rather than override? The body scan practice — lying still and systematically directing attention through each part of the body, from the feet upward, noticing sensation without judgement — is not primarily a relaxation technique. It is a practice in listening to the body as a source of information, which is what the body is, and which most people have, through inattention, stopped doing.

Physically: Three commitments, in order of impact:

First, sleep. The phone out of the bedroom. A consistent bedtime. These two things, done consistently, will produce more measurable improvement in daily function than almost any other single intervention available. This has been established at sufficient length elsewhere in this chapter to not require further argument. It simply requires doing.

Second, walking. Thirty minutes, outside, five days per week. Not the gym, not the fitness class, not the sport — though all of these are welcome additions. The walk is the minimum viable dose of movement for a functioning human body, and it is available to most people regardless of fitness level, time constraints, or financial resources. If thirty minutes is impossible, twenty is adequate. If twenty is impossible, ten is better than nothing and provides a foundation for more.

Third, one meal per day eaten at a table, without a screen, with some attention to what you are eating. Not every meal. One. The habit, once established, tends to expand.

Spiritually: The body is the primary site of your experience of being alive. Every moment of genuine presence — in nature, in conversation, in the sensory richness of physical existence — is experienced through it. The contemplative traditions that recommend attention to the breath are not recommending something mystical. They are recommending the most direct available route to the experience of being, physically and completely, here. The breath is always present. It is always now. It does not have a notification setting.

Spend some time outside. Not walking with purpose, not exercising, not going somewhere. Outside, for its own sake. Under the sky. In whatever weather is available. The sky is large, and the body, placed under it, tends to remember something it had quietly forgotten about the scale of things and its own place in them.

This is not therapy. It is not religion. It is the straightforward observation that human beings, evolved in the outdoor world, generally feel somewhat better when they spend some time in it. The research confirms this. Your body, if asked, will confirm it too.

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Next: Chapter Seven — Mindful Minds: Mental Health and Emotional Life

In which we establish that anxiety is not a character flaw, that loneliness is not a personal failure, and that the gap between what we feel and what we are permitted to admit we feel is one of the more unnecessary sources of suffering in the contemporary world.

✦

Chapter Seven: Mindful Minds — Mental Health and Emotional Life

✦

Anxiety is not a character flaw.

This needs saying clearly, at the start, because the experience of anxiety in 2026 is frequently accompanied by a secondary experience that is, in some ways, more damaging than the anxiety itself: the conviction that the anxiety represents a personal failure. That other people are managing fine. That the correct response to feeling overwhelmed by the pace and volume and pressure of contemporary life is to manage it better, think more positively, be more grateful, exercise more consistently, sleep better, eat more cleanly, and generally perform wellness with greater commitment and application.

None of this is wrong, exactly. Exercise helps. Sleep helps. Gratitude, practised genuinely rather than performed, helps. But the framing — that the problem is individual and the solution is individual — misses something important about the nature of what is actually happening.

What is actually happening is that a significant portion of the population is experiencing anxiety, loneliness, low mood, identity instability, and emotional exhaustion at rates that represent a genuine departure from historical baselines — not because this generation is weaker than previous ones, or less resilient, or more entitled, but because the conditions of contemporary life are, in specific and documentable ways, inimical to the things the mind needs to function well.[1] The mind needs periods of quiet. The conditions provide continuous stimulation. The mind needs stable social connection. The conditions provide abundant but shallow connection. The mind needs a coherent sense of self. The conditions provide an identity performance platform with real-time feedback metrics. The mind needs the experience of competence and completion. The conditions provide an infinite scroll that never ends and a to-do list that, by design, always grows.

The problem is real. The individuals experiencing it are not broken. The situation is.

This chapter does not promise to fix the situation. The situation is structural, and structural problems require structural responses that extend beyond the scope of any individual or any book. But it can offer something useful: an honest account of what is happening and why, and a set of tools that make navigating it somewhat less arduous.

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[1] The cross-national data on mental health is gathered by the WHO, among others, and shows consistent increases in anxiety and depression across the developed world since approximately 2012. The increase is not uniform — it is steepest among adolescents and young adults, and steeper among women than men — but it is present across age groups and genders in most high-income countries. The debate about causality is ongoing; the direction of the trends is not.

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I. Anxiety in the Feed Age

Anxiety, in its clinical sense, is a dysregulation of the threat response: the system that evolved to protect us from danger becoming activated in circumstances that do not represent danger, or remaining activated after the danger has passed, or operating at a chronic low level that constitutes a persistent state of alert without a specific threat to be alert to.

It is, in this sense, a rational system misfiring. Not a weakness. Not a failure of character. A rational system — one that has kept the species alive for a considerable time — operating in an environment it was not designed for.[2]

The contemporary information environment is, as we established in Chapter Two, specifically calibrated to activate the threat response. News that emphasises danger, conflict, and uncertainty. Social comparison that activates status anxiety. The constant availability of catastrophic information about distant events that the reader can do nothing about. The low-level social vigilance required to maintain an online presence. These inputs arrive continuously, at a rate that the threat response system was not designed to manage, and they produce — individually in manageable doses, cumulatively in the quantities actually delivered — a state of persistent mild activation that is, functionally, anxiety.

This is not the only source of anxiety in 2026. Financial insecurity produces anxiety. Relationship difficulty produces anxiety. Health concerns produce anxiety. Grief, uncertainty, the awareness of mortality — all of these are sources of anxiety that predate the smartphone and will persist after it. But the digital environment has added a layer that was not previously present, and that layer is not trivial.

The specific texture of digital anxiety is worth describing, because it is distinct from older forms and because recognising it is the first step in addressing it. It has a characteristic quality of diffuseness: it is anxiety without a clear object, a free-floating unease that is not attached to any specific threat but is present nonetheless. It arrives after a session of news consumption, or social media scrolling, or a sustained period of work communication. It has a quality of incompleteness — as if there is something that needs to be done or known or resolved, without it being clear what that something is. It is frequently accompanied by the impulse to check the phone, which is both the source of the anxiety and its most immediately available, least effective remedy.[3]

The recognition that this particular texture of unease is, in large part, a product of the digital environment — not a signal about your life, not evidence of something fundamentally wrong, but the specific psychological weather produced by a sustained diet of algorithmic content — is itself a significant tool. The anxiety that can be named and attributed is considerably more manageable than the anxiety that simply sits inside you, apparently self-generated, as evidence of your own disordered relationship to existence.

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[2] The evolutionary logic of anxiety is well described in Randolph Nesse's Good Reasons for Bad Feelings (2019), which argues that mental suffering, like physical pain, has evolutionary functions — that anxiety is the brain's smoke detector, calibrated to err on the side of false alarms because the cost of missing a real threat is higher than the cost of responding to a false one. The implication is that anxiety is not a malfunction but a feature, and that treating it as evidence of personal weakness is not only inaccurate but counterproductive.

[3] The impulse to check the phone when anxious is the digital equivalent of scratching an itch: it provides momentary relief through the displacement of attention and the delivery of a small dopamine signal, while doing nothing about the underlying irritant and frequently making it worse. The social media scroll that follows an anxiety-check typically produces further content calibrated to generate engagement — which, as we have established, means emotional arousal — thereby amplifying the state it was consulted to relieve. This is the loop. Naming it does not break it immediately. It begins the process of breaking it.

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II. The Loneliness Paradox

We touched on this in Chapter Four, in the context of friendship and connection. Here we want to dwell on it as a mental health phenomenon in its own right, because loneliness — genuine, chronic loneliness — is not a mild inconvenience. It is a significant health risk, with physiological consequences comparable to smoking fifteen cigarettes per day, and psychological consequences that include elevated rates of depression, anxiety, cognitive decline, and — at its most extreme — suicidal ideation.[4]

The paradox of contemporary loneliness is that it coexists with unprecedented quantities of social contact. The person who is profoundly lonely in 2026 is not, in most cases, socially isolated in the traditional sense. They have contacts. They have followers. They communicate with people every day, through multiple channels. They are, by any quantitative measure, more socially connected than anyone who was lonely in 1920.

They are also, in the relevant sense, not known.

The distinction between social contact and genuine connection is not subtle. It is experienced acutely by anyone who has spent a weekend in a state of continuous digital interaction — messages sent and received, content liked and shared, comments made and replied to — and arrived at Sunday evening feeling more isolated than they began. The contact happened. The connection did not. The mind knows the difference, even when the metrics suggest otherwise.

Genuine connection requires mutual knowledge — the experience of being seen accurately by another person, which is distinct from being observed, and which requires a depth of disclosure and attention that most digital interaction does not provide. It requires time — not the time measured in messages per day but the time measured in shared experience, in the accumulation of ordinary moments that constitute a relationship. It requires vulnerability — the willingness to be known imperfectly, which is the only way actual people can be known, rather than to maintain the curated version that the social media environment rewards.

None of these requirements are impossible to meet online. But they are harder to meet online than in person, and the digital environment provides, at every moment, an easier alternative that meets the need less well while reducing the urgency that might otherwise drive the person toward the harder and more nourishing thing.[5]

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[4] The health consequences of loneliness are documented most comprehensively in the work of Julianne Holt-Lunstad at Brigham Young University, whose 2015 meta-analysis found that social isolation increased the risk of premature mortality by approximately twenty-six percent, comparable to the risk associated

with smoking fifteen cigarettes per day. The comparison is deliberately striking. It has not produced a public health response proportionate to the scale of the problem, which is itself an interesting datum about which health risks we take seriously and which we do not.

[5] This is the core argument of Sherry Turkle's Alone Together (2011) and Reclaiming Conversation (2015), both of which argue that digital communication, while real and valuable, is producing a retreat from the more demanding and more nourishing forms of face-to-face engagement. Turkle's observation that we are "always on" but frequently less present than ever is borne out by subsequent research on conversation quality, attention during interactions, and the declining rates of deep conversation reported in friendship surveys.

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III. The Identity Mirror

Who are you when nobody is watching?

This is not a rhetorical question. It is, in the social media era, a genuinely practical one — because the infrastructure of the current moment makes the state of not being watched increasingly rare, and because the self that is constituted in continuous performance is, necessarily, a somewhat different self from the one that exists in its absence.

The psychologist Erik Erikson described identity development as a process of individuation — the gradual clarification, through experience and reflection, of a stable sense of who one is, distinct from the roles and expectations of others.[6] This process requires, as a minimum condition, some privacy: some interior space in which the self can exist without immediate feedback, where the half-formed thought can be thought before it is expressed, where the uncertain identity can be uncertain without the uncertainty being visible and therefore immediately judged.

The social media environment does not provide this condition. It provides its opposite: a platform on which every aspect of the developing self can be immediately shared, immediately assessed, and immediately incorporated into the social feedback loop that the algorithm has made the primary source of self-evaluation for a significant portion of the population.

The result is what we might call the identity mirror problem: the self, which needs a period of formation before it is ready for the audience, is formed in front of the audience, under the audience's continuous and quantified scrutiny, and shaped by that scrutiny in ways that may or may not be consistent with what the self, given privacy and time, would have become on its own.

This is not a problem of authenticity in the simple sense — the social media self is not straightforwardly false. It is a problem of sequence: the performance is happening before the formation is complete, and the performance is influencing the formation, and nobody has quite acknowledged that this is an arrangement with consequences.

For adults, the consequences are real but generally manageable: the self is formed enough to have some independent stability, and the performance layer sits over something that exists prior to it. For adolescents, whose identity is being formed in real time, under public scrutiny, with real-time feedback, the consequences are more significant — which is why we addressed them in detail in Chapter Five.

For adults, the question worth sitting with is simpler: who are you when you are not performing? Not to suggest that the performing self is invalid. To notice whether there is still someone there when the audience logs off.

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[6] Erik Erikson's developmental framework, outlined in Identity: Youth and Crisis (1968), describes identity formation as the central developmental task of adolescence — a period of productive uncertainty in which the young person experiments with different roles, values, and self-conceptions before arriving at a stable identity. His concept of "identity moratorium" — the necessary period of exploration before commitment — requires exactly the kind of private, low-stakes experimentation that the public, high-stakes social media environment does not provide.

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IV. FOMO, Comparison, and the Happiness Gap

The fear of missing out — FOMO, a term that achieved such rapid cultural saturation that it was added to the Oxford English Dictionary in 2013 — is not a product of the smartphone. The awareness that somewhere else, something more interesting might be happening, and that the life you are living is therefore potentially not the best available life, is as old as the capacity to imagine alternatives.

What the smartphone has done is make the alternatives visible. Continuously. In curated and compelling form.

The comparison that produces unhappiness is not, primarily, the comparison between your life and the lives of people who are genuinely, materially better off than you. Research on this consistently finds that absolute deprivation is less corrosive to wellbeing than relative deprivation — that the person in genuine poverty suffers less from comparison than the person in moderate comfort who is surrounded by evidence of lives that are more comfortable still.[7] What the social media feed provides, in quantities no previous generation encountered, is exactly this: an environment in which the comparison class — the people against whom you implicitly measure your life — has expanded from your immediate social circle to include anyone whose carefully curated highlights are accessible on your screen.

The comparison class, in 1920, was your village. The village contained people who were better and worse off than you in ways that were visible, legible, and embedded in a shared context you understood. The comparison class in 2026 includes, among others, influencers whose income is generated by the appearance of living extraordinarily well, celebrities who have professional teams managing their image, ordinary people whose posts represent the best two percent of their lives photographed in optimal conditions, and the former romantic partner who appears, with suspicious regularity, to be having a substantially better time than you.

The mind makes comparisons because comparison is a primary tool for self-assessment — for establishing where you are and how you are doing relative to others, which has survival relevance in social species. The mind was not designed for a comparison class of several billion people, most of whom are presenting curated highlights. It is doing its best with what it has been given. What it has been given is not representative.[8]

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[7] This is the finding of relative deprivation theory, originally developed by Samuel Stouffer in the 1940s and extensively refined since. The consistent finding — that wellbeing is more affected by one's position relative to a reference group than by one's absolute material conditions — has been replicated across cultures and time periods and provides the psychological basis for understanding why increasing wealth in the developed world has not produced proportionate increases in reported happiness.

[8] The research on social media and happiness is complicated by the fact that correlation and causality are genuinely difficult to separate. People who are unhappy may use social media more, rather than social media causing unhappiness. The most careful current reading of the evidence — including experimental studies in which people are randomly assigned to reduce or eliminate social media use — suggests the relationship is bidirectional, but that the causal direction from social media to unhappiness is real, particularly for passive use and for users with high baseline social comparison orientation.

✦

V. Emotional Norms Across the Three Lenses

The experience of mental and emotional difficulty has not changed dramatically across the three lenses. What has changed is the framework within which it is understood and expressed.

In 1920, the dominant emotional norm — in most of the developed world, and particularly for men — was stoicism. Not the philosophical tradition of Marcus Aurelius and Epictetus, which is a sophisticated and genuinely useful framework for emotional management, but its cultural reduction: the injunction to endure difficulty without expression, to not make a fuss, to keep going. This norm had the virtue of producing a kind of functional resilience — people got on with things, because the alternative was not available — and the vice of producing, beneath the getting-on-with-things, a reservoir of unprocessed emotional experience that found expression in ways that were frequently not helpful: alcohol, physical illness, the particular bitterness of the person who has been telling themselves for decades that they are fine and has almost convinced themselves it is true.

Mental illness in 1920 was not called mental illness. It was called weakness, or nerves, or nothing at all — the absence of language being its own form of treatment, in the sense that a thing without a name is difficult to seek help for. The asylum was available for those whose suffering had become undeniable. For everyone else, there was the stoic norm and, for those with access to them, the limited interventions of early psychiatry.[9]

By the nineties, the framework had shifted substantially. The language of mental health had entered common usage. The concept of therapy — previously the province of the wealthy and the severely ill — was becoming normalised for ordinary people with ordinary difficulties. The stigma was reduced, not eliminated. Depression and anxiety were beginning to be understood as conditions amenable to treatment rather than evidence of moral weakness. The anti-depressant had arrived, with significant consequences for both the treatment of depression and the cultural understanding of what depression is.

In 2026, the language of mental health has become so thoroughly integrated into ordinary discourse that it is, in some contexts, difficult to distinguish between the clinical use of terms like anxiety and depression and their colloquial use as descriptions of ordinary discomfort. I'm so anxious about this meeting and I have an anxiety disorder are not the same statement, but they use the same word, and the conflation has consequences in both directions: it can reduce the stigma of genuine clinical difficulty by normalising the

vocabulary of mental struggle, and it can obscure the severity of genuine clinical difficulty by suggesting that the anxiety of the person who worries about meetings is structurally the same as the anxiety of the person who cannot leave their house.[10]

What is clearly positive: more people are seeking help. More people have the language for what they are experiencing. More people understand that psychological suffering is not a moral failing and that treatment works. These are genuine gains, thirty years in the making, and they deserve acknowledgement.

What is less clear: whether the cultural saturation of wellness language — the meditation apps, the therapy-speak, the gratitude journals — is producing better mental health outcomes in aggregate, or whether it is providing the vocabulary and the performance of wellbeing without the structural conditions that actually produce it.

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[9] The history of mental illness treatment is not a comfortable read. The progress from the asylum to the community to the talking therapy to the pharmaceutical has been genuine but not linear, and the current state — in which NHS mental health services in England have waiting times of months for a first appointment, while a meditation app subscription is available immediately — is not obviously the destination the progress was heading toward.

[10] The psychologist Lucy Foulkes makes this argument carefully in her 2021 book Losing Our Minds, which distinguishes between mental health (a spectrum everyone is on, the promotion of which is genuinely valuable) and mental illness (clinical conditions requiring specific treatment, the prevalence of which is not served by conflation with ordinary emotional difficulty). Her argument is not that suffering should be minimised but that accurate language matters, and that the current cultural tendency to pathologise ordinary experience may be producing anxiety about anxiety — the meta-experience of worrying that your worry constitutes a disorder.

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VI. Self-Esteem, Self-Compassion, and the Internal Critic

There is, in most people's minds, a voice that comments on their performance. It notices the mistake in the meeting. It replays the social interaction that went slightly wrong. It observes the gap between what was attempted and what was achieved, and delivers a verdict. In most people, this voice is not particularly kind.

Self-esteem — the evaluation of one's own worth — has been the subject of several decades of psychological research, a great deal of popular self-help, and a school of educational intervention that taught a generation of children that feeling good about themselves was the prerequisite of achievement, which turned out to be slightly the wrong way around.[11] The research on self-esteem as a target for intervention is, at best, mixed. High self-esteem is associated with positive outcomes, but attempts to directly raise self-esteem without the underlying competence and genuine accomplishment that produce it tend to produce fragility rather than resilience — the person who has been told they are wonderful and is devastated when the world declines to confirm it.

The more robust construct, which has received substantially more attention from researchers in the last twenty years, is self-compassion: the capacity to treat oneself with the same care and understanding that one would offer a good friend in difficulty. Not to lower standards, not to avoid accountability, but to respond to one's own failures and suffering with kindness rather than contempt.

Kristin Neff, whose research has defined the field, identifies three components of self-compassion: self-kindness (treating oneself with care rather than harsh judgement), common humanity (recognising that suffering and failure are universal rather than evidence of personal inadequacy), and mindfulness (holding painful thoughts and feelings in balanced awareness rather than suppressing or over-identifying with them).[12] These three components work together as a system, and the second — common humanity — is perhaps the most important and the most difficult to maintain in an environment that provides, through social media, constant evidence that everyone else appears to be managing considerably better.

They are not. They are curating. The internal critic, which has access to all of your worst moments and none of theirs, is making an unfair comparison with imperfect data. The self-compassion practice begins with this recognition: that the evidence on which the internal critic is operating is not representative, and that the verdict it delivers on the basis of that evidence is, accordingly, unreliable.

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[11] The self-esteem movement in education, which peaked in the 1980s and 1990s, was based on the theory that low self-esteem was the root cause of most social problems and that raising it would produce a cascade of positive outcomes. Subsequent research found that self-esteem was more effect than cause — that it rose as a result of genuine achievement and positive social experience rather than producing them — and that the direct attempts to boost it without the underlying substance produced, in some cases, entitled fragility rather than confident resilience. The educational enthusiasm for self-esteem work has since been substantially revised.

[12] Kristin Neff's foundational paper on self-compassion was published in 2003; her book Self-Compassion: The Proven Power of Being Kind to Yourself (2011) remains the most accessible introduction to the research and practice. Her subsequent collaborations with Christopher Germer on mindful self-compassion have extended both the research base and the clinical application.

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VII. Low Frustration Tolerance and the Instant World

We touched on this in Chapter Two. It deserves its own section here, because it is one of the more significant psychological consequences of the digital environment and one of the least discussed.

Frustration tolerance — the capacity to persist through difficulty, delay, and discomfort without catastrophising or abandoning the task — is not a fixed trait. It is a skill, built through the accumulated experience of encountering difficulty and discovering that it is manageable. The child who waits, who tries and fails and tries again, who sits with a problem long enough for something to shift, is building a capacity that will serve them throughout a life that will contain, on the evidence of all previous lives, a substantial quantity of difficulty, delay, and discomfort.

The digital environment removes, systematically, the conditions under which this capacity is built. Information is instant. Entertainment is instant. Connection is instant. The discomfort of not knowing, of waiting, of being unable to immediately resolve a question or access a desired experience, is now solvable in seconds, which means the discomfort is never held long enough to be moved through.

The clinical consequence is visible in therapy practices, in schools, and in the workplace: a generalised difficulty with delay and uncertainty that is not pathological in the clinical sense but is significant in its effects — on the capacity to complete difficult projects, to maintain commitments through hard periods, to tolerate the ordinary frustrations of relationships and work without immediately seeking relief.

The remedy is, again, embarrassingly simple and genuinely effortful: practice waiting. Not as punishment, not in large doses, but as a deliberate and regular experience of sitting with a small discomfort long enough to discover that it passes. The phone in the other room. The question held rather than immediately Googled. The difficult conversation completed rather than avoided. The book read to the end of the chapter rather than abandoned when the chapter becomes slow. These are small exercises. They build something real.[13]

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[13] The psychological research on frustration tolerance is located within the broader literature on self-regulation and delay of gratification, associated with the Marshmallow Test studies of Walter Mischel in the 1960s and the substantial body of work on executive function that followed. The finding that the ability to delay gratification in childhood predicts positive outcomes in adulthood has been qualified by subsequent research — it is more contextually dependent than the original framing suggested — but the core relationship between self-regulatory capacity and life functioning remains robust.

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VIII. Gender and Emotional Life

The gender dimension of mental health in 2026 runs in two directions that are, in certain respects, mirror images of each other.

Women, on average, are more likely to experience and report anxiety and depression. They are more likely to seek help for these conditions. They are more likely to have the social support networks and the emotional vocabulary that facilitate both recognition and recovery. The rates of eating disorders, self-harm, and anxiety among women and girls have risen sharply in the social media era, for reasons we have examined in detail.

The cost of this pattern is real and significant. It is also, to some degree, the cost of a system that works: women are suffering and seeking help, which means the suffering is visible and can be addressed.

Men, on average, are more likely to experience and less likely to report or seek help for mental health difficulties. They are more likely to externalise distress — through anger, substance use, risk-taking — rather than to identify and express it as distress. They are significantly more likely to die by suicide. The rates of male loneliness, social isolation, and what researchers cautiously describe as "deaths of despair" — suicide, drug overdose, alcohol-related death — have risen consistently over the last twenty years.[14]

The cost of this pattern is also real and significant. It is, in one sense, the cost of a system that does not work: men are suffering and not seeking help, which means the suffering is less visible and less likely to be addressed before it becomes severe.

The cultural pressure on men not to express vulnerability or need is not imaginary. It is present, it is early-installed, and it is reinforced by many of the online communities — the fitness culture, the financial success culture, the explicit masculinity movements — that are most actively courted by the digital economy. It is also, increasingly, being challenged: the range of voices available to young men that model emotional openness and the seeking of help has expanded substantially, and this matters. Cultural change of this kind is slow and real, and its early signs deserve acknowledgement.

The goal is not for men to become more like women in their emotional expression, nor for women to become more like men in their stoicism. The goal is for both to have access to the full range of human emotional experience and the full range of human responses to difficulty — including, prominently, the ability to ask for help from another person when help is needed.

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[14] The "deaths of despair" framework was developed by economists Anne Case and Angus Deaton in their 2020 book of the same name, examining the rise in mortality among middle-aged white Americans from suicide, drug overdose, and alcoholic liver disease. The pattern is most pronounced in the United States but visible, in varying degrees, across other high-income countries, and is associated with the combination of economic decline in particular communities, social disconnection, and the inadequacy of available mental health support.

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Navigation: The Tools for This Chapter

Psychologically: Three tools, in order of accessibility.

The first is naming. The anxiety that can be named — identified as anxiety rather than experienced as undifferentiated unease, located in its likely source (the news, the social media, the unresolved work situation), acknowledged as a feeling rather than a fact about the world — is significantly more manageable than the anxiety that is simply present. This is the foundational move of cognitive behavioural therapy, and it does not require a therapist to begin: when the feeling arrives, pause, name it, locate it, and ask whether it is telling you something you need to act on or something you need to sit with until it passes.

The second is cognitive reframing: the practice of examining the story the mind is telling about a situation and asking whether alternative stories are available. The story everyone is judging me is rarely accurate, but it is not disprovable from the inside. The reframe is not nobody is judging me — which is also not necessarily accurate — but I don't know what other people are thinking, and the story I'm telling myself about it may not be the only available story, or the most useful one. This is not positive thinking. It is epistemically honest thinking, which is a different and more durable thing.

The third is boundary-setting as a psychological practice: the recognition that mental energy is finite, that the demands made on it in 2026 routinely exceed its sustainable capacity, and that the regular refusal of some demands is not selfishness but maintenance. Learning to say no — to the additional commitment, the after-hours message, the obligation that is being taken on because the discomfort of declining feels worse than the cost of accepting — is a skill that protects the capacity for everything else.

Physically: The body-mind connection in emotional regulation is genuine and well-documented. The simplest available physical intervention for acute anxiety is breath regulation: extending the exhale to twice the length of the inhale activates the parasympathetic nervous system and produces measurable reductions in heart rate and cortisol within minutes.[15] Four counts in, hold for two, eight counts out. Do this for ninety seconds. It works, in the specific and limited sense of reducing acute physiological arousal. It does not solve the problem that produced the anxiety. It creates the conditions in which the problem can be addressed more clearly.

Regular gentle exercise — the walk, the swim, the cycle — has consistent and well-evidenced effects on mood, anxiety, and depression, comparable in some studies to pharmaceutical intervention for mild to moderate depression. It works. It is free, available, and does not require a prescription.

Spiritually: Contemplative practice — in whatever form fits you — is the subject of the next chapter. Here it is worth noting its mental health dimension: the regular practice of present-moment attention, whether through formal meditation, through prayer, through contemplative movement, or through the simple practice of sitting quietly without input, produces, over time, a reduction in the mind's tendency toward rumination — the circular, compulsive re-engagement with difficult thoughts that characterises both anxiety and depression — and an increase in the capacity to observe thoughts without being entirely captured by them.

You are not your thoughts. This sounds like a piece of motivational poster wisdom, and in that context it is not very useful. As a neurological observation — that the thoughts arising in the mind are events in the mind, not the mind itself, and that the observing capacity that notices the thought is distinct from the thought being observed — it is one of the more useful things cognitive science and the contemplative traditions have found to agree on.

The thought that you are failing. The thought that things will not improve. The thought that everyone is judging you and finding you wanting. These are thoughts. They arise, as thoughts do. The question is not whether they arise — you cannot prevent them — but how long you remain in them before the observing capacity notices that they are there, names them as thoughts rather than facts, and creates enough distance from them to choose what to do next.

That distance is cultivated, not given. It grows with practice. It is worth growing.

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[15] The physiological mechanism is the stimulation of the vagus nerve through extended exhalation, which activates the parasympathetic nervous system — the "rest and digest" system that counteracts the "fight or flight" response. The technique has been formalised in various breath practices, including box breathing (used by military personnel for stress management), 4-7-8 breathing (popularised by Andrew Weil), and the physiological sigh (a double inhale followed by extended exhale, researched by Andrew Huberman and colleagues at Stanford). The underlying mechanism is the same in all cases.

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Next: Chapter Eight — Sacred Earth, Sacred Self: Spiritual Life and Meaning

In which we ask the oldest question — what does this mean? — and discover that the answer is available, in recognisable form, in the same places it has always been. We have simply stopped looking there, on the grounds that our phones were more immediately interesting.

✦

Chapter Eight: Sacred Earth, Sacred Self — Spiritual Life and Meaning

✦

There is a philosopher whose complete works are available, free, on the internet. His name is Marcus Aurelius. He was Emperor of Rome from 161 to 180 CE, commanded armies, administered an empire of several million people, survived plague, war, and the particular daily grief of watching people he loved die, and in the margins of all of this wrote, in a private journal never intended for publication, a sustained meditation on how to live well in conditions of genuine difficulty.

He covered, among other topics: the management of anxiety, the practice of present-moment attention, the productive contemplation of mortality, the cultivation of equanimity in the face of circumstances beyond one's control, the importance of community and service, and the question of what, precisely, a human life is for.

His reflections — published as Meditations — are available in multiple translations on Project Gutenberg, which is free. The audiobook version is available on several platforms for the cost of a single month's subscription. A physical copy can be purchased for less than the price of a coffee.

And yet.[1]

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[1] The global meditation app market was valued at approximately two and a half billion dollars in 2023 and is projected to continue growing. The works of the Stoic philosophers, the Buddhist suttas, the Sufi poets, the Christian mystics, and the Taoist sages — collectively representing several thousand years of sustained human inquiry into the question of how to live — are available free. The market for guided breathing exercises by people with soothing voices is considerably more commercially vigorous than the market for the original sources. This is not a criticism of guided breathing exercises, which are genuinely useful. It is an observation about what the market rewards.

✦

I. What Is Meaning, and Where Has It Gone?

Meaning is not happiness. This distinction, which sounds academic, is practically important.

Happiness, in the hedonic sense — the experience of pleasure, positive emotion, and the absence of pain — is a real and valuable thing, and there is nothing wrong with wanting it. But it is also, by its nature, transient. It arises in response to circumstances and subsides when those circumstances change. The person who is happy because things are going well is correctly calibrated to reality. They are also, therefore, at the mercy of reality, and reality has a long history of changing.

Meaning is different in structure. It is the experience of one's life as mattering — as connected to something beyond the immediate moment, as part of a story that has direction and significance. It is possible to experience meaning in the midst of difficulty, which happiness, in the hedonic sense, cannot

survive. Viktor Frankl, who developed his psychology of meaning in the specific and extreme conditions of a Nazi concentration camp, observed that the people who survived psychologically were not necessarily those in the best physical conditions but those who retained a sense of why their survival mattered.[2] His framework, logotherapy, is sometimes dismissed as circumstantially specific — most of us are not in concentration camps, thank God — but its core finding translates: meaning is the structure that holds the self together under pressure, and its absence leaves the self exposed.

The question of where meaning is found is answered differently by different traditions, but with a consistency that is itself informative. Almost every sustained human inquiry into the question of meaning — philosophical, theological, psychological — arrives at the same broad answer: meaning is found in connection (to other people, to a community, to a tradition), in contribution (doing something that matters beyond the self), in contemplation (attending to the depth of experience rather than its surface), and in the confrontation with finitude (the recognition that life ends, which gives it weight).

These four sources have in common that they are not passive. They require something from the person. They require presence, which the digital environment systematically undermines. They require time, which the digital environment systematically colonises. They require the willingness to be in contact with difficulty — including the difficulty of other people, the difficulty of sustained practice, the difficulty of sitting with mortality — which the digital environment systematically provides alternatives to.

This is why meaning is in difficulty in 2026. Not because the sources have disappeared. They have not. Because the conditions that allow their cultivation have been substantially eroded by an environment optimised for something else entirely.

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[2] Viktor Frankl's Man's Search for Meaning (1946) describes his experiences in Auschwitz and Dachau and the psychological observations he made there, which formed the basis of logotherapy. It remains one of the most widely read books in psychology. The central claim — that the primary human motivation is not pleasure (Freud) or power (Adler) but the search for meaning — is, on the evidence of research and of experience, more accurate than either of its competitors.

✦

II. Through the Three Lenses: Spiritual Life in Time

1920

The spiritual life of 1920 was, for most people in the developed world, structured by religion in ways we have already touched on in Chapter One. But it is worth returning to the structural features of that religious life — the ones that are most relevant to the question of meaning — because they are not merely historical curiosities.

The weekly gathering. The shared story. The ritual that marked the transitions of life — birth, coming of age, marriage, death — with a form that was communal, repeated, and therefore reliable. The acknowledgement, in every service and in much of the surrounding culture, that individual human life was part of something larger: a tradition, a community, a cosmos, a divine order, depending on the specific form.

These structures provided meaning not because they were necessarily true — the truth claims of religious traditions are various, contested, and not the subject of this book — but because they were social. The meaning they offered was not generated privately, in the individual mind, but publicly, in shared practice and shared story. This is important, because the research on meaning consistently finds that it is not primarily a private psychological state but a social construction: it is made between people, in shared narrative and shared action, and it requires community to sustain it.[3]

The pre-1920 spiritual life was also embedded in the natural world in a way that the urban, electrified, screen-mediated world of 2026 has largely lost. The agricultural calendar — the planting, the growing, the harvest, the fallow — gave human time a shape that corresponded to natural cycles in a way that the digital calendar, which has no seasons and no dark months, does not. The night sky, before electric light, was visibly present in a way that it is not for most people in cities: the Milky Way visible, the stars comprehensibly numerous, the human position in the cosmos legible in a way that a night sky washed out by light pollution is not.

This is not nostalgia for a simpler time. The connection to natural cycles in 1920 was, for most people, a necessity and frequently a hardship. It is being noted here as a source of meaning that has been quietly lost, and whose loss has consequences that most people do not directly attribute to it.

1995–2006

The spiritual landscape of the mid-nineties was in productive, if somewhat eclectic, transition. The formal religious structures of the previous century were declining in the developed West — church attendance falling, institutional trust eroding, the authority of organised religion challenged by the various scandals that were, in this period, beginning to reach public awareness. Into the space they had occupied came a variety of alternatives.

Yoga, as noted in Chapter One, was moving from the margins into the mainstream. Meditation was attracting serious research attention — the work of Jon Kabat-Zinn on Mindfulness-Based Stress Reduction had, by the mid-nineties, established a scientific framework for what had previously been considered a purely contemplative practice.[4] The New Age, in its many and various forms, was providing a market for spiritual experience that was personalised, non-dogmatic, and available without the institutional commitments and moral obligations of traditional religion.

The spiritual seeking of this period was genuine. The proliferation of paths was, in many ways, liberating — the person who found the available tradition too constraining could now find a practice that fit their specific configuration of belief and temperament. But the seeking, increasingly, was individual. The communal structures of spiritual life — the shared practice, the collective narrative, the mutual accountability of belonging to a tradition with specific requirements — were precisely the features being discarded along with the dogma.

The baby, it turned out, had some legitimate uses. The bathwater was still bathwater.

2026

The spiritual landscape of 2026 is abundant in supply and impoverished in infrastructure.

There are more practices available — more teachers, more traditions, more apps, more retreats, more podcasts about consciousness and presence and the examined life — than at any previous point in human history. The Headspace app has more users than most religious denominations have congregants. Calm has been downloaded several hundred million times.[5] The search for meaning has never been more commercially catered to.

The structural problem is that most of what is being sold is experience without obligation, practice without community, and stillness without the social architecture that gave stillness its meaning. The meditation app provides a few minutes of guided attention that is genuinely calming. It does not provide the community that gathers to sit together regularly over years, developing a shared understanding and a mutual accountability that the solitary practice cannot replicate. It does not provide the ritual that marks the passing of significant events in a life. It does not provide the tradition — the accumulated wisdom of people who have practised this for generations — because the app, understandably, wants to be accessible to everyone, and a tradition that is accessible to everyone is, by definition, not a tradition.

The result is what has been called spiritual atomisation: the distribution of the spiritual impulse across millions of individual practices, apps, and approaches, each person constructing their own meaning system from whatever components are available, without the communal scaffolding that makes meaning systems durable under pressure.[6]

This is not without value. The individual practice is real. The solitary contemplation is real. The meaning that a person constructs privately, from the available materials, is not fake. But it tends to be fragile in ways that communally-held meaning is not, because the community that holds the meaning is also there to hold the person when the meaning temporarily fails, which it will, because meaning, like faith, is not a permanent state but a practice that requires continuous renewal.

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[3] The sociological argument for the communal basis of meaning-making is associated primarily with Émile Durkheim, whose 1912 work The Elementary Forms of Religious Life argued that the experience of the sacred — of something beyond the individual self — is fundamentally a social experience, produced by collective ritual rather than individual contemplation. His framework has been extended and refined by subsequent sociologists; its core insight remains the basis of most sociological thinking about religion and meaning.

[4] Jon Kabat-Zinn's Mindfulness-Based Stress Reduction programme was developed at the University of Massachusetts Medical Center from 1979 onward, and represents the most successful translation of contemplative practice into a secular clinical framework. His 1990 book Full Catastrophe Living brought the framework to a wider audience. The subsequent explosion of mindfulness research — thousands of peer-reviewed papers on its effects on anxiety, depression, chronic pain, and wellbeing — owes its existence largely to his willingness to make the practice legible to the scientific community.

[5] Usage figures for meditation apps are self-reported by the companies and should be treated with appropriate scepticism. The order of magnitude — hundreds of millions of downloads — is, however, plausible and is consistent with the broader growth of the wellness market.

[6] The term and the analysis are associated with the sociologist Robert Bellah and colleagues, whose 1985 book Habits of the Heart documented the rise of what they called "Sheilaism" — a form of private religion named after an interviewee who described her spiritual practice as "just my own little voice." Their concern was not the privatisation of practice per se but the erosion of the communal language and shared story that makes private practice meaningful in relation to others.

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III. What the Traditions Know

One of the more interesting features of the accumulated spiritual wisdom of humanity is how much it agrees on, across traditions that were developed in very different geographical, cultural, and theological contexts.

The Stoics — Marcus Aurelius, Epictetus, Seneca — agree with the Buddhist tradition on the central importance of accepting what cannot be changed and directing attention toward what can. They agree on the value of present-moment awareness, on the impermanence of all things, on the practice of contemplating death as a tool for living more fully. They do not agree on metaphysics — on what the cosmos is and what our place in it consists of — but they agree on practice, which is perhaps more useful.

The Sufi tradition — the mystical dimension of Islam, expressed most beautifully in the poetry of Rumi and Hafiz — agrees with the Christian mystics (Meister Eckhart, Julian of Norwich, Thomas Merton) on the primacy of the experience of union with something beyond the self, achieved through the surrender of the ego's insistence on its own centrality. The path to this experience is described differently in each tradition — for Rumi, it involves the radical opening of the heart; for the Zen tradition, the dissolution of the conceptual mind through paradox and direct experience; for the Stoics, the rational acceptance of one's place in a rational cosmos — but the destination is recognisably similar: a state of expanded awareness in which the ordinary anxiety of the separate self is temporarily relieved.[7]

What the traditions also agree on — and this is the point most directly relevant to the concerns of this book — is that this expanded awareness is not produced by passive consumption of content about it. It is produced by practice. By showing up, regularly, to the specific discipline of the tradition, with a commitment that is maintained through the periods when it does not feel like it is doing anything, because those periods are part of the practice.

The meditation app knows this. It is why the apps track streaks — the consecutive days of practice — because the designers understand that consistency is where the value accumulates. But the streak tracker is not the practice. It is the quantification of the practice. And there is a difference between the person who meditates because they want to and the person who meditates because they do not want to break their streak that is, in the experience of anyone who has observed both, visible and significant.

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[7] The comparative study of mystical experience across traditions is a substantial academic field. William James's The Varieties of Religious Experience (1902) is the founding text; Aldous Huxley's The Perennial Philosophy (1945) is the most readable synthesis of the cross-traditional argument; more recent academic work by scholars like Robert Forman and Jorge Ferrer has both extended and complicated the perennialist

position. The debate about whether mystical experience across traditions is truly convergent or merely superficially similar is ongoing and probably not resolvable, but the practical convergence on methods and values is, for the purposes of this book, the relevant point.

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IV. The Loss of Awe

There is a particular quality of experience that psychologists have, in the last two decades, begun to study seriously under the name of awe: the response to something that is vast enough to challenge the existing frameworks of the mind, and that produces, in its wake, a characteristic cluster of effects — a quieting of the self-referential mind, an expanded sense of time, a reduction in the usual preoccupations of the ego, and a sense of connection to something beyond the individual.[8]

Awe is produced by the natural world — a mountain range, a starry sky, an ocean — and by great art, and by witnessing extraordinary human capacity, and by encounters with profound suffering or profound beauty that exceed the mind's ordinary categories. It is produced by religious experience, and by the experience of love at its deepest, and by the birth of children, and by the awareness of death.

What it requires, as a minimum condition, is attention. The awe response cannot be triggered by content you are glancing at between notifications. It requires the full presence of the perceiving mind, turned toward the thing, long enough for the thing's magnitude to register.

This is precisely the condition that the digital environment most consistently prevents.

The average person in 2026 encounters, daily, more images of mountains, oceans, and extraordinary natural phenomena than any person in the entire history of humanity prior to the photograph. They encounter them on their phones, between other content, for a fraction of a second each, at a volume and a pace that is incompatible with the attentional dwelling that the awe response requires. The images are beautiful. They do not produce awe. They produce the mild, momentary pleasure of aesthetic recognition — nice mountain — and then the next thing arrives.

This is not the fault of the mountains. The mountains are as awe-inducing as they have ever been. The problem is the medium, which has inserted itself between the perceiving mind and the thing perceived in a way that prevents the contact from which awe arises.

The remedy is not to stop looking at photographs of mountains. It is, where possible, to also see some mountains. And to stand in front of them, without the phone, long enough for the mind to exhaust its initial catalogue of responses — this is beautiful, I should photograph it, I wonder if I have signal — and arrive, on the far side of those responses, at the thing itself.

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[8] The psychology of awe has been developed primarily by Dacher Keltner at UC Berkeley and Jonathan Haidt, whose 2003 paper "Approaching Awe: A Moral, Spiritual, and Aesthetic Emotion" established the research framework. Keltner's 2023 book Awe: The New Science of Everyday Wonder brings together fifteen years of subsequent research, including cross-cultural studies that find the awe response is universal but its triggers vary by culture. The consistent finding that awe reduces self-focused thinking and increases prosocial behaviour is among the most interesting results in the literature.

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V. Ritual and Its Functions

Ritual is the technology of meaning-making, and it is one of the things the modern world has most thoroughly misunderstood.

The instinct to dismiss ritual as superstition — as the residue of pre-scientific thinking, to be discarded along with the beliefs that produced it — misses the point of what ritual is and what it does. Ritual is not primarily a set of beliefs in action. It is a technology for doing things with time and experience that cannot be done any other way.

What ritual does: it marks transitions. The move from one state to another — child to adult, single to married, living to dead, ordinary time to sacred time — is not, in ordinary experience, a clean break. It requires a form, a container, a recognised and shared acknowledgement that something has changed, in order to be psychologically complete. Without the form, the transition remains ambiguous, the new state unstable, the meaning of the change unavailable to the people for whom it matters.

The contemporary secular world has retained some rituals — the wedding, the funeral, the graduation — while dispensing with most of the smaller ones that gave daily and weekly life its texture. The Sunday dinner. The prayer before meals. The seasonal celebration that was genuinely tied to the season. The daily practice — morning or evening — of setting aside time for something beyond the functional. These small rituals are not religiously significant in themselves. They are structurally significant: they create regular moments of interruption in the flow of ordinary time, in which the person is, briefly, doing something that is not instrumental, not productive, not aimed at an outcome. They create time that is other — set apart, in the original sense of the word sacred — from the time of work and consumption and digital distraction.

The TikTok challenge is not a ritual, in this sense. It has the form — the shared action, the participation, the sense of belonging to something collective — but it lacks the function. It does not mark a transition. It does not create time that is other. It is performed for the algorithm and assessed by the algorithm and its meaning, such as it is, is measured by the algorithm's response.[9]

This is not nothing. The human impulse toward collective, repeated, meaningful action is so powerful that it finds expression even in the flat, commercial, attention-economy environment of social media. The challenge is a degraded ritual. But it is still reaching toward something that ritual does, which suggests the need is present even when the form is inadequate.

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[9] The anthropologist Barbara Myerhoff, in her work on ritual in secular communities, observed that the capacity for ritual is universal but the specific forms it takes are culturally constructed and culturally maintained. The decay of traditional ritual forms does not eliminate the ritual impulse — it displaces it, into the available cultural materials. The standing ovation at a performance, the birthday dinner, the graduation ceremony, the group watching of a sporting event — these are secular rituals that perform the same structural functions as their religious predecessors: they mark time, create community, and produce the experience of being part of something larger than oneself.

✦

VI. Nature as Spiritual Ground

Every major contemplative tradition has, in some form, the practice of being in nature as a spiritual exercise. The desert fathers. The forest monks. The Romantic poets. The Shinto tradition of satoyama — the spiritually significant boundary between human habitation and wild nature. The Indigenous traditions of virtually every culture, in which the relationship to the land is not incidental to spiritual life but constitutive of it.

The convergence across traditions is not accidental. Nature provides, without cost or instruction, several of the conditions that spiritual life requires and that the indoor, digital life systematically removes.

It provides scale. The tree that was there before you were born and will be there after you die communicates, through the simple fact of its existence, something about the relative significance of the daily preoccupations that the mind, left to its own devices, tends to inflate to emergency proportions.

It provides process. The natural world is in continuous, visible change — seasonal, daily, minute by minute — in a way that communicates impermanence more directly than any text about impermanence can. The leaf that is green in July and gone by November is a teaching that the body receives and the mind, at some level below the verbal, recognises.

It provides attention without effort. As noted in Chapter Six, natural environments engage the involuntary attention — the diffuse, restful awareness that notices without effort — in ways that restore the directed attention consumed by the working day. This restorative quality is not merely comfort. It is the condition in which the deeper questions — the questions about meaning, direction, and what matters — tend to surface, because the surface-level preoccupations have been quieted enough to allow them.

The forest bathing practice — shinrin-yoku, developed in Japan in the 1980s as a formal health practice — is, at its core, the formalisation of something human beings have always known and that the urban, digitalised life has made it necessary to remind people of: that time in natural environments is not leisure, exactly. It is maintenance. The body and mind in nature are doing something that the body and mind in the office or on the sofa cannot do. They are recovering something that cannot be recovered any other way.[10]

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[10] The scientific literature on the health and psychological benefits of time in natural environments is now substantial. A 2019 study in Nature Scientific Reports found that spending a minimum of two hours per week in natural environments was associated with significantly better health and wellbeing outcomes across a large UK population sample — a finding that held across age, gender, social class, and health status. Two hours per week. The recommendation is modest. The compliance rate, in a country where the average person spends ninety percent of their time indoors, is not what it might be.

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VII. Gender and Spiritual Life

The relationship between gender and spiritual life is complex enough to be worth more than a footnote, and brief enough, in this chapter, to require some selectivity.

The broad finding from sociology and psychology of religion is that women, in most cultures and across most traditions, are more religiously and spiritually active than men: more likely to participate in formal religious practice, more likely to pray, more likely to report spiritual experiences, and more likely to seek meaning through spiritual frameworks. This is not universal — it varies by tradition, culture, and the specific measures used — but it is consistent enough to be a recognised pattern.[11]

The explanations are various. Some researchers point to differences in socialisation — women are encouraged to express emotional and spiritual needs more directly than men. Some point to structural factors — religious communities, historically, have provided women with community, authority, and recognition that other social institutions denied them. Some point to the relationship between spiritual practice and the orientation toward relationship and connection that, on average, characterises women's psychological lives more than men's.

Men's relationship to spirituality is, in the data, complicated by the same pattern that complicates their relationship to emotional life generally: the cultural constraint against the expression of need, vulnerability, and the admission that there are things that exceed one's individual capacity. The spiritual life requires all three — the acknowledgement of limitation, the orientation toward something beyond the self, the willingness to be, in some sense, a beginner. These are in structural tension with the dominant cultural construction of masculinity in the developed world.

And yet: the Stoic tradition, with its emphasis on rational discipline and practical wisdom, has found genuine and growing resonance among men who would not describe themselves as spiritual seekers — men who are drawn to Marcus Aurelius not for his metaphysics but for his practical frameworks for managing the difficulties of a responsible life. The Stoics were soldiers, emperors, slaves: people whose lives required an engagement with difficulty that was neither denied nor dramatised. They are, in this sense, an accessible entry point to a contemplative tradition for people who would not use the word contemplative about themselves.

For those who exist outside the binary of male and female — whose experience of gender is more complex, more fluid, or more resistant to the available categories — the spiritual life offers something that the gender frameworks of most traditions do not: a domain in which the question who am I? is asked most deeply, and in which the answer is not determined by the categories the surrounding culture provides. Every major contemplative tradition has, in its mystical dimension, the practice of moving beyond the ordinary constructions of self — including, prominently, the gendered self — into an experience of identity that is prior to those constructions. This is not a resolution of the political and social questions that face gender-diverse people in 2026. It is, perhaps, a resource.

✦

[11] The gender difference in religious participation is one of the most consistent findings in the sociology of religion. Marta Trzebiatowska and Steve Bruce's 2012 book Why are Women More Religious than Men? provides the most thorough recent examination of the data and the available explanations. Their conclusion — that the difference is real, substantial, and not reducible to any single cause — is probably the most honest available summary of a genuinely complex phenomenon.

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VIII. Practical Anchors for a Secular Age

For those for whom the formal traditions are not available — through lack of belief, through the specific exclusions of available traditions, through temperament, or through the simple practical difficulty of finding a community — the spiritual life requires construction rather than inheritance. This is harder. It is also possible.

The following are not prescriptions. They are anchors: practices that have, across traditions and across individuals, demonstrated the capacity to create the conditions in which meaning accumulates. They do not require belief in anything specific. They require showing up, regularly, with some degree of attention.

Daily practice. Something small, done every day, at approximately the same time, that is not instrumental. Not productive. Not aimed at an outcome. Five minutes of sitting quietly in the morning, before the phone. A few lines in a journal, not about tasks but about what you notice, what you feel, what you are grateful for and what you are afraid of. A walk taken slowly, with attention to what is actually there. The practice does not need to be large. It needs to be consistent, because consistency is where the change happens — in the gradual, almost imperceptible shift in how the day is oriented when it begins with something that is not a screen.

Seasonal awareness. The year has shape — not just the work year with its quarters and deadlines, but the actual year: the lengthening of light into summer, the turn toward darkness, the depth of winter, the return of warmth. Most people in 2026 experience this shape only incidentally, through the changing of clothes and the quality of light through a window. Attending to it more deliberately — marking the solstices and equinoxes, noticing what is growing and what is dying in the natural world around you, letting the season have some presence in the texture of daily life — is not paganism, particularly, though it is consistent with most pre-modern spiritual traditions. It is a way of being in time that is oriented toward something beyond the individual, which is one of the things meaning requires.

Community ritual. One gathering, per month, that is not for productivity or consumption but for the practice of being together with some acknowledgement of what being together is for. A book group that takes the books seriously. A regular meal to which people bring something of themselves. A monthly walk with others in a natural place. The content matters less than the regularity and the intention: these are people who are gathering, on purpose, to do something together that is oriented toward something beyond the immediate.

The technology sabbath. One period per week — a morning, an afternoon, an evening, a full day if the situation allows — in which the phone is off and the screen is dark and the available space of time and attention is returned to whatever presents itself without algorithmic assistance. Not to accomplish anything. To notice what emerges when the noise recedes. This is a practice recommended across several traditions under different names, and it is recommended consistently because it consistently reveals something: that the self that was present before the noise is still there, and is, often, somewhat more interesting than the self that spends its time attending to the noise.

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Navigation: The Tools for This Chapter

Psychologically: Meaning journaling — distinct from gratitude journaling, though gratitude is part of it — is the practice of regularly attending, in writing, to the questions that the pace of daily life tends to suppress. Not what am I grateful for but what mattered today, and why? Not what went well but what am I part of that is larger than myself, and am I participating in it adequately? These are not comfortable questions. They are generative ones. The mind that asks them regularly tends to orient differently than the mind that does not.

Philosophical inquiry — reading the people who have thought seriously about these questions, not as intellectual exercise but as practical counsel — is an undervalued resource. Marcus Aurelius. Epictetus. Montaigne. The Book of Job. The Tao Te Ching. Rumi. These are not decorative references. They are the distilled wisdom of people who faced the same fundamental questions — about suffering, about meaning, about how to live — in conditions that were, in several cases, considerably worse than ours, and who found answers that have lasted. The answers are available. Reading them, slowly, with attention, is itself a spiritual practice.

Physically: The nature walk as spiritual practice, rather than exercise with scenery: slow, without earphones, without the phone in your hand. Looking at what is actually there. The quality of the light. The specific tree in front of you. The sound of what the environment is doing. Thirty minutes of this, once a week, produces something different from thirty minutes of walking while listening to a podcast — not superior in every dimension, but recovering something the podcast walk does not.

Yoga, qigong, tai chi, walking meditation — the body-mind practices that are present in most contemplative traditions — have in common the quality of directed attention to physical sensation and movement, which is itself a form of presence practice. The body, attended to, becomes the entry point to the present moment in a way that the mind, left to itself, frequently is not.

Spiritually: Sit. Not in the performance of meditation, not with the app running, not with the streak tracker counting. Sit somewhere quiet, for as long as is available, with no agenda. If thoughts come — and they will, in quantity — let them come and go without following them. If silence arrives — and it will, eventually — let it be what it is. The Quakers call this waiting on the Light. The Zen tradition calls it just sitting. The Sufi tradition calls it fana, the annihilation of the separate self. The secular research literature calls it default mode network activation and associates it with creativity, self-reflection, and the consolidation of identity.

They are, in the relevant respects, describing the same thing. The thing is available. It requires nothing but the willingness to stop, which turns out, in 2026, to be the most countercultural act available to an ordinary person on an ordinary day.

Stop. Sit. Wait. See what is there.

It has been there all along.

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Next: Chapter Nine — Endings and Beginnings: Death, Grief, and the Wider View

In which we turn to face the one thing that the digital age has not solved, cannot sell a solution to, and has therefore largely declined to discuss — and discover that facing it, rather than scrolling past it, is among the more useful things a person can do with a Wednesday afternoon.

✦

Chapter Nine: Endings and Beginnings — Death, Grief, and the Wider View

✦

There is an app, available on most smartphones, that will calculate your life expectancy. You enter your age, your weight, your smoking status, your exercise habits, whether you drink and how much, whether you floss, and the app produces a number: the age to which, on current trajectory, you are statistically likely to live.

It will not tell you what the number means. It will not tell you whether the years between now and then will be good ones, or how many of them will be spent in the condition you are currently in versus some diminished version of it, or what the people you love will be doing when you are no longer there to notice. It will not address the quality of the number — only its size. It will then, having delivered its verdict, offer you an upgrade to premium features.[1]

This is, in miniature, the relationship that 2026 has with death: close enough to quantify, far enough from understanding to make the quantification feel like engagement. We know, with unprecedented precision, the statistics of mortality. We know the leading causes of death. We know the risk factors. We know the life expectancies by country, by income, by postcode. We have made death, in this sense, enormously legible.

We have also, in the same movement, made it more hidden than it has been at any point in recorded history — moved it from the home to the hospital, from the community to the institution, from the visible, present, unavoidable fact of ordinary life to a managed, professional, private event that most people in the developed world will not witness at close range until they are middle-aged, or older, or not at all.

This chapter is about what that hiddenness costs, and about how to face the thing that the digital age has, with all its ingenuity, found no way to avoid.

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[1] The premium features on most life expectancy apps include personalised health recommendations, trend tracking over time, and comparison with other users in your demographic. Whether knowing that you are currently on track to live three years longer than the average for your postcode constitutes meaningful engagement with your mortality is a question the apps decline to address.

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I. Through the Three Lenses: Death in Time

1920

We have already described, in Chapter One, the presence of death in the life of 1920. Here we want to dwell on what that presence did — what the consistent, close, unavoidable proximity to mortality produced in the people who lived within it.

It produced, among other things, a cultural vocabulary for death that we have largely lost. Not a comfortable vocabulary — the Victorian and Edwardian periods produced some extraordinarily eccentric thanatological customs, including mourning jewellery made from the hair of the deceased, post-mortem photography in which the dead were posed as if living, and a formal social calendar of grief that prescribed, with considerable precision, how long you were expected to wear black and in what company you were permitted to be seen.[2] These customs are not being recommended for revival. They are being noted as evidence that the culture had developed, through long experience with the thing, a set of practices for containing and expressing what death produces in the living.

The infant mortality rate we noted in Chapter One — eighty deaths per thousand live births — meant that most families in 1920 had lost children. This is not a small thing. The grief it produced was real and was not, in most cases, well accommodated by the emotional frameworks of the period. But the experience of that grief — of being in the presence of death, of conducting the rituals of farewell, of having the community gather and witness and hold the loss — meant that death was not foreign to the body's experience. The body knew what death was. The mind had been in contact with it. The grief had form.

1995–2006

By the nineties, death had completed its retreat from the domestic sphere. The hospice movement — which had begun in the 1960s under Dame Cicely Saunders — was established as the primary alternative to hospital death, providing palliative care of genuine quality in dedicated environments staffed by specialists. This was progress. People were dying with better pain management, more individual attention, and more dignity than the general hospital ward typically provided.

But the hospice, like the hospital, was not the home. The dying were elsewhere. The children of this period grew up without the experience, common to all previous generations, of being present in a house where someone was dying. The rituals of death — the laying out of the body, the sitting with the dead, the community gathering that preceded the formal funeral — had largely moved out of the home and into professional hands.

The grief vocabulary was also changing. The language of closure — borrowed from psychotherapy and suggesting that grief was a process with a defined endpoint — had entered popular usage, bringing with it the implication that the grieving person was expected, with appropriate support, to arrive at a conclusion. The research on grief, which suggests that bereaved people do not typically reach closure but rather learn to carry their loss differently over time, had not yet widely displaced the closure model in popular understanding.[3]

2026

Death in 2026 is simultaneously more present and more distant than it has been at any point in the three lenses.

More present: the news feed delivers footage of mass casualty events, war, famine, and natural disaster at a rate and with an immediacy that no previous generation experienced. The death toll of a distant earthquake is delivered, with photographs, within hours. The last moments of people who die publicly — through violence, through accident, through the various catastrophes that the always-on news environment has made perpetually available — are sometimes filmed and shared before anyone has thought to ask whether they should be. The body count is live-updating and searchable.

More distant: the death of someone known to you — a relative, a friend, a colleague — remains, for most people in the developed world, as managed and as invisible as it was in the nineties. The dying person is in the hospital or the hospice. The body is handled by the funeral director. The children do not see it. The rituals, where they exist, are brief and formal and attended by people who are, with the best intentions, uncertain what to do with their faces.

The asymmetry between these two modes of encountering death — the abundant, distant, mediated, and the rare, close, actual — has produced a particular kind of grief illiteracy. We are saturated with death-at-a-distance and starved of the cultural tools to manage death up close. We watch strangers die on our phones and we do not know what to say to our neighbour whose mother has just died.[4]

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[2] The history of Victorian and Edwardian mourning customs is documented in detail in Lou Taylor's Mourning Dress: A Costume and Social History (1983). The customs were, as noted, elaborate to the point of peculiarity. They were also, in their elaboration, serious: they provided a social framework for the expression of grief that the current culture, with its relative absence of mourning customs, does not.

[3] The "closure" model of grief derives loosely from Elisabeth Kübler-Ross's stage model, first described in On Death and Dying (1969), which was developed from interviews with terminally ill patients and was not, as Kübler-Ross herself repeatedly stated, intended as a prescriptive model for how bereaved people should grieve. Its popularisation as a predictive sequence — denial, anger, bargaining, depression, acceptance — with the implication that acceptance is the destination and that arrival there constitutes completion, has been widely criticised by grief researchers, including Colin Murray Parkes and the contemporary researcher George Bonanno, whose longitudinal research on bereavement suggests that the most common response to loss is not the staged process but a more variable, non-linear trajectory.

[4] The phrase "grief illiteracy" appears in the work of David Kessler, a grief researcher and author who studied with Kübler-Ross, and has been extended by other grief practitioners to describe the general cultural difficulty with being present to others' loss. The difficulty is real and consistent: studies of bereaved people's experiences consistently find that the behaviour they find most distressing from others is not the absence of words but the absence of presence — the friends who disappear, the colleagues who avoid eye contact, the well-meaning people who say something unhelpful because saying something unhelpful is easier than sitting with the silence.

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II. What Grief Actually Is

Grief is not, primarily, sadness. Sadness is one of its components. Grief is the response of the whole person — psychological, physical, spiritual — to the loss of something or someone to whom they were attached. It is the price of love, which is both an observation about cost and an observation about value: the grief is proportionate to the attachment, which means that the depth of grief is evidence of the depth of connection.

The physiology of grief is real and significant. The bereaved body produces elevated cortisol, disrupted sleep architecture, impaired immune function, and, in the early period of loss, neurological changes in the regions associated with reward and social bonding that are measurable on brain imaging. The phrase broken heart is not purely metaphorical: the bereavement period is associated with elevated risk of cardiac

events, a phenomenon documented extensively enough to have a name — Takotsubo cardiomyopathy, or broken heart syndrome — in which acute emotional stress produces a transient weakening of the heart muscle that mimics a heart attack.[5]

The psychological experience of grief is not uniform. Bonanno's longitudinal research has identified several trajectories: the resilient (who experience relatively brief, moderate grief and return to baseline functioning without significant disruption), the recovering (who experience more significant disruption that gradually resolves), the chronically grieving (for whom the loss remains acutely painful for an extended period), and the delayed responders (who function well initially but experience grief later, often triggered by subsequent events). None of these trajectories is wrong. They are different responses by different people with different attachments in different circumstances.

What this means, practically, is that there is no correct way to grieve. The person who is functioning within weeks of a significant loss is not grieving incorrectly. The person who is still profoundly affected two years later is not grieving incorrectly. The person who cries constantly is not doing it wrong. The person who does not cry at all is not doing it wrong. The grief is the grief, and it takes the form it takes, and the primary task of the people around the bereaved person is to remain present to whatever form it takes without interpreting it as either insufficient or excessive.

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[5] Takotsubo cardiomyopathy was first described by Japanese physicians in 1990 and is triggered by acute physical or emotional stress. It produces a characteristic ballooning of the left ventricle visible on echocardiography. Most patients recover fully within weeks. The syndrome is more common in post-menopausal women, though it occurs in both sexes. Its existence is among the more concrete pieces of evidence that the boundary between emotional and physical suffering is less clear than the medical and the psychological traditions have historically assumed.

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III. Digital Grief

The death of a person now produces a digital aftermath that has no precedent in human history.

The deceased's social media profiles remain. Their messages are in your phone. Their photographs are in your camera roll, surfaced periodically by algorithmic memory features that have not been informed of the death and continue to generate on this day reminders with a cheerfulness that, in the circumstances, lands differently than intended. The deceased continues to appear in suggested contacts, in tagged photographs, in the search history that remembers what they were looking at before they stopped.[6]

Mourners create digital memorials — Facebook pages become gathering places for condolence, Instagram posts mark the loss publicly, WhatsApp groups are formed among people who are grieving together and want to do so in each other's company without being in each other's physical company. These practices are not nothing. They create a community of shared acknowledgement that has genuine value, particularly for people who are geographically dispersed and cannot gather physically.

But they also produce a particular quality of grief that is worth examining. The public expression of grief on social media — the tribute post, the anniversary remembrance, the shared photograph — is subject to the same dynamics as all social media expression: it is visible to others, it generates responses, and the

responses create a feedback loop that may or may not correspond to the actual interior experience of the grieving person. The grief that is performed publicly is not necessarily less authentic than the grief that is experienced privately. But the performance layer, once established, can make it harder to access the private experience, because the public performance has provided an outlet that the private experience then competes with.

There is also the question of the digital remains. The deceased's online presence — their posts, their profiles, their digital history — exists indefinitely unless actively managed, and most families do not manage it. The social media profile that remains active after death is a novel and unresolved cultural situation: it provides comfort to some bereaved people, who can visit it as a form of memorial, and distress to others, for whom its continued existence prevents the psychological process of accepting the reality of the loss. There is no established norm. There is no social contract governing how long the profile should remain, who has the authority to modify or remove it, or what obligations the platforms have to the bereaved.[7]

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[6] Several social media platforms have introduced "memorialisation" features that allow a deceased user's account to be marked as such, removing it from birthday reminders and suggested contacts while preserving it as a memorial. The features exist. They require someone to notify the platform of the death, which requires knowledge of the feature, which requires someone in the bereaved family to be thinking about social media at a time when they are usually thinking about other things. The process is imperfect. It is better than nothing, and it is improving.

[7] The legal status of digital remains is an emerging area of law. In the UK, digital assets are technically part of the estate but their practical management is complicated by the terms of service of most platforms, which do not transfer account access to next of kin. The Digital Legacy Association campaigns for clearer legal frameworks and greater platform responsibility in this area. As of 2026, the legal landscape is still developing.

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IV. The Art of Being With the Dying

There is a skill — practical, learnable, requiring no special training — that most people in 2026 do not have and are not taught, because the conditions that produce it through ordinary experience have been removed: the skill of being with someone who is dying.

Not managing their care, which is the work of professionals. Not organising the practical arrangements, which is necessary and important. Being with them. Sitting in the room. Saying what is true. Not pretending that it is not happening.

The dying, on the testimony of hospice workers and palliative care physicians, want primarily to be not alone. They want to be talked to normally, about ordinary things and about important things. They want the people they love to say what they feel rather than maintaining the protective fiction that everything is fine and that this is not, in fact, the ending. They want their death to be acknowledged by the people who love them, because the acknowledgement makes it real in the way that pretence does not, and reality, even this reality, is preferable to the loneliness of a silence that everyone is colluding to maintain.[8]

The fear that prevents this is largely the fear of doing it wrong — of saying the wrong thing, of being overwhelmed, of not knowing what to do with the feelings that arise. These fears are reasonable. They are also, in the presence of someone who is dying, considerably less important than the fears of the person who is dying, whose situation is rather more pressing. The visitor who is imperfect but present is serving the dying person. The visitor who avoids because they might do it wrong is, in the most gentle possible reading, serving themselves.

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[8] The research on this is found primarily in the palliative care literature, associated with researchers including Ira Byock, whose book Dying Well (1997) and subsequent work document extensively what dying people report wanting from the people around them. The consistent finding — that presence, acknowledgement, and honest communication matter more than any specific thing said or done — is both simple and, given the cultural difficulty of death-talk in the contemporary West, not easy to act on.

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V. Mid-Life, Mortality, and the Existential Shift

Death is not only what happens at the end. It is also what the middle of life eventually forces you to confront.

Mid-life — which arrives, for different people, at different times, and which is not always accompanied by the sports car and the romantic entanglement that cultural mythology associates with it — is, at its psychological core, an encounter with finitude. The younger life is structured, in the main, around possibility: the sense that there is time, that options are open, that the significant choices are still ahead. Mid-life is the moment when the mathematics of time changes: when it becomes clear that there is less ahead than behind, that some of the possible lives are no longer possible, that the choices already made are, in a meaningful sense, who you are.

This is not, as it is sometimes framed, a crisis. It is a reckoning. And the reckoning, faced honestly, tends to produce not despair but clarification: a growing clarity about what actually matters, about where time is most usefully invested, about the things that have been tolerated without examination and the things that have been neglected without acknowledgement.

The digital age has given mid-life its own particular texture. The algorithmically surfaced memory — five years ago today — confronts the fifty-year-old with a visual record of their former self that previous generations did not have. The social media comparison class, which in mid-life tends to include people of roughly similar age who appear to be doing significantly better or significantly worse by various metrics, creates a landscape of comparison that can either motivate or demoralise, depending on the comparison chosen and the framework in which it is held.[9]

The existential anxiety of mid-life — the awareness that the life is real and finite and that its quality is substantially within one's influence — is, in one sense, the most useful anxiety available. It is the anxiety that asks the important questions. The person who has never felt it has either been very fortunate or has been very successfully distracted, and the digital environment has provided, for the first time in history, distraction of sufficient quality and quantity to potentially defer the question until rather later than is useful.

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[9] The psychologist Daniel Levinson, in his foundational work on adult development The Seasons of a Man's Life (1978), documented the mid-life transition as a universal feature of adult psychological development — not a crisis in the dramatic sense but a necessary psychological reorientation. His framework has been extended and revised; the most useful contemporary treatment is probably Roger Gould's work on transformations in adult life, or the empirical work of Daniel McAdams on narrative identity, which frames mid-life as the period in which people revise the story they tell about themselves to incorporate the evidence of lived experience.

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VI. Learning to Die: The Contemplative Traditions

The contemplative traditions have, without exception, developed specific practices for the contemplation of death. Not because their founders were morbid — though some of them were, in ways that their followers have found prudent to downplay — but because they understood, through direct observation, that the avoidance of mortality produces a specific and curable kind of suffering, and that its contemplation produces a specific and valuable kind of clarity.

The Stoic memento mori — remember that you will die — was not a counsel of despair. It was a tool for perspective. The emperor who remembered, in the morning, that today could be his last day was the emperor who was less likely to waste the day on trivial concerns, less likely to be unmanned by the ordinary inconveniences of Roman imperial life, less likely to mistake the temporary for the permanent. The daily contemplation of death was, for the Stoics, a precondition of the well-lived day.[10]

The Buddhist tradition's maranasati — mindfulness of death — serves a similar function and is practised in some traditions through direct exposure: visiting charnel grounds, contemplating images of the dying body, sitting with the physical reality of mortality until the defences that ordinarily prevent its acknowledgement have been, if not eliminated, at least temporarily lowered. This is, by most Western standards, extreme. The principle it embodies — that the honest acknowledgement of death reduces rather than increases existential anxiety — is, however, well supported by the psychological research on terror management and mortality salience.[11]

The Sufi poet Rumi, whose lines on death are among the most beautiful in any language, understood mortality not as an ending but as a transformation — the dissolution of the individual self into the larger whole from which it was, temporarily and incompletely, separated. His line "Die before you die, and discover that there is no death" is not, in context, a counsel of nihilism but an invitation to the mystical experience in which the ordinary boundaries of the self — including the boundary that makes death seem like an absolute ending — become permeable. Whether or not this is literally true is a question this book will not adjudicate. As a description of a possible human experience, and as a pointer toward a relationship with mortality that is less governed by avoidance, it is useful.

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[10] The memento mori practice among the Stoics is described by Seneca in his Letters (particularly Letter 77) and by Marcus Aurelius throughout the Meditations. The most practically accessible account of how to incorporate it into contemporary life is Ryan Holiday's The Daily Stoic (2016), which, whatever its limitations as a philosophical text, has introduced Stoic practice to an audience that might not otherwise have encountered it.

[11] Terror Management Theory, developed by Jeff Greenberg, Sheldon Solomon, and Tom Pyszczynski from the work of Ernest Becker, proposes that much human behaviour is motivated by the management of anxiety about death — that culture, worldview, and self-esteem function, in part, as buffers against the terror of mortality. Their research has generated hundreds of studies on how mortality salience affects human behaviour. The somewhat paradoxical finding — that conscious, explicit engagement with mortality tends to reduce defensive behaviour more than the suppression of death-awareness — is consistent with what the contemplative traditions have been saying for millennia.

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VII. Gender, Grief, and Mortality

Men and women tend to grieve differently, and the differences are consistent enough across cultures and studies to be worth naming.

Women, on average, are more likely to express grief openly, to seek social support during bereavement, to talk about the person who has died, and to participate in communal rituals of mourning. They are more likely to enter therapy during bereavement and to make use of the social networks available to them. The grief tends, in its expression, toward the external and the relational.

Men, on average, are more likely to grieve privately — to process loss internally, through activity rather than conversation, through the doing of things rather than the talking about things. They are less likely to seek formal support, less likely to disclose the extent of their grief to others, and significantly more likely to experience what researchers call "complicated grief" — grief that becomes stuck, that does not follow the trajectory toward re-engagement with life, that produces prolonged functional impairment — partly because the social support that might facilitate the trajectory is not sought or offered.[12]

The male bereaved are, in the research, consistently overlooked: by the health system, by grief support services, and by the informal social network that tends to organise its support around the women in the bereaved family and to assume that the men are managing, because the men are saying they are managing. The men are frequently not managing. They are performing management, because the cultural framework available to them does not readily accommodate the admission that they are not.

The most useful thing the people around a bereaved man can do is not to accept the performance of management as a final answer. To remain present. To keep showing up. To be still there when the performance eventually falters, because it usually does, and when it does the person needs to find someone already present rather than having to seek them out from scratch.

For women, the grief that is expressed and witnessed and held by community is the grief that is most likely to resolve without becoming stuck. The risk, for some bereaved women, is the opposite of the risk for men: not the suppression of grief but its perpetuation through continuous rehearsal, through the grief that feeds itself in the telling. Both forms of difficulty are real. Both deserve compassionate, unhurried attention.

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[12] The research on gender and grief is reviewed in the work of Wolfgang Stroebe and colleagues, including their development of the Dual Process Model of grief, which distinguishes between loss-oriented coping (attending to the grief itself) and restoration-oriented coping (attending to the practical and life-change demands that loss produces). Their finding that most bereaved people oscillate between these two modes of coping, and that healthy adjustment involves both, is consistent with the gender difference noted: men tend toward restoration-oriented coping and may underdo loss-orientation; women tend toward loss-orientation and may sometimes underdo restoration-orientation.

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VIII. The Wider View

There is a perspective available on one's own life and death that requires some altitude to access — the view from far enough back that the individual life can be seen in the context of what it is actually part of.

What is it part of? This is the question that the contemplative traditions have been asking, and the answer varies, and the variation is itself informative. Some traditions place the individual life in the context of a divine order — a cosmos that is intentional, purposive, and in which the individual death has meaning beyond its immediate disappearance. Others place it in the context of the natural world — the cycle of matter and energy, the ecological web in which what dies becomes the material of what lives next, in which the individual is a temporary expression of processes that are neither created nor destroyed by its passing. Others place it in the context of human history — the great river of the species, in which each individual life is a reach of water that flows from what came before and into what comes after.

None of these perspectives are available to the person who is scrolling.

They are available to the person who stops, who looks up, who is willing to hold the discomfort of the question long enough for it to become something other than discomfort — which it does, eventually, for most people who are willing to stay with it. The question of what one's life is part of is not resolved by answering it. It is resolved by inhabiting it: by living in the question, by letting it inform daily choices and daily priorities, by allowing the awareness of finitude to make the present, which is the only available moment, more rather than less vivid.

This is, ultimately, what the contemplation of death offers. Not comfort, exactly. Not certainty. But the clarity that comes from looking at the thing without flinching, and discovering that it is, on examination, not quite as terrible as the avoidance of it.

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Navigation: The Tools for This Chapter

Psychologically: Narrative therapy approaches grief by attending to the story the bereaved person is telling about their loss and about their life in relation to it. Not to change the story, necessarily, but to discover its full dimensions — to find the chapters that are about more than the loss, the threads of the narrative that continue beyond it, the aspects of the person's identity that existed before the loss and persist through it.

The exercise is simple: write the story of your relationship with the person who has died. Not a summary. The whole story, with specificity. The difficult parts and the good parts. What they gave you. What you gave them. What remains.

This is not comfortable. It is generative. The grief that has a narrative can be carried more easily than the grief that remains formless.

The Stoic practice of memento mori, adapted for daily use: in the morning, before the phone, take one minute to hold the awareness that this day is finite and yours and not to be wasted on things that do not matter to you. Not as a meditation on death but as a clarification of life. The question it is asking is: given that this day is real and limited, how do I want to spend it?

Physically: Grief lives in the body. The tension of suppressed tears. The heaviness in the chest that the bereaved describe, which is not metaphorical — the body responds to loss with physical symptoms that are real and measurable and that require physical as well as psychological response. Movement in grief is not avoidance. Walking in a natural environment, as ceremony rather than exercise — slowly, with attention, with the explicit intention of carrying the grief into a space larger than the room where it has been sitting — is a practice with a long history in many traditions. It does not resolve the grief. It moves it, in the sense of allowing it to be in motion rather than stuck, which is, with grief, a meaningful distinction.

Plant something. This is not a whimsical suggestion. The act of putting a seed or a bulb or a sapling in the ground — something that will grow without you, that will be there when you are not — is a form of physical ritual that connects the personal loss to the larger cycle of which it is a part. It is also an act of commitment to the future, which grief, in its acute phase, tends to make difficult to imagine. The act of planting is the body saying: there will be a future. It will have things in it. Some of them will be growing.

Spiritually: Sit with the fact of death. Not with the theory. With the fact. Find whatever form of this practice is available to you — the memento mori, the Buddhist contemplation, the simple practice of holding the awareness of finitude without immediately reaching for distraction — and do it regularly enough for it to become part of how you inhabit time.

The paradox of this practice — acknowledged by every tradition that recommends it — is that the regular, honest contemplation of death tends to produce not morbidity but vitality. The life that is held against the background of its own ending is the life that is more awake to its own value. The day that is understood to be one of a finite number is the day that is, in some way, more fully used.

Death is not the opposite of life. It is its context. And the context, attended to, tends to make the thing it contexts more, not less, worth living.

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Next: Chapter Ten — Society and Civics: From Personal to Political

In which we discover that we have more information about the state of the world than any previous generation, more ways to express our opinions about it, and a somewhat surprising difficulty agreeing on what any of it means — or, indeed, what is actually for lunch.

✦

Chapter Ten: Society and Civics — From Personal to Political

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We have more information about the state of the world than any generation in history. We have more ways to express our opinions about it. We have more platforms, more voices, more data, more analysis, more commentary on the analysis, more commentary on the commentary, and at least four different podcasts explaining why all of the other sources are wrong.

We have, in the United Kingdom alone, approximately four hundred active news sources at the time of writing. The number will be different by the time of reading, but it will not be smaller.

And yet.

A 2024 Reuters Institute survey found that forty-three percent of people in the UK actively avoid the news — not because they lack access, not because they lack interest in the world, but because they find it emotionally draining, confusing, and unlikely to lead to anything they can usefully do.[1] In the United States, the figure is higher. In several European countries, it is higher still.

We are, as a species, drowning in information about the world and retreating from engagement with it. This is not apathy. It is a reasonable response to an unreasonable situation. The question this chapter addresses is what that situation is, how it arrived, and what a person of ordinary goodwill and limited time can actually do about it that is more useful than either drowning or retreating.

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[1] The Reuters Institute Digital News Report is published annually by the Reuters Institute for the Study of Journalism at Oxford University and represents one of the most comprehensive surveys of news consumption habits available. The news avoidance figures have risen consistently since they began tracking the phenomenon in 2017, suggesting that the trend is not temporary adjustment but structural change in the relationship between citizens and news media.

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I. Through the Three Lenses: Civic Life in Time

1920

Civic life in 1920 was local in ways that are now difficult to imagine.

The mechanisms of democratic participation — the ward meeting, the parish council, the union branch, the working men's club, the mutual aid society — were small-scale, face-to-face, and embedded in the community they served. The MP was likely to be known, at least by reputation, to a significant portion of their constituents. The local councillor was probably your neighbour. The decisions that affected your daily life — the maintenance of the roads, the provision of the school, the regulation of working conditions in the local factory — were made by people who were physically proximate and socially accountable in ways that a distant parliament was not.

Political information arrived through the newspaper, through word of mouth, and through the public meeting — a form of civic engagement that has largely disappeared from the contemporary landscape but that was, in 1920, a genuine institution. The public meeting required the politician to appear in person, to speak without notes in many cases, to field questions from the floor, and to be present to the response — the heckling, the applause, the silence that told you something had landed wrong. This created a feedback loop, imperfect and frequently manipulated, but real in the sense that the politician's body was in the same room as the consequences of their positions.

The political culture of 1920 was not, it should be noted, a model of rational deliberation. It was partisan, frequently corrupt, viscerally tribal, and animated by a class politics whose bitterness can still be felt in the social architecture of contemporary Britain. But it was grounded in material reality — in the lived conditions of specific communities, in the concrete interests of specific groups — in a way that the abstracted, mediatised politics of 2026 frequently is not.[2]

1995–2006

By the mid-nineties, political life had moved decisively to the screen — to the television broadcast, the managed media appearance, the focus-group-tested message. The town hall meeting had not disappeared, but it had become, in many cases, a managed event: the questions pre-selected, the audience carefully composed, the politician prepared with responses that demonstrated engagement without risking authentic exchange.

The twenty-four-hour news cycle — introduced by CNN in 1980 and replicated by competitors through the nineties — had changed the tempo of political communication in ways whose consequences were not yet fully visible. The requirement to fill twenty-four hours of broadcast time with political content produced a journalism that prioritised novelty over depth, conflict over consensus, and the dramatic development over the slow-moving story that was, in most cases, actually more important.

The internet was arriving into this environment, beginning its long work of disaggregating the media landscape — first the news aggregators, then the blogs, then the social networks that would, within a decade, restructure the entire ecosystem of political information. In the late nineties, the internet was primarily supplementing the existing media structure. It had not yet replaced it.

What was already visible, to those paying attention, was the beginning of what would become the defining political fact of the next thirty years: the collapse of the shared informational commons. The moment when the range of people watching the same news programme, reading the same newspaper, inhabiting the same basic framework of political reality, began to shrink — and the question of what, if anything, would replace the shared framework became, gradually, urgent.[3]

2026

The shared informational commons has not been replaced. It has been succeeded by several thousand competing informational ecosystems, each with its own sources, its own interpretive frameworks, its own understanding of which events matter and what they mean, and its own conviction that the other ecosystems are not merely wrong but actively malicious.

This is the situation. It is worth looking at directly.

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[2] The political historian Jon Lawrence's Me, Me, Me? The Search for Community in Post-War England (2019) provides a careful account of the decline of the face-to-face political culture that characterised working-class community life in the early twentieth century. His argument — that the decline of this culture has produced not the individualist liberation that its critics feared but a more atomised and less politically effective citizenry — is one that the subsequent decade has done little to contradict.

[3] The media scholar Yochai Benkler's The Wealth of Networks (2006) was among the first serious analyses of how the internet was changing the structure of public discourse — both the optimistic case (more voices, more diversity, more democratic participation) and the early signs of the problems (fragmentation, the decline of shared facts, the vulnerability to manipulation). Reading it in 2026 is an unusual experience: the optimistic case has been partially realised and the problems have been significantly exceeded.

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II. The Outrage Economy

The algorithm, as we have established, does not care about truth. It cares about engagement. And the most engaging political content is not the most accurate, or the most nuanced, or the most likely to produce productive civic action. It is the most emotionally arousing — and in the domain of politics, emotional arousal is most reliably produced by content that triggers disgust, fear, and tribal identity threat.[4]

The result is a political media environment that is, in its basic incentive structure, opposed to the things that civic life requires: shared facts, the capacity for charitable interpretation of opposing positions, the tolerance for complexity, and the willingness to update one's views in response to evidence. Each of these capacities is undermined by an environment that rewards their opposites: emotional certainty, tribal identity performance, the confident assertion of simple truths about complex situations, and the algorithmic amplification of whatever produces the strongest response.

This is not a problem of the left or the right. It is a structural problem that operates across the political spectrum, producing — in different ideological flavours but through the same mechanisms — the same pathologies: the in-group that becomes more extreme as it feeds on its own certainty, the out-group that becomes more monstrous with each retelling, the shared factual basis for political discussion that erodes until the two sides are not merely disagreeing about values but inhabiting different versions of what is happening.

The filter bubble — the algorithmically produced information environment in which you primarily encounter content that confirms your existing views — has been somewhat overstated as a phenomenon; the research suggests that most people's online diets are more politically varied than the filter bubble hypothesis implies.[5] The more significant phenomenon is the outrage loop: the tendency of the algorithm to surface, within whatever political content you engage with, the most extreme and most emotionally provocative examples, because those examples generate more engagement than the moderate ones. The moderate conservative and the moderate progressive do not drive traffic. The outrage merchants on both sides do. The algorithm rewards them accordingly.

What this produces at the level of individual experience is a persistent sense that the other side is composed primarily of its most extreme members — because the algorithm has provided you, relentlessly, with those members as the representatives of the other side. The moderate, reasonable person who disagrees with you is invisible in this environment, because their moderation generates less engagement

than the extremist's outrage. You are, in a meaningful sense, not seeing the people you are in political disagreement with. You are seeing a curated selection of their most alarming representatives, and forming your political understanding accordingly.

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[4] The relationship between emotional content and political sharing was documented in a landmark 2017 study by William Brady and colleagues at New York University, which analysed millions of tweets and found that the inclusion of "moral-emotional" language — words expressing outrage, disgust, or identity threat — increased retweet rates by approximately twenty percent per additional moral-emotional word. The finding has been replicated across platforms and political contexts. The algorithm did not cause this — it amplified an existing human tendency — but its amplification has produced consequences at a scale that the underlying tendency could not have reached without it.

[5] The filter bubble hypothesis is associated with Eli Pariser's The Filter Bubble (2011), which argued that algorithmic personalisation was creating informationally isolated communities. Subsequent empirical research, including work by Levi Boxell, Matthew Gentzkow, and Jesse Shapiro, found that political polarisation had increased most among older Americans who are the least likely internet users — suggesting that the filter bubble is not the primary driver of polarisation, though it is a real phenomenon. The outrage loop is a more accurate description of the primary mechanism.

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III. Polarisation and the Loss of Dialogue

Political polarisation — the increasing distance between the positions, values, and mutual perceptions of people on different sides of political divides — is not new. It has been present in every democratic society that has been around long enough to measure it. What is new, in 2026, is its rate of increase and its depth.

The depth is important. Older forms of political polarisation were primarily about policy positions — people disagreed about the right level of taxation, the appropriate role of the state in the economy, the correct approach to foreign policy. These are genuine disagreements, and they are hard to resolve, but they are, in principle, disagreements about means rather than ends: both sides want a prosperous, stable, fair society and disagree about how to achieve it.

Contemporary polarisation, in many developed democracies, has moved beyond this into what researchers call affective polarisation: not merely disagreement about policy but mutual contempt, the perception of the other side not as people with different views but as bad people with wrong values who represent a genuine threat.[6] The percentage of Americans, in 1960, who would be uncomfortable if their child married someone from the other political party was approximately five percent. In 2020, it was approximately forty percent. The figure for Britain, while lower, has moved in the same direction.

This shift matters because affective polarisation is considerably more resistant to resolution than policy disagreement. You can update a policy position in response to evidence. You cannot easily update a perception of the other side as morally contemptible, because the perception is not primarily about evidence — it is about identity, about the social cost of being seen to think well of the enemy, and about the psychological security of belonging to a group that knows who it is by knowing who it is against.

The digital environment has not caused this. Political scientists point to economic inequality, institutional distrust, and the decline of cross-cutting social institutions — the union, the church, the civic association — as the primary drivers. But the digital environment has accelerated it, by providing the infrastructure for the mutual contempt to be expressed, amplified, and rewarded at a scale and speed that face-to-face political culture cannot replicate.[7]

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[6] Affective polarisation is the subject of a substantial and growing political science literature. The term and the foundational research are associated with Shanto Iyengar and Sean Westwood at Stanford, and their colleagues. The cross-national data, gathered by the More in Common organisation among others, consistently finds that affective polarisation is increasing across most developed democracies, and that it is consistently worse in online environments than offline ones — that people who interact across political lines in person are significantly less hostile to each other than people whose political interaction is primarily digital.

[7] The political scientist Robert Putnam's Bowling Alone (2000) documented the decline of civic association in America over the second half of the twentieth century — the fall in union membership, church attendance, club participation, and the various forms of face-to-face civic life that produce what Putnam calls "social capital": the network of relationships that make communities function. His argument — that the decline of these institutions has weakened the social fabric in ways that are only partially remedied by digital connection — has been consistently borne out by subsequent events.

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IV. Hashtag Movements, Slacktivism, and the Real Thing

Social media has, in the last fifteen years, demonstrated a genuine and remarkable capacity to mobilise political action. The Arab Spring, #MeToo, Black Lives Matter, the various environmental movements that have achieved policy effects through public pressure — these are real examples of digital tools enabling collective action at a scale and speed that would not have been possible through the slower mechanisms of previous generations.

This capacity is real and should not be minimised. The person who would have remained isolated in their political concern in 1980 — whose experience of injustice or whose commitment to change had no outlet beyond the local — can now find community, amplify their voice, and participate in collective action without needing to be in the same place as anyone else. This is a genuine democratic expansion.

The complication is the gap between participation and impact. The hashtag that goes viral is not necessarily the hashtag that produces policy change. The petition signed by a million people online is not equivalent to the legislative pressure produced by a million people who vote, who canvass, who attend constituency surgeries, who stand outside the housing office in the rain. The expression of political commitment online is real. Its relationship to political outcomes is, in most cases, indirect, mediated, and considerably more uncertain than the emotional intensity of the online moment suggests.[8]

Slacktivism — the term for low-effort online political expression that provides the feeling of civic participation without the costs and constraints of actual civic engagement — is real enough to have its own research literature. The finding that online petition-signing and hashtag participation can actually reduce

offline political action — by providing an outlet for political concern that satisfies the psychological need for contribution without producing it — has been replicated across several contexts.[9] This does not mean online action is without value. It means that the feeling of having done something politically useful online is not a reliable guide to whether something politically useful has actually been done.

The most effective civic action remains, as it has always been, expensive in the ways that matter: time, consistency, the tolerance for slow, unglamorous, often frustrating engagement with institutions and processes that are not designed to be responsive and frequently aren't. The person who attends the local council meeting for the third consecutive month, who canvasses in the rain, who volunteers for the organisation that is doing the thing they believe in, who maintains their engagement through the periods when nothing appears to be changing — that person is doing something that a thousand retweets cannot replicate.

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[8] The political effectiveness of online activism is examined carefully in Zeynep Tufekci's Twitter and Tear Gas: The Power and Fragility of Networked Protest (2017), which argues that the ability to rapidly scale online movements is both their strength and their weakness — that movements assembled quickly online lack the organisational infrastructure and institutional knowledge that slower-built movements develop through the process of building, and that this makes them more fragile at precisely the moment when durability is most needed.

[9] The "moral licensing" effect in online activism — the phenomenon by which performing a token positive action reduces subsequent motivation to engage in more costly actions — was documented in a 2011 study by Kirk Kristofferson and colleagues. The finding that online petition signing predicted lower rates of subsequent in-person volunteering, compared to direct asking without the online option, has been replicated in several subsequent studies. The implication is not that online activism is worthless but that it is most valuable as an entry point to deeper engagement rather than as a substitute for it.

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V. News: A Managed Diet

The news is not the world. This sounds obvious. It does not, in the experience of the daily news consumer, feel obvious, because the news presents itself as the world — as the full account of what is happening, filtered for significance by journalistic judgement and delivered with an authority that suggests comprehensiveness.

The news is, in fact, a selection. Made by editors with specific values, commercial interests, audience models, and time constraints. Filtered through the particular structure of what is considered newsworthy — the dramatic, the novel, the conflict, the failure — which systematically excludes the slow-moving, the gradual, the successful, and the ordinary. Amplified through the algorithmic environment that, as we have established, rewards emotional arousal over accuracy and conflict over consensus.

The news, consumed at the rate that the contemporary media environment delivers it, produces in most people a persistent, low-grade sense that everything is getting worse. This is partly because some things are getting worse, and it is the news's legitimate function to report them. But it is also partly because the selection mechanism of the news is biased toward the bad in ways that systematically understate the good

— the diseases that have been eradicated, the poverty rates that have fallen, the violent crime statistics that, in most of the developed world, have declined substantially since the nineties — because these stories are harder to tell dramatically and less emotionally engaging than their counterparts.[10]

The news is also not, in the main, action-producing. The person who consumes forty items of bad news about the state of the world in the course of a day is not, in most cases, better positioned to respond usefully to any of them than the person who consumed ten. They are more informed, in the narrow sense of having encountered more data, and more distressed, in the broad sense of having absorbed more alarm. Whether this represents an improvement is a question worth asking.

The news fast — a defined period of complete news abstention — is a practice that has been studied in enough contexts to have consistent findings: most people who attempt it report, after an initial period of anxiety about what they might be missing, a significant reduction in ambient stress and a notable absence of any important development that they needed to know about for their daily life. This is not an argument for permanent news abstention — an informed citizenry requires some level of civic engagement with current affairs — but it is an argument for a managed and intentional relationship with the news, in which you decide how much and what kind of news you consume, rather than allowing the algorithm to decide for you.

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[10] The psychologist Steven Pinker's The Better Angels of Our Nature (2011) and Enlightenment Now (2018) made this argument systematically, documenting long-term trends in violence, poverty, disease, and life expectancy that the daily news cycle routinely fails to convey. His work has been criticised on various methodological and political grounds, and the criticisms deserve engagement. The core finding — that the news is structurally biased toward the bad in ways that produce a systematically distorted picture of aggregate human progress — is, however, not seriously disputed.

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VI. Gender and Online Political Life

The experience of political engagement online differs significantly by gender, and the differences are significant enough to warrant their own section.

Women in online political spaces are subject to a specific and well-documented form of hostility: coordinated harassment, threats, the sexualisation of disagreement, the targeted attacks on credibility that are designed not to win arguments but to drive the target out of the conversation. The research on this is consistent: women who express political opinions online — particularly women of colour, women in positions of public visibility, and women who engage with topics that intersect with gender — are significantly more likely to experience harassment than men who express equivalent views, and the harassment they experience is more likely to be sexual and more likely to involve threats of physical harm.[11]

The consequence is real and measurable: women's public political participation online is reduced by harassment, through the rational process of calculating that the personal cost of expression exceeds the civic value of the expression. This is a democratic problem. The systematic silencing of a significant

portion of the population through coordinated hostility is not a minor inconvenience. It is the suppression of political voices, achieved through the infrastructure of platforms that have, with varying degrees of effort and success, attempted to address it.

Men's online political experience is shaped by different pressures. The culture of online political debate — particularly on the more adversarial platforms — rewards the confident assertion, the devastating rebuttal, the performance of certainty. These rewards tend to produce, in the men who internalise them, a political communication style that is more comfortable with conflict and less comfortable with nuance than is actually useful for civic life. The online male political voice, at its worst, is the voice that has learned to be heard by being loud and has confused volume with persuasiveness.

The online political space is, for those whose gender identity does not fit the binary, additionally hostile in specific ways that are both more personal than policy disagreement and more persistent. The person whose existence is treated as a political position to be debated — whose identity is a subject of public controversy rather than a fact about themselves — is navigating a political environment that is not merely inhospitable but actively denying the premise of their participation.[12]

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[11] The most comprehensive UK data on online gendered harassment is from Amnesty International's Toxic Twitter (2018) report, which analysed 228,000 tweets sent to women politicians and journalists in the UK and US and found that black women were fifty-four percent more likely to receive abusive tweets than white women. The pattern has been documented subsequently by researchers including Wired, the Guardian, and the Online Safety Institute. The platforms' responses have improved the situation somewhat; the situation has not been resolved.

[12] The political scientist Paisley Currah, in his work on the politics of transgender recognition, argues that the treatment of trans existence as a political debate rather than a social fact is itself a form of political power — that deciding what is open for debate and what is not is one of the primary mechanisms through which political inclusion and exclusion are maintained. Whatever one's views on the specific policy debates, the observation that the people whose existence is being debated experience the debate differently from those who are debating it is accurate and worth holding.

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VII. Meaningful Civic Life

If the argument of this chapter is taken seriously — that the current civic environment is producing more anxiety than action, more polarisation than dialogue, more performance than engagement — the question is what, practically, a person of ordinary goodwill and limited time can do that is more useful than either consuming the news until they are distressed or disengaging until they feel guilty.

The answer, which will disappoint anyone hoping for a novel solution, is the same answer it has always been: show up, locally, for things that matter to you, consistently.

This is not glamorous. It is not shareable. It will not go viral. It requires the tolerance for slow processes, for the frustration of bureaucracy, for the experience of caring about something and watching it move with the urgency of a glacier. It requires showing up in rooms where not everyone agrees with you, listening to

people who see things differently, and finding — in the difficult, inefficient, sometimes infuriating process of local civic life — the actual texture of what democracy is: not the performance of political identity online, but the negotiation of shared life among people who did not choose each other.

The forms this takes are various. Volunteering with an organisation that is doing work you believe in — not posting about it, doing it. Attending the local council meeting, the planning committee, the school board. Canvassing, campaigning, the actual unglamorous work of political organisation. Knowing your neighbours well enough to have a real conversation about what is happening in the street, the block, the estate. Participating in the institutions — the community garden, the food bank, the local sports club — that constitute, in aggregate, the social fabric that politics ultimately exists to serve.

These things are less exciting than a viral hashtag. They are also considerably more effective, over time, in the actual domain in which civic life operates: the local, the specific, the real.

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VIII. The Values Compass

One of the more useful tools for navigating the civic environment of 2026 is what we are calling here the values compass: a clear, privately held understanding of what you actually believe — not what your social circle believes, not what your algorithm has been serving you, not what the party platform says — and why.

This sounds simple. It is not, in an environment that has made the performance of political identity so readily available and so socially rewarding that the distinction between what you believe and what you perform having believed can become genuinely difficult to maintain.

The values compass is developed through the practice of taking a political position and asking: why do I believe this? What evidence supports it? What evidence might challenge it? Who benefits from me believing this, and is that the same as who should benefit from the policy? These are not comfortable questions. They are the questions that the outrage economy is specifically designed to prevent you from asking, because the person asking them is a less reliable engagement source than the person who has already decided.

The values compass is also personal rather than tribal. It may lead you, on some questions, to positions that do not align with the political community you otherwise belong to. This is not a crisis. It is evidence that your values are genuinely yours rather than borrowed.

The relationship between personal values and civic action is the through-line of meaningful political engagement: the cause that fits your actual values, pursued through actual engagement with the actual world, is more sustaining and more effective than the cause that fits the current cultural moment, pursued through the performance of engagement online. The latter is available now. The former is available for the duration of a life, and the duration of a life is what civic change actually requires.

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Navigation: The Tools for This Chapter

Psychologically: Media literacy — the capacity to evaluate sources, identify motivated reasoning, recognise emotional manipulation, and distinguish between what is known and what is inferred — is the primary psychological tool for navigating the civic environment of 2026. It is a skill, not a disposition, and it is learnable. The basic practice: before sharing anything political, ask three questions. Who made this? What do they want me to feel? What am I not being told? These questions do not produce certainty, but they produce the gap between reception and reaction in which critical thought is possible.

News boundaries are the second tool: a defined and limited relationship with the news, in which you consume a specific quantity at specific times rather than continuously. The decision about how much is yours. The decision that it should be defined is not optional, if you want to avoid the ambient distress that continuous consumption produces. One session per day, of specified duration, is a reasonable starting point. The morning is usually worse than the evening, because the day's events have had less time to be understood.

Physically: Civic engagement is a physical act before it is a digital one. The walk to the polling station. The drive to the food bank. The presence in the room where the decision is being made. The handshake with the person whose vote you are asking for. These physical acts are the substrate of democratic life, and they are not replicable by their digital equivalents — not because the digital versions are without value, but because the physical version creates something the digital version cannot: the experience of being in the same space as the people you are in civic relationship with, which is the experience that makes the relationship real.

Find one physical civic act per month. One meeting attended. One hour volunteered. One conversation with a neighbour about something that affects both of you. One letter written rather than a tweet posted. The cumulative effect of these small, physical, local acts is the thing that politics is actually made of.

Spiritually: The question of what you owe to people you will never meet — to the people in the news, to future generations, to the vast majority of humanity whose lives your political choices affect without your ever knowing them — is a spiritual question as much as a political one. Every contemplative tradition has a version of the answer, and most of them converge: that the individual self is embedded in a web of relationship that extends far beyond the visible, and that the recognition of this embeddedness is both the basis of ethics and the antidote to the tribal narrowing that the current political environment rewards.

The spiritual practice most relevant to civic life is perhaps the simplest: the regular, deliberate practice of considering other people's perspectives with genuine curiosity rather than strategic intent. Not to change your mind, necessarily — though that is always possible — but to know what the world looks like from a position other than your own. The person who can do this, consistently and without contempt, is the person who is most useful in the civic environment of 2026. Not the loudest. Not the most certain. The most genuinely curious about the human beings on the other side of the divide.

They are, it turns out, more various, more reasonable, and more like you than the algorithm has been suggesting.

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Next: Chapter Eleven — What Changed This Year: A 2026 Snapshot

In which we pause the analysis to observe the specific landmarks of the current moment — the particular developments, discoveries, and disasters that distinguish 2026 from 2025, and that will distinguish 2027 from 2026, in the continuing process of working out what is happening now.

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Chapter Eleven: What Changed This Year — A 2026 Snapshot

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Every year this book is published, this chapter will be different. Everything else — the three-lens framework, the Navigation Map, the analysis of the digital condition, the gender perspectives, the tools — these are the bones. This chapter is the weather. And the weather, in 2026, has been instructive.

This is the inaugural edition, which means this chapter has the unusual task of establishing what the baseline looks like before there is anything to measure it against. Future editions will open with this chapter, because returning readers will come first to the current moment before returning to the deeper analysis. New readers will find it here, at the end, because they will need the deeper analysis to make sense of the snapshot.

The following is not a comprehensive account of 2025 and early 2026. It is a selective one — filtered for the developments that are most relevant to the concerns of this book: the psychological, physical, and spiritual navigation of daily life. Political events are included where they bear directly on these concerns, not as political commentary.

With that noted: here is where we are.

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I. The AI Transition: From Novelty to Infrastructure

Twelve months ago, artificial intelligence was still, for most people, a novelty — something encountered in specific contexts, interesting enough to discuss at dinner, not yet woven into the ordinary fabric of daily life. That has changed, and changed faster than most of the people making predictions had predicted, which is itself worth noting as a data point about our collective capacity to anticipate the rate of technological change.[1]

In 2026, AI is infrastructure. It is inside the word processor you used to write the document you sent this morning. It is answering the customer service query you made last week, with a fluency that made you briefly unsure whether you were speaking to a person. It is reading the chest X-ray in the hospital three miles from where you live, flagging an anomaly that the radiologist will then assess. It is writing the first draft of the legal brief, the marketing email, the primary school lesson plan.

For most people, most of the time, this is invisibly good. The word processor that suggests a clearer sentence. The navigation app that finds the route. The algorithm that catches the fraudulent transaction. The AI is present and useful and largely uncontroversial when it is doing these things.

The controversy lives at the edges, and the edges are expanding.

Employment. The jobs most significantly affected by AI in the last twelve months have been, broadly: entry-level knowledge work (the writing, analysis, and research tasks that previously provided the training ground for professional careers), customer service and administrative roles (substantially automated in the

insurance, banking, and retail sectors), and creative work at the commercial end (the stock image, the marketing copy, the web design brief that previously sustained a class of freelance creative workers). The skills of the generation now entering the labour market are being devalued before they have been fully developed, which is a particular kind of economic disruption with psychological consequences that the jobs statistics do not capture.[2]

Relationship and companionship. The AI companion market — already substantial at the start of 2025 — has expanded significantly, with several new entrants offering relationships of increasing sophistication and emotional granularity. The regulatory response has been uneven: some jurisdictions have moved to restrict companion AI marketed to minors, while the adult market remains largely unregulated. The research on the psychological effects of sustained AI companionship is beginning to accumulate, and its findings are mixed enough to resist simple summary — genuinely helpful for some populations in some circumstances, genuinely concerning for others. This is likely to be one of the defining questions of the next edition.

Truth and evidence. The capacity to generate convincing synthetic media — images, video, voice — has become accessible to ordinary users with ordinary devices and ordinary levels of technical skill. The deepfake that required a professional team in 2020 requires an afternoon in 2026. The epistemic consequences are real and visible: the percentage of people who report being uncertain whether a piece of media they encountered was real or generated has increased significantly across all age groups.[3] We are in the early stages of a crisis of evidence — a situation in which the link between what can be shown and what is true has been weakened in ways that the legal, journalistic, and social systems that depend on evidence are not yet adequately adapted to.

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[1] The AI forecasting record is, on examination, characterised primarily by consistent underestimation of near-term capability gains. The experts who predicted, in 2020, that large language models could not achieve the capabilities demonstrated by GPT-4 in 2023 were wrong. The experts who predicted, in 2023, that the next major capability threshold was five years away were, in most cases, wrong. The reasons for consistent underestimation are themselves interesting — technical, psychological, and institutional — and are examined in depth in the work of AI researcher Katja Grace and colleagues. The practical implication: predictions about AI should be held lightly.

[2] The World Economic Forum's Future of Jobs Report 2025 estimated that approximately eighty-three million jobs globally would be displaced by automation between 2023 and 2027, while ninety-seven million new roles would emerge. The net figure is positive. The transition figure — the disruption experienced by the eighty-three million during the gap — is the number that the aggregate data does not adequately represent.

[3] The Reuters Institute's Digital News Report 2025 found that sixty-one percent of respondents in the UK were worried about their ability to distinguish between real and fake online content — an increase of twelve percentage points from the previous year. Comparable increases were recorded across all surveyed countries.

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II. The Mental Health Data

The mental health statistics of 2025 and early 2026 are, depending on how you read them, either evidence of genuine crisis or evidence that the measurement and help-seeking systems are improving enough to capture what was always there. Both interpretations are probably partly true, which makes neither fully satisfying.

What is clear: NHS mental health services in England received a record number of referrals in 2025, with the greatest increases in the adolescent and young adult cohorts. Waiting times for a first appointment with a mental health professional remain, for the majority of referrals, above the clinically recommended thresholds. The gap between need and provision is not closing.

What is also clear: the rollout of digital mental health tools — apps, AI-assisted CBT programmes, online therapy platforms — has increased access for people who could not or would not access traditional services, and the outcomes data for these tools, while modest, is positive enough to represent genuine marginal benefit. The technology is not a substitute for adequate provision. It is, for a significant number of people, better than what they were accessing before.

The teenage mental health picture has not improved. The data that was visible in 2022 and 2023 — the steep rise in anxiety, depression, and self-harm presentations among adolescent girls, the less visible but real rise in isolation and help-seeking among adolescent boys — has continued in the same direction. The Online Safety Act's provisions, which came into fuller effect in 2024, have produced some reduction in the most harmful content reaching minors on major platforms, and no measurable improvement in the mental health outcomes that content was associated with. The relationship between the specific content and the broader structural dynamics of the social media environment is sufficiently complex that removing the most harmful content may be insufficient without addressing the underlying architecture.[4]

The most interesting mental health development of the last twelve months is not clinical. It is cultural: the gradual, halting, imperfect emergence of a more honest public conversation about male mental health, driven partly by high-profile disclosures from men in public life, partly by the work of organisations like Movember and CALM, and partly by the simple demographic reality that the male suicide rate — approximately three times the female rate — has become too visible to continue not discussing. The conversation is early and is not uniformly helpful — some of what passes as engagement with male mental health online is barely distinguishable from the toxic masculinity it claims to counter — but the direction is, on balance, positive.

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[4] The Children's Commissioner published an assessment of the Online Safety Act's early effects in early 2026, finding measurable reductions in child exposure to the specific categories of illegal content targeted by the legislation, alongside limited evidence of impact on the broader social dynamics — the comparison culture, the social hierarchy mediation, the dopaminergic architecture — that the research links to mental health outcomes. The conclusion, which the report states with some care, is that the content-focused approach of the legislation may be necessary but insufficient.

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III. The Body Politic: What Is Happening in Civic Life

The political landscape of 2025 and early 2026 has been, in most developed democracies, characterised by three broad features that are relevant to the concerns of this book.

Institutional trust continues to decline. The percentage of people in the UK who report trusting the government, the media, and major institutions has reached, in the most recent Edelman Trust Barometer, historic lows. This is not unique to Britain: the trend is consistent across most high-income democracies and has been moving in the same direction since at least the 2008 financial crisis.[5] The practical consequence is not primarily political — though it is that — but psychological: the person who trusts no institution has no collective resource to fall back on in difficulty, which increases the burden on individual and family resilience in ways that individual and family resilience was not designed to carry alone.

Local civic engagement is increasing. Quietly, with little national media attention, local civic participation in many parts of the UK has increased over the last two years. Food banks and community larders have expanded their volunteer base. Community energy projects, local repair cafés, neighbourhood mutual aid networks that formed during the pandemic and were not expected to survive its end — these have, in many cases, not only survived but grown. The story of declining civic engagement at the national level is real. The story of growing civic engagement at the local level is also real, and considerably less reported.[6]

The information environment has deteriorated further. The proliferation of AI-generated content, the continued fragmentation of the media landscape, and the increasing sophistication of coordinated inauthentic behaviour on social platforms have made the assessment of basic factual claims more difficult than it was twelve months ago. This is not a problem that any individual can solve. It is a collective problem that requires collective responses — regulatory, technical, and cultural. The individual response is the media literacy toolkit described in Chapter Ten, maintained with the awareness that the environment against which it is deployed is more challenging than it was at the last assessment.

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[5] The Edelman Trust Barometer 2026, published in January, found that only thirty-three percent of UK respondents trusted the government, and forty-one percent trusted the media — both figures at or near historic lows for the survey. The figures for NGOs (fifty-six percent) and business (fifty-three percent) were higher, which is itself an interesting datum about where institutional credibility currently resides.

[6] The figures on local civic participation are less systematically gathered than national political data, which is one of the reasons the story is less often told. The National Council for Voluntary Organisations (NCVO) publishes an annual almanac of volunteering data that captures some of this, as does the Community Life Survey. The direction of both is consistent with the anecdotal evidence: local volunteering has grown while national political engagement has declined.

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IV. The Body in 2026: Physical Health Developments

Two physical health developments of the last twelve months are significant enough to require specific mention in the context of this book.

GLP-1 medications and the obesity question. The class of drugs known as GLP-1 receptor agonists — semaglutide and its successors, marketed as Ozempic, Wegovy, and various others — have moved, over the last two years, from specialist obesity treatment to mainstream cultural phenomenon. Their effectiveness at producing sustained weight loss is not in dispute: the clinical data is robust, and for a significant proportion of users, the outcomes represent genuine health improvements. What is in dispute — and what has not yet been resolved by the evidence available — is the relationship between these medications and the psychological relationship to eating, appetite, and the body that we discussed in Chapter Six.[7]

The concern is not primarily that the medications are harmful — for many users in specific clinical circumstances, they are genuinely beneficial. The concern is that the cultural enthusiasm for them risks reinforcing, rather than addressing, the relationship to the body that produces the problem. If the body that fails to manage its weight is a body that can be pharmaceutically corrected, the question of why so many bodies are struggling — the engineered food environment, the sedentary lifestyle, the stress and sleep deprivation — may receive less attention than it deserves. The medication treats the symptom. The environment that produced the symptom continues.

Sleep technology. The market for sleep-monitoring technology has expanded significantly, and the data that consumers now have access to — via wearables, smart mattresses, and various monitoring devices — has produced, in many users, a paradoxical relationship to sleep. The person who checks their sleep score upon waking, and finds it low, begins the day with the information that they slept badly, which produces anxiety, which impairs the day's function, which makes the next night's sleep harder — a cycle that researchers have named orthosomnia: the anxiety about sleep quality produced by monitoring sleep quality.[8] The irony of sleep technology making sleep harder, by providing the information required to worry about sleep, is elegant enough to deserve a footnote in a future edition.

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[7] The GLP-1 literature is expanding rapidly. For a balanced overview of the clinical data and the outstanding questions, the BMJ's coverage is more reliable than the mainstream press, which has tended toward either uncritical enthusiasm or headline-seeking alarm. The psychological research on GLP-1 medications and their effects on the reward system, appetite psychology, and body image is still in early stages.

[8] The term orthosomnia was coined by researchers at Rush University Medical Center in a 2017 paper in the Journal of Clinical Sleep Medicine, in which they described patients whose anxiety about sleep data was itself impairing sleep. The phenomenon has become more common as sleep-tracking technology has proliferated. The recommendation — to use sleep data as one source of information among several rather than as an authoritative verdict — is simple and frequently difficult to follow for the person who has paid several hundred pounds for the authoritative verdict.

✦

V. What to Watch: Questions for the 2027 Edition

Every annual edition of this book ends with a brief list of the questions that the current year has opened but not answered — the developments that are in motion, the situations that are unresolved, the research that is underway and whose findings will shape the next snapshot.

For 2027, the questions are:

On AI and society: How will the labour market absorb — or fail to absorb — the displacement of entry-level knowledge work? What will the regulatory frameworks for AI companionship look like, and will they be adequate? What will the first generation of children raised with AI tutors, AI companions, and AI-mediated social environments look like at twenty-five?

On mental health: Will the adolescent mental health crisis continue to worsen, or are the interventions currently being piloted — the delayed school start times, the phone-free school policies, the enhanced CAMHS provision — sufficient to begin reversing the trend? What will the longitudinal data on heavy social media use from ages twelve to twenty-five show, when that cohort is old enough to be studied?

On civic life: Will the local civic engagement trend continue and expand, or is it a temporary response to national political dysfunction that will recede if national politics improves? What will the information environment look like when AI-generated content is ubiquitous enough that its presence is assumed rather than suspected?

On the body: What will the long-term data on GLP-1 medication use show, at five and ten years? Will the cultural enthusiasm survive the longitudinal data, or will it be qualified by findings that are not yet visible?

These are not rhetorical questions. They are the questions this series will track — checking back, annually, on what was unknown in 2026 and has since become clearer, and on what was unknown in 2026 and has since become more complicated.

The map is updated. The territory continues.

✦

A Note on Reading This Chapter in Future Years

Readers of the 2027 and subsequent editions will find this chapter replaced by a chapter covering the twelve months preceding publication. The chapter you have just read will be archived in the series record but will not be reprinted in subsequent editions.

What will remain constant across editions:

The three-lens framework. The Navigation Map. The gender dual-perspective. The tone. The commitment to honest diagnosis over comfort. The footnotes.

What will change:

The specific developments, the current research, the named crises and emerging questions. Each edition is a new map of the same territory — the territory of being alive in a rapidly changing world and trying to navigate it without either drowning in information or retreating from engagement.

The 2026 edition has done what it set out to do: established the baseline, named the structure, and provided a set of tools for the reader who is trying to live well in circumstances that are, on the evidence, genuinely challenging.

The 2027 edition will do it again, updated and revised and carrying forward whatever the intervening year has taught us.

This is the work. It does not end. Neither, fortunately, does the capacity to do it.

✦

Final: Conclusion — The Navigation Map: Forward

In which we gather the tools, acknowledge the difficulty, and send the reader back into the world with something more useful than certainty — which is, at this point in human history, not on offer — and something better than despair, which is not warranted.

✦

Conclusion: The Navigation Map — Forward

✦

You have now spent a considerable amount of time in the company of a book that has, among other things, told you that the phone is affecting your attention, that social media is affecting your mood, that the food environment is engineered against your appetite system, that the information environment is designed to make you anxious, that work has lost its edges, that love has been complicated by abundance, that civic life is in difficulty, and that death is being avoided with insufficient success.

This is, you may feel, a lot.

It is worth pausing, before we close, to note what the book has also said — which is somewhat different from what it is easy to remember, because the brain, as we have established, has a negativity bias that makes the diagnostic sections easier to retain than the navigational ones.

So: what the book has also said.

That the capacity for genuine connection has not disappeared. It has been complicated, and the complications are real, but the human need for mutual knowledge — for being seen accurately by another person, and for seeing them in return — is as present and as powerful as it has ever been, and it is being met, imperfectly and beautifully, in the margins of the digital world by the same ordinary acts it was always met by.

That the body, beleaguered as it is, is fundamentally on your side. It is trying, with considerable ingenuity, to maintain itself in conditions it was not designed for. It responds to almost everything you might do for it — the sleep, the movement, the food, the outdoor air — with disproportionate gratitude, in the sense that small consistent investments in the body's basic needs produce returns that exceed the investment by a significant margin.

That the mind, trained as it has been by the attentional economy toward fragmentation and distraction, retains the capacity for depth. The same brain that has learned to check the phone eighty times per day is the brain that can learn, with practice and patience, to sit with a difficult problem long enough for something interesting to happen. The capacity is there. It has been underused, not destroyed.

That meaning — the experience of one's life as mattering — is not a product of circumstances but of orientation. It is found in the practice of paying attention, in the decision to be present to the people and the world in front of you, in the willingness to do something that matters beyond yourself, and in the honest confrontation with the fact that your life is finite, which gives it weight. None of these require exceptional conditions. They require, primarily, the decision to begin.

✦

The Tools, Assembled

Across the ten chapters that precede this conclusion, we have accumulated a Navigation Map — a set of tools, organised across three domains, that the evidence and the accumulated wisdom of the contemplative traditions suggest are most useful for navigating the conditions of 2026.

Here they are, assembled.

✦

Psychological Tools

Name what you are feeling. The emotion that can be identified — located, attributed, understood as a signal rather than a verdict — is considerably more manageable than the emotion that is simply present. Anxiety about the news is different from anxiety about your relationship, which is different from the ambient unease of the dopamine loop. They require different responses. Naming them is the first step toward choosing the response rather than being chosen by it.

Examine the story. The mind generates narratives about experience continuously — stories about who you are, what others think of you, what the future holds, whether the current difficulty is temporary or permanent. These stories feel like facts. They are not facts. They are interpretations, and interpretations can be examined, challenged, and revised. The question to bring to the story the mind is telling: is this the only available story? Is this the most accurate story? What would a reasonable, well-disposed person who knew all the facts make of this situation?

Set boundaries as maintenance. Mental energy is finite. The demands placed on it in 2026 routinely exceed sustainable supply. The regular refusal of some demands — the additional commitment, the after-hours message, the obligation accepted because the discomfort of declining felt worse than the cost of accepting — is not selfishness. It is the maintenance of the capacity for everything else. Learn to say no to the things that are not yours to carry, so that you can say yes to the things that are.

Cultivate frustration tolerance. The discomfort of not knowing, of waiting, of being unable to immediately resolve something, is temporary. It passes. The practice of sitting with small discomforts long enough to discover that they pass builds a capacity that the instant-gratification environment is steadily eroding. Hold the question before you Google it. Stay with the difficult passage before you put the book down. Complete the conversation before you reach for the phone. Small acts. Real accumulation.

Find the values compass. Know what you actually believe, and why, separately from what the algorithm has been serving you and what your social circle rewards you for performing. The values that are genuinely yours — tested, examined, held against evidence — are more durable than the values you have borrowed, and they are the ones that will carry you through the periods when the borrowed ones no longer fit.

✦

Physical Tools

Sleep. Phone out of the bedroom. Consistent timing. The hour before bed low-stimulation. This is the single most evidence-backed intervention available, and it costs nothing except the willingness to do it. Everything else in this list is harder when you are not adequately rested. Sleep is not a luxury. It is the foundation.

Walk. Thirty minutes, outside, most days. Not as a performance of fitness. As the minimum viable dose of the movement your body was designed for and is currently not getting. Bring nothing to listen to, or bring something worth listening to, but at some point on the walk put the phone in your pocket and look at what is actually there. The walk outside is not the same as the walk on a treadmill. Both are better than not walking. The outside one is better.

Eat at a table. One meal per day, without a screen, with some attention to what you are eating and whether you are still hungry. The satiety signals require attention to register, and attention directed at a screen is not attending to the body. One meal. The habit tends to expand.

Move the body through the day. Stand up once an hour. Look at something in the distance for twenty seconds. Take three deliberate breaths. Adjust the position of your work so that it does not require you to hold your neck in a position that is causing structural damage over time. These are ninety-second interventions. They are not ninety-second cures. They are the minimum maintenance that a body spending eight hours per day at a screen is entitled to expect.

Go outside for its own sake. Not to exercise, not to commute, not to get somewhere. Outside, in a natural environment, slowly, for long enough that the mind exhausts its initial inventory of preoccupations and arrives at something quieter. Twice a week, at minimum. The evidence for the restorative effects of natural environments on the attentional system and the stress response is robust enough to constitute a clinical recommendation. It is also, remarkably, free.

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Spiritual Tools

Daily practice. Something small, done every day, before the phone. Five minutes of sitting. A few lines in a journal. A slow cup of tea at the window, attended to. The practice does not need to be large. It needs to be consistent, and it needs to be not-the-phone. The day that begins with something other than a screen begins differently. The accumulation of days that begin differently is a life that is oriented differently, and the orientation is what matters.

Cultivate awe. Go to the places that make you feel small in the good way. The mountain, the ocean, the old cathedral, the concert in which the music is doing something that transcends the notes. These experiences are not luxuries. They are the recalibration that the ego-focused, achievement-oriented, notification-saturated self requires to maintain any kind of accurate sense of proportion. Seek them. Schedule them if necessary. The self that has recently been reminded of its own smallness in the vastness of things is the self that is most capable of generosity, of patience, of the wide view.

Maintain ritual. The shared meal. The seasonal celebration. The annual tradition. The small, repeated act that marks time as significant and belonging as real. Let the teenagers roll their eyes. Keep the rituals. The rituals are the architecture of meaning-in-time, and without them time becomes a sequence of indistinguishable units that the algorithm is very happy to fill.

Sit with the question. Not every question requires an answer. The questions that are most important — what am I for? what do I owe to others? what will this look like when I am dying? — are not answerable in the sense that a Google search is answerable. They are liveable. The person who inhabits these questions regularly, who lets them inform their choices and their priorities and their relationship to the time they have, is the person who is navigating most honestly. The answers are not the point. The orientation is.

Practise dying. Not morbidly. In the Stoic sense: hold the awareness, briefly and regularly, that your life is finite. That this day is one of a number that is not unlimited. That the people you love will not always be there, and nor will you. This awareness, which the digital environment is extraordinarily effective at preventing you from maintaining, is the most reliable available antidote to the spending of significant quantities of your finite time on things that, on examination, do not matter to you.

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What This Is Not

This book is not a promise. It has not suggested that if you follow the Navigation Map you will be happy, or that happiness, even if achieved, is the right measure of a life well lived.

It has not suggested that the structural problems we have described — the designed-for-addiction architecture of the attention economy, the economic conditions that have made financial security unavailable to a generation, the political environment that is making shared reality harder to maintain — are yours to solve individually. They are not. They require collective responses of the kind that individual self-improvement, however sincere and sustained, cannot substitute for.

It has not suggested that the contemplative traditions have all the answers, or that the psychological research does, or that any framework offered here is complete. Completeness, in a domain this complex, is not available. What is available is the map that is most useful given current knowledge, offered by a voice that has tried to be honest about its own limitations.

What it has suggested — consistently, across every chapter, in every domain — is that the quality of your attention is the primary lever available to you. Where you put your attention, and for how long, and with what quality of presence, is the variable that most determines the quality of your experience of being alive. Not the circumstances — circumstances change, often without your agency. The attention. The choice, made repeatedly and against the resistance of an environment designed to make the choice difficult, to attend to what actually matters rather than to what the algorithm has decided is most engaging.

This choice is ordinary. It is not heroic. It does not require extraordinary conditions or exceptional willpower or the permanent abolition of the phone from your life. It requires, primarily, practice — the repeated small decision to return, again, to the thing that matters, when the pull of the thing that is merely stimulating has done its work and you have noticed that you are somewhere else.

You will notice. You will return. That is the practice.

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A Word About Next Year

In 2027, this book will return. It will carry forward the three-lens framework, the Navigation Map, the gender dual-perspective, and the tools assembled above. It will open with the annual chapter — the weather report for the year just passed — and then move through the same domains, updated where the research has changed, revised where the analysis has been improved by intervening events, and honest about what was wrong in 2026 that can now be corrected.

The series is predicated on the belief that navigation is ongoing. That the terrain keeps changing, and the map must keep changing with it. That the person who read the 2026 edition and returns for 2027 is not returning because they did not understand the 2026 edition — but because they understood it well enough to know that understanding is not a destination.

We are not, any of us, finished with the question of how to live in this particular moment. The moment keeps moving. The question keeps moving with it.

The book will too.

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The Last Thing

There is a practice in certain contemplative traditions of closing a teaching with something simple — not a summary, not a final insight, not the clinching argument, but a gesture toward what is always already available when the words run out.

Sri Das, who is a careful observer rather than a sage, does not have a tradition. But there is something that wants to be said at the end of this particular exercise — this long, earnest, occasionally funny attempt to map the conditions of life in 2026 and suggest some tools for navigating them.

It is this.

The world is difficult and strange and moving very fast and full of people who are, mostly, doing their best in conditions that are harder than they look from the outside. The digital environment has made some of the difficulty worse and some of it better and has not yet reached a stable configuration in which we can assess the net. The political environment is concerning. The economic environment is, for a significant portion of the population, genuinely hard. The mental health data is not reassuring.

And yet.

The tree in the street is still a tree. The child who has just learned to walk is still luminous with the effort of it. The person who laughed at something genuinely funny today — a joke that required intelligence to make and intelligence to receive, that landed in the precise space between understanding and surprise — is still having that experience, and it is still the thing it has always been. The conversation that went somewhere unexpected. The book that changed something. The moment on a hillside when the light did something extraordinary and you noticed it because, for once, you were looking.

These are not small things. In fact — measured against everything that is not them — they are exactly the right size.

Navigate well.

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— Sri Das, 2026

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What Is Happening Now: How to Navigate It is published annually. The 2027 edition will be available in early 2027. Readers wishing to contribute observations, corrections, or experiences from navigating the terrain described in this edition are invited to do so through the publisher.

For resources on any of the topics covered in this book — mental health support, civic engagement, parenting guidance, and contemplative practice — please refer to the Resources section at the back of this volume.

Bibliography and Further Reading

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Readers wishing to verify, challenge, or extend any argument in this book are strongly encouraged to consult the primary sources directly. The author's interpretations are his own, and are not endorsed by the researchers cited.

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